

**On the Religious  
in  
its Unity with the Human**

A Positive Supplement to  
“The Problem of Faith and Knowledge”

*Om det Religiøse i dets Enhed med det Humane*

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Translated from the Danish

Copenhagen: P. G. Philipsen, 1869



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# [Introduction]

The present work, whose publication has been delayed by circumstances independent of the author's will, attaches itself most closely to the historical-critical treatise: *Problemet om Tro og Viden*, in which reference is made to it in several places, and reproduces, like that treatise, in all essentials unchanged, the content of a university lecture course. It forms the positive supplement to that treatise, whose result, from the nature of the case, had essentially to be negative; and taking its starting point from this negative, it seeks, presupposing the developments by which that result was established, the definitive determination of faith's relation to knowledge.

The result, of a negative kind, to which all the developments given in the earlier work (in the "preliminary determinations of concepts", in the critique of theology's standpoint and of the attempt to bring about a reconciliation by a distinction of principle) have led, may be summed up in the following points:

1. Between faith in the sense of positive religion, i.e. faith as "faith in revelation", and knowledge there arises — whether the standpoint be taken in the positively religious or in science — in virtue of their different content and their different source, an unabolishable incongruence, an irreconcilable opposition.
2. It therefore becomes impossible that faith (in the sense indicated) and knowledge should be united without discord in the same consciousness, should preserve their validity for the same personality.

This negative result now converts itself immediately into a positive one differing from it only formally. If the opposites are irreconcilable in consciousness, then it becomes a necessity that a *choice* be made between these opposites, of which one must be the expression of the human spirit's highest energy, must enclose within itself the goal of its highest striving.

This choice, whose necessity under that presupposition is not to be evaded, is then, with respect to its character, to be formally determined thus: that in accordance with the

demand which lies in the unity of the human being and of human self-consciousness, it must be such a choice as one in which the spirit's fundamental activities are in harmony within themselves and with one another, in which therefore the being, undivided and unmutilated, is in unity with itself in its cognising and its willing.

When this determination is taken as the norm, it becomes clear what direction the choice can and must take, what can and must become the object of the choice.

For from the developments given in the earlier work it emerges that faith, as faith in the sense of the positive religions, *cannot* be chosen if the demand set up above is to be fulfilled. That it cannot be so chosen lies partly in its relation to the practical, partly in its relation to the theoretical. It cannot be chosen because, in the practical respect, it cannot become the forming principle for the wholeness of an ethical human life, cannot form human nature. For on the standpoint of positive religion the source of the ethical demand becomes the supranatural, transcendent subject of revelation, distinguished from the human being, whose will is absolute arbitrariness; and the demands of this will cannot therefore be congruent with the essential demand of the human spirit. And when positive religion has been clarified into the highest form of a religion of spirit, then its "ethical" demand requires the denial of the natural, that is, of something fundamental in the human being, of something that *must* assert itself in its essentiality. — If we look to the theoretical, then faith cannot be chosen because it cannot round itself off into a totality, because, while it cannot make itself independent of knowledge, it cannot take up into itself what is essential in knowledge, cannot see through and explain knowledge<sup>\*)</sup>. Knowledge must then, as an essential determination in human nature, inevitably assert itself as justified over against faith, and bring discord into the consciousness that was to be filled by faith. A relation of subordination on knowledge's part is excluded by the kind of the opposition and by the essence of knowledge. When faith is chosen, therefore, the being's harmony and its inner reconciliation cannot be attained.

But when the demanded goal cannot be attained through the choice of faith, then there shows itself, through what was developed in the previous work, a possibility that it can be attained through a choice of knowledge. For in that knowledge is chosen, that is chosen which, by being an expression of the universality of the human being, has the capacity to unfold itself as a totality resting in itself with an inner infinity. In that knowledge is chosen, that is chosen in which the being in its unity becomes manifest to itself, that which in the indivisible human spirit holds the ideal principate, and which therefore can become the norm for a true ethical *wholeness of life*. In that knowledge

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<sup>\*)</sup>Cf. Problemet om Tro og Viden, pp. 195; 210 f.

is chosen, there is finally chosen that which, as enclosing the cognition of the spirit's *whole* life and development of life, can see through the essence of the finite forms of religion and comprehend them in their springing from human nature in its unfolding, and therefore does not retain a disturbing barrier of consciousness within them; and which therefore also, in separating out within the historical forms of religion the transient and finite from the abiding and essential, can stand in harmony with and take up into itself this essential element, which is precisely the religious according to its true and eternal significance.

How now, from this standpoint of the necessity of a choice, and of a choice so determined, a *reconciling* solution of the problem of the relation of faith and knowledge becomes possible; how the right and validity of knowledge can be asserted without faith being violated in its truth, without the religious that is demanded by a need of the human spirit being denied — this it will be the task of the developments that follow to make clear. Their course is determined by the nature of the task. *First* it will be necessary to establish that there is present, conditioned by the unity of essence, a relation of unity between true cognition and true action, ethical action. *Thereafter* it shall be shown that the essential marks of the religious in its true and eternal sense — faith and devotion — are inseparable from true cognition and true action, and that these are therefore in harmony with the religious and bear it within themselves, so that human life, according to its harmonious unity with itself in the totality of its fundamental functions, can show itself as penetrated by the religious. And *finally* the possibility shall be shown that out of philosophy's concepts of the concretely determined Absolute — the highest determination of knowledge — and of the human being in its relation to the principle and to real existence, there can be developed a view of life that can satisfy ethically and religiously, and that there can be attained those essential determinations of the ethical and religious relation of which it has been asserted that they can be derived only from a principle of will and of faith absolutely heterogeneous with the principle of knowledge. Here, then, the central ethical-religious problems — the problems of the freedom of the will, of the possibility and actuality of ethical evil, and of reconciliation and restitution — will come up for discussion.

In connection with these developments there will at the same time be made clear the relation of the view of life indicated to those conceptions which offer real or apparent points of contact with it, and the critique of them given, partly directly, partly indirectly.

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# I.

## On the Relation of Unity between True Cognition and True Action.

The fundamental relation between cognition and will, as primitive forms of expression of the human being, has been indicated in the earlier work (pp. 134 ff.), and to the determinations there given I may at this place refer back. The conception there asserted was this: that the human being, whose indivisible unity is posited by the concept of subjectivity and impresses itself in the unity of self-consciousness, is according to its fundamental concept a selfhood-energy, and that this determination of the selfhood-energy is the pervading universal which gives itself its peculiar forms of activity in cognition and will. In these peculiar forms of expression, then, the universal determinateness of the being reveals itself; they become primitive functions of the selfhood-energy; and while their originality encloses their peculiarity and their self-validity, their relation to the universal determination of the selfhood-energy — the determination inherent in the particular — encloses this: that they are governed by the unity of the being, that they reflect one another's formal determinatenesses, and that the essential energy therefore preserves its unity in the twofold form of appearance. By the *equal* relation in which cognition and will have been shown to stand to the determination of the energy, that confusion of concepts is removed which, through an arbitrary and unclear extension of the concept *drive*, identifies drive with the energy and thereby procures for the will an illusory precedence in the human being, without being able, then, to explain the origin of cognition, or of consciousness generally; without being able to remove the confusion that "the drive" is itself to posit what the drive, in the *proper* sense of the word, strives to hold fast *or* to remove; and without being able to account for the fact that the first expression of the selfhood-energy, as unconscious organic forming, continues *after* the will has been actualised, and continues *independently* of the will. Through the critique of this one-sided and unclear conception the primitivity both of cognition and of will has been

asserted; and when the question of the ideal principate was raised, this was assigned to cognition in virtue of its relation to that fundamental determination in the human being, *essential universality*, by which the human being categorically distinguishes itself from the other stages of the development of life<sup>\*)</sup>. This ideal principate of cognition reveals itself also in *consciousness's* relation to the particular functions of spirit. As functions of the human selfhood-energy they are *accompanied by consciousness*, and are precisely thereby functions *of spirit*; but consciousness stands according to its concept in another relation to cognition and thought than, for example, to the will; it becomes the *abstract, formal*, expression of cognition, that which can be unfolded into an *appropriating cognition*, into *comprehending* thinking, into the transparency of spirit to itself in its content; and the fact that it enters into relation to the different functions of spirit, in becoming the form of their being-for-the-self, points precisely to the ideal principate of cognition, and to the possibility of a transparency of the self to itself through cognition in the self's various peculiar forms of expression<sup>\*\*)</sup>. When this fundamental point — the being's undivided unity in cognition and will, and the ideal principate of cognition — has already been won as a result in the earlier work, then at this place the *relative* opposition is to be more closely elucidated which must come forward in virtue of the peculiarity of the fundamental functions and in virtue of the conditions of the development of spirit, but through which, in virtue of the fundamental relation, harmony — the unity grounded in essence — must actualise itself as governing the opposition.

*The relative opposition* in which cognition and will come forward in their independence is to be apprehended first as an opposition *of concept*, and thereafter as an opposition *of facticity*.

*The opposition of concept* between the two primitive functions has already been indicated in "Problemet om Tro og Viden" (pp. 135 f.). It showed itself as coming forward immediately in the difference of formal determinateness; but the difference of form was seen not to constitute an abstract opposition, since the determinations which expressed it pointed to one another and developed out of one another, so that the fundamental functions reflected one another's formal determinatenesses. Thereby it became possible

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<sup>\*)</sup>Cf. Problemet om Tro og Viden, p. 137; Et Svar til Prof. Nielsen, pp. 12 f.

<sup>\*\*)</sup>With respect to the charge which a critic has brought against me of confounding what is essentially different, I remark only — what every thoughtful reader of the earlier work will surely have seen — that I do not identify the *immediate forms of consciousness* with unfolded *scientific cognition*, but maintain only that what comes forward in those forms of immediacy is partly such as can be unfolded in clear cognition, and partly a *resulting* immediate, and more precisely such a one as has resulted from a preceding *cognition*. Just as little do I confound the *subjective* with the *objective*; rather I maintain that the former, as an expression of the subject's *being*, has the same transparency for cognition, i.e. for a *theoretical* cognition, as has that immediate.

that beneath the difference of form the *essential* unity of the content can be preserved: a unity which is required by the fact that the same undivided being gives both forms their content. When thus, in the ethical resolution, the cognition of duty is converted into a willing of duty — when therefore that which as an object of cognition has the form of possibility is posited in the form of actuality in the I — then this *determinate* content is in both forms *essentially* unchanged, and must be so already for this reason, that otherwise the fulfilment of duty in the action would *not* be a fulfilment of this determinate thing cognised as duty; and in the preceding cognition the universal determination of possibility is so punctualised in relation to the existing subject, and the object of cognition so brought into relation to the cognising *being*, so seen as an essential determination which is required to be posited as a determination of reality, that the conversion into a content of will cannot abolish the essential unity of the content.

That the difference between cognition and will does not transform itself into an *abstract* opposition shows itself also indirectly when we elucidate the attempt to assert such an opposition through the opposition between the “theoretical” and the “practical consciousness”, between “theoretical” and “practical cognition” (thinking).

With respect to this theory we touch only upon what we have shown elsewhere: the lack of clarity in the application of the categories of which it makes itself guilty, in that the concepts consciousness, cognition and thinking are used indiscriminately without clear delimitation, and cognition, which relates itself to action, is confounded with the act of will itself, the resolution of the will. Disregarding this confused application of the concepts, and distinguishing what has been called practical cognition from the immediate “practical consciousness” — which is partly a consciousness of the subject’s state in the practical respect, of the subject’s resolution of will and of the motive, the factually moving, and partly a consciousness of the ethically a priori, of the practical demand — we investigate how the sought opposition between a theoretical and a practical cognition is to be determined.

It will then be immediately evident here that there cannot be two essentially distinct kinds of cognition, two absolutely heterogeneous forms of cognition, since in that case the determination of cognition would transform itself into a purely contentless name and in its duality could not be the property of the same cognising being. An opposition which springs from the ground of the same being must preserve within itself the essential unity. And therefore it is to be held fast that cognition, *as* cognition, in every form and in every application, must preserve its essential determinateness. The opposition between a “theoretical” and a “practical” cognition then becomes a merely relative opposition

between a cognition which is determined solely by the laws of thought and which has theoretical insight as its result, and a cognition which is determined also by motives of will (laws of will) and which has action, resolution, as its result.

The designation of practical cognition as determined by motives of will points partly to this cognition's presuppositions and starting points (premisses), partly to its being affected by the will in the course of its advance. Its starting points are practical incitements: partly promptings of drive, partly effects of an ethical *a priori* (grounds of conscience). From these starting points, which stand as something given, "practical" cognition then advances in the same way as the theoretical, which draws consequences from its premisses, partly from unresolved ones and partly from transparent ones. — Cognition's being affected in the course of its advance may proceed from a more clearly or a more obscurely conscious will, which either supplements incomplete premisses, or corrects one-sided theories, or hinders true cognition. In the first case the will supplies a starting point which, in order to be used, must not stand in conflict with what is theoretically cognised. The relation here forms an analogy to that in which, in theoretical reasoning, an unproved current opinion (a prejudice) is used. In the second case the will inserts a corrective which cognition acknowledges as its own, and which forms the starting point for a new inference. Here too the theoretical domain offers perfectly corresponding analogies (cf. *Problemet om Tro og Viden*, pp. 144 f.). — In the last case the relation is more complicated. During cognition's advance the will works partly by bringing forward instances that can prevent a conclusion, and partly by spacing out the unfolding of the premisses from the conclusion, the resolution, whereby the clarity of cognition can be obscured, and contradicting instances, specious grounds and pretexts can take on the appearance of validity. To this hindering there is formed, in the theoretical domain, the analogy of the working of prejudices upon cognition.

The *result* of "practical cognition" is partly the acceptance of a doctrine which relates itself to the subject's action, to its practical life, and partly an inference in the direction of action, which is converted into a resolution. If the result is the acceptance of a doctrine, then this acceptance comes forward as an inference which proceeds with necessity from its premisses; but among these premisses there may be found, according to what has been developed above, such as have been inserted by the will. If the result is resolution, as resolution to the determinate action, then the preceding act of cognition — to which the resolution in the proper sense always points back — is, like the cognition upon which the acceptance of the practical doctrine depended, and like the cognition which drew consequences from practical premisses, in its form not essentially different from

the theoretical; but this would be impossible if an absolute heterogeneity separated “practical” and “theoretical” cognition from one another. For cognition is only what it is by its form; but by form is then of course understood something other and more than the empty syllogistic form applied *externally* to an arbitrary content.

The result with respect to the cognition which relates itself to the practical is therefore this: that in virtue of its form and in virtue of its relation to the universal concept of cognition, and likewise in virtue of the relation of the practical — of the starting points and of the result — to the human *being*, it must be essentially one with the cognition designated as theoretical. All cognition is *as* cognition theoretical. That cognition can be applied in a practical direction, and in this application be affected by the will, proves nothing for an essentially distinct practical cognition; for a unity of the will with cognition comes forward *everywhere*, its reciprocal action with cognition becomes manifest in the domain of indisputably theoretical cognition as well, and theoretical cognition can *as such* become an object of the will. That the relation is of this kind will become still more evident when the *marks of character* are examined by which the alleged abstract opposition between theoretical and practical cognition is *described*: they will all show themselves as leading back from the relative difference to the essential unity.

When the opposition is first characterised thus, that the *theoretical* consciousness (cognition) is *impersonal* and the *practical* *personal*, then this opposition, as an abstract and exclusive opposition, shows itself untenable already for this reason: that theoretical cognition, as the expression of the unity of that being whose fundamental determination is personality, must not merely be an expression of personality in general, but must have for its final goal a cognition of personality in its connection with the whole of existence and in its subordination under the principle of existence. In this cognition of the personal self, the cognition of objective real existence — of that world of corporeality to which personality stands in relation through its side of reality and its conditions of reality — will then also show itself as having “personal” significance. That determination of theoretical cognition as impersonal encloses the consequence that *theoretical cognition, although a primitive expression of the self, cannot become self-cognition*, inasmuch as it finds its limit in the very self which is the source of this cognition. If, in order to maintain the assertion of theoretical cognition’s impersonal character, one were to lay the emphasis on this, that the cognition of the self too, as theoretical cognition, must remain in the form of the universal, and that therefore the personal self can through it be cognised only in an impersonal manner — then it would have to be urged against this

that the universal in such cognition is not held fast in the original form of abstraction, but is constantly more and more punctualised towards concretion, so that what remains “impersonal” in theoretical cognition would designate only what remains relative in the punctualisation of the universal; and this relative element is moreover such as is not merely abiding in theoretical cognition, but is and must be so in the resolutions of the will as well, precisely because these are conscious and are expressions of spirit, and as such are raised above that form of singularity which belongs to natural existence and to natural determination by drive.

The object of impersonal, theoretical cognition is determined as the *objectively valid*, that of personal, practical cognition as the *subjectively valid*, and an abstract opposition is made between the objectively universally valid and the subjectively universally valid. When, however, that self-contradicting limit upon theoretical cognition is removed, it shows itself to comprehend also that which, as a “subjectively valid”, was set in opposition to the objectively valid, and to comprehend not merely what, in virtue of its connection with cognised human nature, has validity in its universality for all subjects, but also what, as determined in its concretion by co-operating universal grounds, has validity for this determinate subject.

Only in virtue of this relation can there be any talk of a “subjectively universally valid”, whereas the abstract opposition between the subjective and the objective must lead to letting *individual* subjectivity as such determine the valid as it *wills* to determine it, and so to letting the subjective grounds become one with individually accidental grounds, promptings of drive and the like — to letting “grounds of will” become such as an arbitrary will makes into grounds.

If the opposition between the two kinds of cognition is then determined thus, that theoretical cognition is moved by *necessity* while practical cognition “*is grounded in freedom*” — the former, as lost in the universal, being compellingly determined by incontrovertible grounds of knowledge, the latter, as conditioned by regard for the self, resting on grounds of conscience — then this opposition too shows itself to be dialectical. Theoretical cognition is governed by necessity where the presuppositions of the inference are fully transparent, where the proof acquires stringency through clear and complete premisses. But just as fully is “practical cognition” determined with necessity where these conditions are present, where the presuppositions are given clear and complete. What produces the appearance of an abstract opposition is *the difference in concretion* between the object of practical cognition and certain spheres of the theoretical. In the domain of the concretely ethical a seemingly unabolishable

difference may persist, precisely on account of the incompleteness of the premisses, in the same way as within the theoretical, in the more concrete domains. The difference can maintain itself because the manifold presuppositions are not clarified and are therefore partially supplemented in an individual manner. Thus, under the same presuppositions, the necessity is the same. And the necessity which determines theoretical cognition is, when the cognition is *comprehending* and as such *appropriating*, an expression of *the lawfulness of the cognising being itself*, and thus converts itself into *freedom*. In the form of unfree necessity theoretical cognition comes forward only where what is given in sensation is determinative in its foreignness. But to this stage there corresponds that stage in the development of practical “cognition” where the regard for the self which determines it is regard for something obscurely drive-like, by which the will is brought under natural necessity. Only as the expression of something essential has the subject’s need, which determines that “cognition”, any warrant; but as an expression of the being this need bears at once the stamp of true necessity and of freedom, while the so-called “freedom” of determination by drive is unfree necessity, just as the necessity of sensation is. In theoretical and in practical cognition alike, therefore, *both the* determinations come forward which were to constitute the sharp opposition; the real relation becomes obscure only through this, that the individual who acts “arbitrarily” does not become conscious of being, precisely in this action, unfree.

When finally the opposition is determined in this way, that theoretical cognition is to be *disinterested*, *contemplative*, *without responsibility*, while the practical is *interested*, moved by *fear and hope*, an object of *responsibility* – then this opposition stands as the previous ones do. Theoretical consciousness is *disinterested* when “interested” is taken in the sense of egoism; it is on the contrary interested in the highest degree when interest is taken in the sense of a striving towards an essential end, and this end for theoretical cognition is precisely the self’s clarity about itself, its being for itself as self-conscious according to its total concretion. That spirit theoretically finds rest in any result whatever to which the consequences of the presuppositions lead is correct only in so far as spirit can halt momentarily at that result; but in the untrue or only half-true result there is always a stimulus which again awakens cognition’s interest for a new investigation and again drives it forward, precisely because the untrue result cannot come into accord with, or comprehend, that totality of cognition which cognition according to its essence must strive to work out<sup>\*)</sup>.

Theoretical cognition is to be *contemplative*, absorbed in the grounding of the ob-

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<sup>\*)</sup>Theoretical cognition’s interest in its result comes strikingly forward in its supplementing of the incomplete premisses of the inductive inference.

jective; but it is so only in the sense limited by the earlier determinations. From the contemplative, self-forgetting absorption in the universal and objective it seeks back to the punctual and to that self-cognition towards which an irresistible inner need drives it; and in striving towards its goal there is, in cognition's *struggle* for the appropriation of actuality, in the *true* cognition's struggle against the untrue, something corresponding to the will's conflict with existence, to its struggle for its realisation, to the good will's struggle against evil.

Theoretical cognition is finally to be *without personal responsibility*, the practical accompanied by the consciousness of such. This opposition too is untenable in the form in which it is set up. That with respect to the consciousness of responsibility there is a difference between the *act of will* and the activity of thought, when regard is had only to this, that the former intervenes determiningly in reality while the latter does not, at any rate not in a conscious manner, goes without saying. But the activity of cognition does not therefore fall outside responsibility. The act of cognition, which is subject to *the norm of the idea of truth*, has in that norm an "ought", in relation to which there is a consciousness of responsibility. When responsibility in general points to this, that what the individual is responsible for is the individual's own deed, that it proceeds from the individual's being, and that it stands in relation to a higher, more comprehensive law, then responsibility becomes common to what proceeds from the activity of cognition and from that of the will; and it must become so all the more, since the normal activity of cognition is, as will appear in what follows, the condition of the normal activity of the will. Cognition's connection with responsibility is therefore not to be apprehended merely thus, that the will's relation to cognition can bring cognition under responsibility, but thus, that cognition *in and for itself*, by its relation to the individual's being and to the higher law of truth, comes under it.

Through the consideration of the marks of character by which an abstract opposition between "theoretical" and "practical cognition" (consciousness), and thereby between cognition and will, was to be maintained, we are thus led to the *same result* as above: that the *abstract opposition* yields its place to an *essential unity* which *governs the relative difference*, and *must* do so, on account of the relation of the primitive expressions of the being to the unity of the being. This result will now receive a new confirmation when we consider the *opposition of facticity* between cognition and will, the opposition into which they can enter towards one another in the course of the individual development of the life of spirit.

A *factual* opposition comes forward at the imperfect stages of development of cogni-



tion and will: partly under the form of a one-sided development of cognition or of will; partly under the form of an indifference of the will towards, or an independence of it from, cognition; partly under the form of the act of will's opposition to cognition.

The *first* of these forms of divergence finds its explanation<sup>\*)</sup> in the sporadic element which comes forward, and must come forward, at the subordinate stages of development, but which at the highest stage of development — the stage at which cognition and will are determined by reason in their concrete content — must be joined together in unity and harmony. And unity is not merely the goal of the development: in the course of the diverging development there is a pointer towards it in this, that the one-sided development of cognition is defective not merely with respect to will but also with respect to cognition itself, just as the one-sided development of will is defective not merely with respect to cognition but with respect to will as well — so that the belonging-together and reciprocal conditioning of what has been separated becomes plain. Cognition developed one-sidedly, and not united with a development and firmness of will in the personality, will always show itself to be an abstract and uncarried-through cognition; a will developed one-sidedly, and not united with the richness and clarity of cognition, will show itself to be a will not yet purified through, and therefore not liberated from the instinctive, the fanatical and the violent, and thereby from the egoistic.

In the *second* form of the difference an effect of the sporadic likewise<sup>\*\*)</sup> makes itself felt, as where one acts from a mere prompting of drive or in blind passion; or else the resolution has only an incomplete cognition for its presupposition, and one acts from the immediacy of the concentrated personality. With respect to this last case there has been shown, in the earlier work (p. 144), the form under which, in such a resolution, a preceding cognition that has “gone back into immediate being in spirit” is at work<sup>\*)</sup>. The relation between the resolution and the incomplete presupposition of cognition has its exact parallel within the theoretical, in the inference which, with an incomplete empirical foundation — an experience not exhausted — for its presupposition, states the universal not hypothetically but categorically.

In the *third* form of divergence there makes itself felt partly<sup>\*\*)</sup> a working of the ethically a priori in the will's determining of itself in opposition to one-sided theory, and partly a counter-working of the will against the true, through an affecting of cognition

<sup>\*)</sup>Cf. *Problemet om Tro og Viden*, pp. 136 f.

<sup>\*\*)</sup>The same work, pp. 142 ff.

<sup>\*)</sup>A more thorough psychological observation will show that the concept of a determinateness of the will proceeding from a cognition that has gone back into immediate being — cognition taken in the widest sense of the concept — finds application also in the will's first expressions in the child, since the “pronouncedness” of these expressions follows step by step the pronouncedness of the life of representation.

<sup>\*\*)</sup>*Problemet om Tro og Viden*, p. 144.

and through a hindering of cognition's realisation. With respect to the activity which the ethically a priori exercises in consciousness, "Problemet om Tro og Viden", p. 145, has pointed to the parallel with the working which the a priori exercises within the theoretical, and it has been established that the *ethically* a priori, as an *essence*-determination and as an expression of the *undivided* being for which *knowledge* too is an expression, must also be a *knowledge*-determination and be transparent to cognition, so that its working is a working of that which finds its place within knowledge and enters into the system of knowledge's fundamental concepts. — As regards the will's conflict with what is cognised as true, this will show itself to take place only in relation to an *imperfect* cognition, and therefore to be confined to those stages of development at which the power of the sporadic is unconquered. A sharper psychological and ethical observation will confirm that clear, *concrete* cognition is never powerless against the will, that it is impossible to act against such an *actual* cognising. Could the will withstand what was in this way cognised as the *being's* determination, as the being's demand, then it would act merely in virtue of the essenceless, or the being would have to be split into two heterogeneous parts; but the former is self-contradictory, and such a split in the being, according to which the will would be something irrational and cognition something rational, is an empty representation, which becomes no less empty if, instead of a split, a "defectiveness" in the being is spoken of by way of postulate. In such cases as seem to speak for the will's unconditional power to withstand cognition, cognition will partly show itself to be incomplete in such a way that in its abstraction it as it were gives room for the conflicting action; and partly it will appear that cognition, as not yet fully unfolded, is by an act of will — more clearly or more obscurely conscious — which affects the direction of thought, brought outside the focus of consciousness, moved off into a distance of time for consciousness, and thereby obscured and hindered, so that it can be paralysed by a conflicting illusory cognition, an excuse, a pretext; and only through such a spacing-out does the conflicting action become possible. The clear cognition of what is unethical in an action, of its opposition to a preceding better cognition, sets in only *after* the action. Here the *time*-determination acquires a decisive significance.

While thus the factual divergence which at the imperfect stages of development can take place between cognition and will does not show itself to be of such a kind as to abolish the inner unity, this inner unity — in which cognition and will stand as expressions of the same being — finds its impress in that parallelism between the universal stages of development of cognition and of will which comes forward in spite of the unlike development the two functions of spirit may have in the individual. Just as cognition

develops from its first form, sensation, through the involuntary formation of universal representations, to a conscious and progressive separating out of the universal in the concept, so the will develops from the first, immediate, single determinateness by drive, through a determinateness by involuntarily formed *practical universal representations* — produced by a spontaneously arising momentary and partial reflection, such as make themselves felt in an abiding inclination — to a determinateness by consciously formed principles, maxims, out of which the unity of a view of life may then proceed.

The harmony and unity to which there was a pointer even in the divergence itself then comes forward unveiled at that stage of development of cognition and will at which the human spirit has attained to clarity about itself according to its concrete essential determination. In that the human spirit here becomes conscious in cognition of the content of its being, it expresses this content of cognition in the determinateness of the will: the will makes that content of cognition, in which the being becomes manifest to *itself*, into *its own* content, realises the being in its own form, in the resolution; and it does so in virtue of the necessity lying in the unity of the individually-universal, ideally-real being, in virtue of that law of the being which lets the being manifest itself in its *total* formal determinateness, and therein manifest itself in harmony with itself<sup>\*)</sup>. In the resolution the will is determined by the necessity of the being; but inasmuch as this necessity is the necessity of its *own* being, the will is *self*-determining through freedom. In order that the being may realise itself in an act of will, in the proper sense of that concept, it must first have become manifest to itself in cognition; but the will's self-determining is maintained through that relation to the essence-*totality*.

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If, after having elucidated the universal relation between the theoretical and the practical, we seek the closer determination of *cognition's true form* — of the form which is the goal of its development — then it is to be found from the fundamental relation of consciousness. In the relation given in the human spirit between self-consciousness and consciousness there lies the necessity of a striving to bring all content of consciousness under the unity of self-consciousness, to abolish the foreignness of the object of consciousness and to make it transparent for spirit in a comprehending cognising, in which the self has its ideal unfolding and its self-revelation, in that it ideally appropriates actuality. Only in such a comprehending cognising, in which the content of consciousness forms for spirit a unity answering to the unity of self-consciousness, is

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<sup>\*)</sup>Cf. Problemet om Tro og Viden, p. 142.

that contradiction abolished which lies in the relation of consciousness: that the object is in my consciousness as a determination of *my* consciousness, and yet according to its content is something foreign to me; and only in such cognising is that contradiction likewise abolished, that spirit — which in self-consciousness relates itself to itself in an infinite manner and is in unity with itself — is at the same time foreign to itself through the foreign content which the self comprehends. But when such a leading back of the content of consciousness to transparent unity with self-consciousness is cognition's demand, determined by the fundamental psychological relation, then such a leading back and such a unity become possible only on condition of a cognition of the principle which is the principle of unity of the self and of existence; and cognition's true form then becomes a principle-determined unity of cognition, in which the self, in cognising itself as an organic member ordered into the totality governed by the principle, can cognise itself according to its concretion. Such a form of cognition, in its essence like that which philosophy according to its concept is to give, must — in virtue of its relation to the original demand of consciousness, in virtue of its universal principle, in virtue of the kind of thought it presupposes, in virtue of the consciousness it encloses of the essence and fundamental relation of thought, in virtue of its combining of the a priori and the empirical — claim for itself the place of cognition's τέλος.

If we seek *action's true* form, then this must be determined from the will's fundamental relation to the essence of the self-conscious spirit. Since man is a self-conscious being and as self-conscious is a willing being, that working which in the animal, as unconscious and unfree fulfilment of drive, is only a deed acquires the character of *action*, i.e. of a *conscious* working proceeding from *will*. More closely, the nature of action is to be determined thus: that it is not merely accompanied by the consciousness *that* one is acting, but is determined by the consciousness of *why* one is acting. Action as action, in the proper sense of the word, is directed towards a goal, an *end*, is guided by this, is a conscious working for the attainment of this end. Action's goal, the consciously willed end, may, seen from the standpoint of the objective, show itself as an immediate or as a mediate goal: as that which stands directly in relation to the will and is willed for its own sake, or as that which stands in relation to the will only through something else and is willed for the sake of something else, as a means to the attainment of the end. But when, with respect to the objective, we speak of a willing of it for its own sake, this is nevertheless to be understood only in comparison with the objective means, not so that the subject's relation to itself is excluded, or the agent's subjective interest in the objective forgotten. The subject of action relates itself, as subject, at every point to itself;

in determining the objective as an end, it determines it as *its* end, and relates itself *to itself* in the realisation of the end, wills *itself* in willing the objective. Through the relation to the objective we are therefore led back to the relation to the subject; and that we are led back to it lies in the very essence of subjectivity, in its fundamental determination: to be for itself in its other. The end of action becomes then everywhere the subject itself, and this holds also of the action through which the subject gives itself up to the higher; for through self-surrender the higher self-affirmation is won.

But when the determination given holds of *all* action, then within it falls the opposition between *true* and *untrue* action. Action's truth is determined by the truth of the will (of the will's determinateness); but the will's truth is determined by whether the willing subject, in willing *itself*, wills itself *according to its truth*, i.e. according to its *essential determination*, and more closely, according to its *full* essential determination. *True action* is therefore that in which the will makes the realisation of the being — of which the will is a primitive expression — into its end, in which the will therefore works as *essence-willing*.

In opposition to this true form of action, which we anticipatively designate as *ethical* action, the *untrue* form of action becomes — setting aside for the present the unethical action, whose essence will be determined later — the *not yet* ethical, imperfect action, which proceeds from the subject's willing of itself according to its particular determinateness of immediacy, according to its finitude and contingency, according to its phenomenal existence. Such a willing becomes a willing by the subject of itself according to its ungoverned side of sensibility — sensibility being taken here in the widest compass of the concept — as an unconsciously egoistic willing of enjoyment. In this form of action, and in the will from which it proceeds, there lies an inner contradiction which reveals its untruth. When the self, as sensibly determined, wills enjoyment, it wills *itself* through enjoyment, in that in enjoyment it wills its self-affirmation as sensible. But in willing enjoyment the self wills that which is *independent* of the self's willing and which according to its nature is *changeable* — that, therefore, which *cannot* be governed by the will and which in its incommensurability with the self's universal essence *cannot* be held fast by the will. And in willing itself in the ununified manifoldness and essenceless changeableness of enjoyment, the self wills itself in a determinateness — the determinateness of sensible externality — in which its unity is abolished; it wills itself, therefore, in that in which, while it seeks a self-affirmation, it *loses itself*; it wills itself as not-self. The inner contradiction is abolished only when the will — which as an expression of the being must according to its concept be essence-willing — becomes

a willing of that which in truth *can* be willed, because it is one with the essence of the willing subject: a willing of that in which the self affirms itself according to its unity and abiding essentiality, according to the infinity of its essence. To such a willing of itself there is, at the imperfect stages of development of the will, a pointer, as to the goal at which the will finds rest, in that the will realises what was obscurely striven for at those lower stages of development. The goal of will and action, which is determined by the self and in which the self relates itself to itself, must from the beginning be covertly determined from *the self's unity* — a determining which betrays itself through the working-forth of the universal — and as the self becomes clear to itself according to its essence, it must *consciously* and *freely* be determined from *the self's content-rich unity*, so that the self according to its *total* essential determinateness, according to its true universality and infinity, becomes the contradiction-free τέλος of will and action. But such a willing by the self of itself according to its truth, according to the infinity of its essence, is *ethical* willing.

For this ethical, essential willing a twofold determination has been indicated in what immediately precedes, and the two stand in the closest inner connection. The ethical is constituted in that the self wills itself *according to its essence*, and in that — this being the condition of the former — it draws itself out of its immediate being with that being's unfreedom, finitude and changeableness, and by *freedom* determines itself *as spirit* according to its *inner infinity*. At the stage which lies before the ethical, the self willed that which as finite is something vanishing and is independent of the will; it willed *itself*, therefore, in what is something vanishing and something foreign to the self, that is to say, it lost itself. As it becomes conscious of the transitoriness of what is willed and of the contradiction lying therein, the opposition comes forward between the transitory finite and the infinite and unconditioned; there shows itself a *choice*; and as the will, in despair of the finite, frees itself from the finite and chooses the infinite, the ethical breaks through. But the infinite is chosen precisely in that the self chooses itself according to its essence; for that means: according to the *determination of eternity* within it, according to its *eternal validity*. In this *resolution of choice*, which is a *self-acquiring of freedom*, the oppositions in the choice receive a new elucidation and a new determination: the determination of the *good* and the *evil* — concepts which first belong in the ethical domain; and in the ethical choice the good is chosen.

In choosing itself according to its essence and through the choice willing its essence, the self has therefore made a movement of *infinity*: its *immediate* being according to its determinateness by *nature* is converted into a being of *spirit* through *itself*, through its

*freedom*. In that the self, through that infinitising choice, chooses and wills itself, it wills itself *absolutely*, i.e. *as an absolute*; and *only itself*, i.e. *its own essence*, can the self will absolutely; but this willing is possible only in that it wills the *Absolute* in the self. *The self* which chooses itself by the absolute willing of the ethical resolution has a *twofold* significance: it is the *ideal, universal self*, the self's absolute essence, that is chosen; but the choosing self, which chooses that essence as *its own*, is the *individual self*, which in choosing that other self chooses itself in its individuality. This is to say: it *takes over* its own development, lying prior to the ethical choice; but in taking it over in the choice of the ideal self, it takes it over as that development shows itself in the ideal self's light. In other words: it passes the ethical judgement of *repentance* upon that development; it *transforms* itself in principle in the ethical resolution, in virtue of its fundamental essence. In this repentant choosing the self gathers itself together in its whole finite concretion; and while in the choice it as it were takes itself out of finitude, it is in the most absolute continuity with finitude and has itself as its task in its ethically chosen concrete actuality — an actuality which is to be worked through by, and penetrated with, the universal, so that the actual self is determined by the ideal self which it has within it, and expresses at one and the same time the individual and the universally human<sup>\*)</sup>.

For *ethical willing*, whose essence and task are thus determined, there now shows itself — both in its first constituting of itself and in its unfolding in action's concrete determinateness — *true cognition* as an essential and necessary *condition*.

For the immediate working of the ethically a priori, by which such a presupposition of cognition might seem to be replaced, shows itself insufficient. That the a priori has an activity which reveals itself in conscience is incontrovertible; but in order that this activity may be raised above a merely enveloped (implicit) presence in the form of the merely instinctive and drive-like, it presupposes a development of cognition, just as the logically a priori presupposes such a development in order to be freed from what hinders and obscures it. In that first working the ethically a priori works immediately together with promptings of drive, works itself under the form of a prompting of drive — for example under the form of sympathy, of natural love — but is not clarified into ethical freedom. Therefore the ethically a priori in its immediate working is insufficient as a regulative for action. In the immediate prompting, which is not yet clarified through by cognition, it remains constantly uncertain how far what prompts is something in truth a priori, and as such a true essential determination, or whether it is not something untrue, an expression of something unwarranted, something phenomenal and contingent. And since the a

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<sup>\*)</sup>Cf. the developments in *Kierkegaard's Enten* — Eller, II.

priori *as a priori* has the stamp of the abstract, it becomes, when it is not unfolded into concretion by cognition, insufficient for the determination of the concrete action. When action is called for, the subject will come to seek the determinateness of the action outside the abstract norm, in its own unclarified, nature-determined immediacy, in which it is not conscious of itself according to its essence; and there will then arise a dividedness and doubleness in the will, since the universal and the particular, the norm and the concrete content of the action, cannot be willed as one. This contradictory doubleness can vanish only when the essential demand unfolds itself in concrete determinateness for cognition.

The diversity of what at different times, at the different stages of human development, has been held to be morally right confirms the insufficiency of the immediate prompting by the *a priori*. One need take as an example only the manner in which the feeling of reverence for the divine, or the immediate feeling of piety towards parents, has found its expression.

In virtue of the ethically *a priori* there may be an immediate consciousness of an ethical obligation, as an obligation towards something higher; but the clear consciousness of *that which obliges* is conditioned by true cognition, and likewise the *assured* consciousness of the concrete content of the obligation is conditioned by such cognition — by the concrete cognition of that which obliges and of the *essential determinateness* and *essential content* of the one obliged. Instinctively one may live in accordance with the moral, in that the objectively moral — custom and tradition — immediately determines the acting individual, who in a relation of piety subordinates itself to this objective as to a higher power in which it feels something akin to itself, and whose law it therefore follows, not as a foreign law. Instinctively the immediate consciousness may grasp the good, may act in the spirit of morality, in that it, unconsciously affected by the surrounding moral element of life, acknowledges something universal and ideal as the norm of action, gives up the egoistic, and in the particular action acts with the will of resignation, guided by its determinateness in principle. But custom and tradition, the surrounding moral atmosphere of life — whether they be the resultant of the immediate working of the *a priori* or of a preceding cognition which has as it were been deposited in immediate being — can be the secure norm only when they can again be freed, in living cognition, from the immediate form in which something contingent and foreign may cling to them. The clear, free, assuring consciousness of the moral and of the inner connection within it can be attained only through such a cognition as separates out the contingency of immediacy, and more determinately through that kind of cognition



by which what is cognised can acquire inner unity and necessity — therefore through the principle-determined cognition whose essence has been developed above. Such a cognition has, in its incompleteness — inseparable from the conditions of human development — and in its relative abstraction, the essential truth and the possibility of as it were growing out from its centre and filling out its forms without their being displaced. With such cognition for its presupposition the ethical will acquires its true form, precisely because the being is in that cognition clear to itself; and in its liberation from finite entanglement, from the obscurely drive-like which in itself is the changeable and which, even in its direction towards the good, knows no limit, the ethical will acquires that true resoluteness, firmness and purity which is conditioned by the being-for-cognition of what is willed. The subject's concrete cognition of its essence and of the true demand of that essence acquires here its decisive practical significance.

From what has been developed it becomes clear that cognition's significance for the ethical already comes forward where the ideal self is to be made *with consciousness* into the object of the will, where something *absolute* and *unconditioned* announces itself and is to be separated out from what veils and obscures it. But it comes forward still more clearly when the idea of the good is to be realised in the *concretion* of the moral will, to be worked out in the actuality of a wholeness of life — when, what becomes identical with this, the self's willing of itself according to its ideal essence is to attain the concrete form of actuality of the ethical action, the realisation of the human being through free human action, action in truth agreeing with itself and with its own essence. For only through the true and concrete cognition of the self's essence and of its fundamental relation does free action become in its determinateness action *determined by reason*, does the ethical unfold its rational content *clearly and unmixed*. Since the *ethically a priori* in its abstraction meets with something concretely given, with something *empirical*, then in this meeting — which is to lead to a determining of the latter by the former, to an unfolding of the abstract ethical consciousness of essence into an essential consciousness of actuality — only the true form of cognition, which acknowledges the *a priori* and realises its essential unity with the empirical — a cognition, therefore, of the kind determined above — can be guiding in the last instance. Only through it can the self's willing of its essence become a willing of the essence according to its complete concrete determinateness; only through it can the self in its acting truly “will one thing”). —

An expression of this significance of cognition for action is the fact that *ethics*, the scientific cognition of the ethical, must acquire its *essential* significance for that ethical.

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<sup>\*)</sup>Cf. Section III (on the realisation of the ideal).

If *scientific* cognition is cognition's clearest and most complete unfolding, then what has been said of true cognition must find its immediate application to it.

Since ethical action is determined as action's true form on the ground that the will from which it proceeds is an *essence*-willing, a willing of the self according to its essential determinateness, ethical action acquires its *norm* in the *human being*, its *law* in the being's own law of activity, and its task becomes to express the total actual personality. Herewith there is once more a pointing back to *the opposition to the positively religious*. This opposition shows itself here partly as an opposition between the being's indwelling law and the supranatural, arbitrarily determined law of action, partly as an opposition between an ethical life which comprehends the total, real existence and a life which, as obeying the supranatural demand, flees away from the natural, relates itself negatively to the natural through asceticism, and expresses the spirit-side of the being in an abstractly spiritualistic way.

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The result of the developments given in the foregoing we sum up in the following propositions:

1. True cognition, which is chosen in the choice between *knowledge* and *faith*, becomes the condition of the clearly conscious willing of the ethical, and of the ethical's concrete unfolding into a wholeness which comprehends the life of the actual personality.
  2. The personal life can be clarified through by true principle-determined cognition, and this cognition can, as it advances in concretion, win such a punctuality that the concrete ethical action can find in it its *ratio sufficiens*.
  3. The true unity of theory and practice, of the "theoretical" and the "practical" consciousness, is present in this relation, in which the subject's consciousness of its action and of its "grounds of will" is in harmony with its theoretical cognition of its essence and of the essence's demand; — and it is present *only* in this.
  4. In virtue of this relation between cognition and ethical action, since no splitting into incommensurable forms takes place within cognition, all that is truly ethical must be a rational ethical, just as all true ethics is a rational ethics. An antirational ethical is a self-contradiction, an antirational ethics an absurdity.
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## II.

# On the Presence of the Essential Marks of the Religious in its True Sense in True Cognition and True Action, and on their Relation of Unity to the Former.

### 1. The Essence of the Religious.

The expression for the religious relation which was used in the “preliminary determinations of concepts” in “Problemet om Tro og Viden” to designate that relation according to its ideal determinateness becomes here our starting point, and through the analysis of it we shall be able to reach the more concrete unfolding of the concept of the religious.

We there determined the religious relation as “*the absolute relation*<sup>\*)</sup> *to the Absolute*” — by an expression, therefore, which not merely in form approaches S. Kierkegaard’s usual designation of the stage of a religiousness not yet Christian, which he characterises as “the absolute direction towards the absolute τέλος”, but which has already been used by him where he sets the religious absolute relation beside the relative relations, which with him comprehend the ethical relations as well, and in which that absolute relation is not to exhaust itself or become concrete. While we thus appropriate his designation of the concept, it will nevertheless appear through the developments that follow how in our conception this designation acquires another significance than it had with Kierkegaard —

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<sup>\*)</sup>If it should seem to “inverted” dialecticians contradictory to speak of an *absolute relation*, because relation expresses *relativity*, we need presumably only recall the Absolute’s relation to itself, and spirit’s infinity-relation to itself in the concretion of self-consciousness.

already where he speaks of the pre-Christian religious stage, and still more determinately where he speaks of the paradoxically religious.

If we analyse the determination of the religious relation as the absolute relation to the Absolute, then the analysis leads us to the following consequences, through which the concept acquires its more concrete determinateness.

a) *With respect to the Absolute*, which is the object of the relation, the fundamental determination encloses the following:

α) The “Absolute” which is the object of the religious relation can be an absolute *for us* only when it is *our* Absolute, i.e. when it stands in a relation of *essential unity* to us. In an opposition of essence there would lie immediately a determination irreconcilable with absoluteness. Against this unity of essence the ethical “absolute distinction” between God and guilty man, so strongly accentuated by Kierkegaard, does not tell; for the determination of guilt lies, as will be more closely developed under III, within the relation of immanence, and therefore makes no definitive breach in the unity of essence.

In the positive religion’s conception of the relation between God and man there is a doubleness present. On the one side likeness is accentuated, out of the immediate religious need: man is posited as created in God’s image; but on the other side the reflection determined by the form of representation leads to accentuating the opposition between the transcendent God and man, and this opposition fixes itself as an unabolishable one (cf. Section III, on reconciliation).

β) The object of the religious relation can be the Absolute for us only when it is *the in truth infinite*. Only the in truth infinite can be absolutely willed, absolutely sought through the need of the *whole* human being; and only what we will absolutely, absolutely strive towards, is for us an absolute. A willing of something finitely determinate is a finite willing, and the relation to it a finite, relative relation. This determination — that the Absolute must be the in truth infinite — is inseparable from the other, that it must stand in a relation of essential unity to us. For it can be the in truth infinite only when it is not separated from us by the barrier of a represented, and therefore finitely determined, transcendence.

Only these more formal determinations of the Absolute are necessary in the present connection; the more concrete determinations of the concept will be given under III, Chapter 1.

b) *With respect to the subject of the relation: man*, it follows from the determination “the absolute relation” that the subject must be present in the relation according to its essence’s *inner infinity*, that is to say, according to its *whole* essential determinateness, according to

the totality of its *universal* essence. The religious relation cannot, therefore, be a relation which relates itself to a single side of the human spirit or to a single fundamental function, even if this were thought to enclose the others within itself as moments — whereby the others would enter the relation precisely only *in the determinateness* they could have as moments; but it must be a relation into which the fundamental functions of the human spirit, as totalised within themselves, enter equally. Just as it therefore becomes a one-sidedness in the *Hegelian* philosophy of religion that it apprehends the religious relation exclusively as a relation of *cognition*, so it becomes just as fully a one-sidedness to determine it as a mere relation of *will*, or to designate it as what has been called, with a somewhat unclear expression, a relation of *life*, in *opposition* to a relation of cognition. The religious relation is a *life-relation in the sense* of a relation which comprehends *the whole of human life*; but human life, the life of spirit, is the life of cognition just as much as of will and of feeling; it is therefore apprehended in a one-sided and imperfect manner when it is apprehended only as opposed to cognition. But since the relation comprehends the totality of human life, the relation of will acquires on the other side a just as decisive and primitive significance, and it can step into the foreground where reconciliation is *sought*. The will in the relation to the Absolute is, when the relation is in truth, the religiously determined, *ethical* will, which actively transforms existence through the relation. Through this will the relation becomes a relation of *conscience*. That the relation is a *relation of personality* points back equally to cognition and to will<sup>\*)</sup>: what is a fundamental expression of the being is at the same time a fundamental expression of the personality; otherwise the determination of personality would stand in a merely contingent relation to the being, which is immediately self-contradictory.

That towards which spirit infinitely strives through the absolute relation so apprehended is *reconciliation*, and the religious life becomes a life for spirit's reconciliation *within itself and with its ground of essence*. This is as yet more a *metaphysical* determination of the religious relation, and it is reached already through the concept of spirit as that which according to its essence is infinite, and which, in order to find rest in itself, strives to realise this infinity within itself, but first realises it through the absolute relation to the in truth infinite, to its own and to existence's ground of essence. The specifically ethical-religious determination of the relation — the determination of reconciliation as reconciliation of *guilt* — will be developed only later.

Since the equal entry of the *whole* human spirit into the religious relation is thus accentuated, the divergent conceptions are to be touched upon which emphasise the

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<sup>\*)</sup>Cf. the preceding Section.

one-sidedly limited determination of a *life-relation*. We may here take account partly of *Grundtvig*, partly of *Martensen*.

With the *former* an emphasis is laid on the relation of *life* in the sense of a relation of *immediacy*, which is so apprehended that the immediacy acquires the aesthetic character of sensible presence and comes to enclose within itself the moment of the magical. In the conception of the working of the “living Word”, of the power of the sacrament, spirit’s relation of freedom to spirit here gives room for a magical working; and while the religious consciousness, which by a postulate cuts reflection off at a determinate point, at the symbol, seeks rest in an unshakable, immovable objectivity, it exchanges the in truth religious relation for an aesthetic, poetic relation, in which the personality has not itself made the movement of infinity through true inwardisation, in which it does not know infinite resignation, but relates itself to the divine without knowing the seriousness of the relation, without remembering that the possibility of doubt becomes at every moment that which must be overcome if the relation is to be in truth, and that the anxiety of uncertainty becomes the ground upon which the victorious certainty of the relation of faith is to rest. Since, with a half-conscious shyness of thought, there is unclear talk of a relation of life into which the life of thought is not taken up, it is overlooked at this standpoint that a relation through cognition, through thought — precisely because cognition is the being’s expression, because it is the form of realisation for the relation of essence — becomes in the true sense a relation of life, and that it leads to *that* immediate unity which can be thought in the domain of the life of spirit.

With *Martensen* there comes forward an endeavour to bring the *whole* of human life into the religious relation: *faith* is determined as *a unity of religious feeling, cognition and will*. But in virtue of the subordinate and governed position which he lets cognition occupy in relation to faith, and in virtue of the conception he asserts of the *will* as “the concluding moment in religious consciousness”, this endeavour is not realised, and the relation of cognition is pressed back. Since the religious God-relation is separated from the speculative and the aesthetic, which are determined as relations “at second hand”, while the religious becomes an *existential relation*, a “consciousness of the God-relation which is one with the personal living and being in this relation”, then in this form of separation what is essential in the relation of cognition is pushed aside; the one-sided distinction between the impersonal and the personal is asserted also for that true, concrete cognition in which the self seeks a satisfaction for its deepest need, grounded in the essence of its personality. And this one-sided pressing back of the moment of cognition betrays itself also in the closer developments, in which the religious relation is

characterised as a *holy* relation, a relation of *conscience*; for through these determinations it is to be expressed that the relation of religion is a relation to the “*personal*” God, in *that* conception of the concept which raises it above the “logical” and makes the *will* the organ of the God-relation.

c) With respect to the *relative* relations it follows from the determination of the religious relation as the *absolute* one that this relation cannot fall outside them, but must comprehend them, penetrate them and make them absolute through their unity with it. In this unity — a unity conditioned by the ethical becoming something all-comprehending — the relative relations must acquire a higher significance, so that they can become adequate expressions of the religious, which has its concrete unfolding in them.

This determination receives its sharper elucidation by a comparison with S. Kierkegaard's conception of the relation between the absolute religious τέλος and the relative ones. As he seeks the expression for that form of religiousness which is not yet that of the paradoxically religious, the *first* expression of religious existence becomes for him *the absolute direction (respect) towards the absolute τέλος, expressed in action in the transformation of existence*. In the relation to the absolute τέλος *all* the moments of finitude are to be once and for all reduced, in action, to what must be given up in relation to eternal blessedness; only on condition of this exceptionless surrender is the existing individual in actuality to relate himself to the absolute τέλος, to will it absolutely. As the absolute τέλος for the willing individual who wills to strive absolutely, it is to be so abstract that, aesthetically regarded, it is the poorest representation; the willing individual is not even to will to know anything of this τέλος beyond that it exists; for as soon as he comes to know something of it, he is already to begin to be delayed in his course. The absolute τέλος is then not to be possessed at rest in existence; the whole time, the whole of existence, becomes the time of expectation. Mediation is to have no place here, because the existing individual is prevented from gaining such a footing outside existence that from it he could mediate what moreover, by being in becoming, withdraws itself from completedness. In relation to the absolute τέλος, that mediation takes place is to mean precisely that the absolute τέλος is reduced to a relative τέλος. It is not to be true that the absolute τέλος becomes concrete in the relative; for resignation's absolute distinction is at every moment to secure it against all fraternising. The absolute relation is to be able to demand the renunciation of *all* the relative ones. But for that very reason the one who relates himself to the absolute τέλος is nevertheless to be very well able to be in the relative ones; it will be precisely in renouncing that the absolute relation is practised: the relation which rests on the absolute distinction, the relation to that which is won

only by absolutely venturing all<sup>\*)</sup>.

In the first determination of the religious relation thus more closely developed, there are already indicated in Kierkegaard the consequences which come forward decisively where at last, within Christianity, the demand of the religious is raised so high that it consumingly burns up all finitude and with it all those ethical relations which, seen from this height, come under the determination of finitude. The religious relation here acquires the utmost abstraction: it can become the power which with the force of infinity draws the existing individual out of finitude and constantly gives him the direction towards the eternal; but it cannot win shape in the existing individual, cannot form his concrete actuality; for, as I have shown in another place<sup>\*\*)</sup>, it becomes only a *demand* that the individual should be able at one and the same time to relate himself absolutely to the absolute τέλος and relatively to the relative ones, in which the former is not to become concrete. But by this abstraction, which unavoidably attaches itself to the religious relation, that relation acquires precisely the character of *relativity* and loses the possibility of expressing the highest energy of the undivided human being; and in the finite which it is to be able to demand be given up there is also that which, as something essential, is something that cannot be given up: the ethical relations as a totality. A corrective against that conception lies already in this, that with Kierkegaard the fundamental ethical relation comes into being only as a relation of will to *the eternal*, and that the determination of the eternal in the domain of the ethical is not to be distinguished from the determination of it at that stage of the religious which we have characterised. If this is held fast, then the ethical cannot be apprehended as a stage of transition in the sense that there could be an ethical life which was not yet religious; rather the ethical becomes ethical only by being from the first religious. And precisely for that reason the religious stands in such a relation to the ethical that it must always find its expression in the ethical — so that there cannot be thought a surrender, warranted by the religious, of the totality of the ethical, of all the ethical relations, but the renunciation of an ethical relation must always be in virtue of a higher and more comprehensive ethical, and religious renunciation must therefore always be borne by ethical action.

d) The first, essential determination of the religious relation was therefore that it was an *absolute, infinite* relation. And in the concept of the human spirit, in its essential determination, lies the *necessity* of such a relation for the human spirit. Infinity is its essence, its true element of life; only in a relation of infinity can it therefore come to rest, and so that it stands in an absolute relation — i.e. in a relation of infinity — not merely

<sup>\*)</sup>Kierkegaard: Afsluttende Efterskrift, pp. 295 ff.

<sup>\*\*)</sup>Problemet om Tro og Viden, p. 221.



according to a single one of its fundamental functions but according to their totality. Even when the content of spirit is converted into the form of *feeling*, the relation's absoluteness can be preserved, since feeling, in totalised unity with cognition and will, becomes that intensive form of immediacy of spirit whose content has the infinite richness of unfolded possibility, and which at every moment can become mobile and be clarified through in cognition and will.

e) That first determination of the religious relation, as the absolute relation to the Absolute, now acquires a *more concrete* form in that the limitation of *existence*, the determinateness by *finitude*, of the human being that enters the religious relation is accentuated. At this point, however, only the general determinations to which this standpoint leads are to be indicated; the closer consequences — namely with respect to the significance of the temporal relation for the ethical-religious life, for guilt and its abolition — will be shown in the last Section.

The new determinations that come in, and that express that the absolute relation to the Absolute is the absolute relation to the Absolute of a human spirit which is *according to its essence infinite* but which *exists in determinateness by finitude*, are the determinations of *faith* and of *self-surrender*. Of these, when they are distinguished, the first points rather to cognition, the second to will — but so that faith's cognition must according to its truth be determined as being in inner, harmonious unity with the will, and self-surrender's will as standing in the same relation of unity to cognition.

f) The determination of *faith* comes forward in that the finite consciousness is, out of its determinateness by finitude, to grasp the infinite and eternal in the form of certainty and to hold it fast as that which penetrates and determines finitude. Faith is a postulate of cognition, an inference incommensurable with its premisses: in the relation to the eternally present it leaps over the intermediate links of grounding cognition and grasps the eternally present as this present; it transforms the uncertainty of what is to come into the certainty of something present. In this relation faith shows itself to stand at one and the same time in relation to the being's determinateness by finitude and to its determinateness by infinity. Faith is only as that certainty which is born of uncertainty, which as it were unwinds itself out of uncertainty; and through the uncertainty which at every moment is to be conquered, finitude betrays itself. But that certainty can be won through uncertainty, that uncertainty *can* be conquered, shows the infinity of spirit. That which warrants faith's postulate, that which fills out the distance between its premisses and its conclusion, is *the essential determination of the human spirit*, which with the necessity of the *a priori* points to *the Absolute* as that without which consciousness

would lose its hold upon itself. It is the being's infinity which, through the enclosure of finitude, compels consciousness to acknowledge the infinite and eternal<sup>\*)</sup>. And through the infinity of the *being* there works the infinity of the *principle*, by which the being has its being. That postulate of faith has therefore at once a human and a divine origin; it is an expression of the unity of the working of the human and of the divine spirit.

As such a postulate of cognition faith is at work in that, in the ethical choice, man's living is determined by the infinite and eternal; and as such it is at work in that the infinity of life is held fast in the particular action which fills out human life and which, as *ethical*, confirms that primitive choice's constituting of the character of the life of spirit.

In the ethical choice and in the ethical action which confirms the choice there reveals itself the *true form of the unity of cognition and will* in the relation of faith. The choice, and the action which rests upon the choice, is at one and the same time the expression of that energy of cognition with which cognition breaks through the finitude that veils infinity and with the power of its own essence grasps infinity, and the expression of the will's resolution. The will, which through cognition is clear about itself, demands as the goal in which it, as essence-willing, can come to rest, the infinite, which is the condition of the infinity of essence; it demands the infinite in order to be able to be itself<sup>\*)</sup>. And just as the will demands the Absolute in order to rest in it, so also does feeling first find rest in it; and feeling preserves the Absolute's absoluteness in that at every moment of its intensive concentration it as it were conceals within itself the memory of cognition and the tension towards will.

g) The determination of *self-surrender* comes forward in that the particular finite will is to break through the determinateness by finitude in which it immediately has its life, in order to will infinitely, and in this willing — which is a willing of the true infinity of its own essence — to enter into the absolute relation, to set itself in unity with the in truth infinite, to let itself be determined by the in truth infinite as a member of that totality, that community of spirit, which the infinite governs.

Self-surrender is first the self-surrender of *the choice*, the choosing will's decisive surrender in principle of the determinateness by finitude in order to be able to grasp

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<sup>\*)</sup>Immediately there lies in this as yet only such an acknowledgement as can be united with an averted disposition, as when it is said of the demons in the New Testament that they believe in God and tremble. But when the infinite is to be acknowledged as the in truth infinite, then this acknowledgement is conditioned by a faith which acknowledges the infinite and eternal in its validity as the ideal of human life, by a faith which is in unity with self-surrender. In that relation in which faith stands beside an averted disposition, the divine becomes, through the *opposition* to the self's abstract infinity, only an abstract infinite, in reality therefore only a finite, with the form of negative infinity. The rest of infinity which spirit seeks, because infinity is its essential determination, is therefore found only where faith and self-surrender are in unity, i.e. where faith is according to the completeness of its essence.

<sup>\*)</sup>The will's possible resistance to the divine will be elucidated under Section III.

infinity. But the moment of the constituting choice is to be unfolded so as to comprehend a *whole* life, in whose particular actions the choice, formed into an abiding resolution, repeats itself, through the confirmation of the will's first surrender of the finite content of will and of its own selfishness. In the choice and in the repetition of the choice, self-surrender acquires on the one side the form of resignation, of dying away from immediacy (S. Kierkegaard), of inwardisation, of "self-annihilation" in the sense of the abolition of the selfish; and on the other side — since the goal is a regaining by the self of itself according to its determinateness by eternity and in concrete actuality — the form of a self-assertion according to the self's truth. But since such a regaining, such a self-asserting, is possible only through the unity with the divine, which is the principle of the being, self-surrender acquires the form of a surrender to the working of the divine («*Deum pati*») — a surrender which is not merely the purification of the finite will but, as its infinitising, the expression of its highest energy: it becomes a suffering which is one with the highest acting<sup>\*)</sup>.

Its *definitive* determination self-surrender acquires in that the subject which surrenders itself to the divine determines its own life in the determinateness by finitude as *guilt* — in that self-surrender therefore becomes one with consciousness's repentant acknowledgement of guilt, and with its striving after that guilt's reconciliation in God through a divine working. This determination is here only touched upon; its closer development will be given under Section III, as will the demonstration of its relation to the determinations of the Christian.

In self-surrender, in which the will's working comes forward primitively, this will is, as emerges from the earlier developments, conditioned by and in unity with cognition. And just as fully as self-surrender beneath the infinite must be determined as the will's goal, so must it also be determined as cognition's and as feeling's; for when the cognising spirit, through the surrender of its finitude, finds rest in self-surrender to the infinite, spirit as feeling finds rest in that self-surrender which is the self-surrender of the feeling of absolute dependence.

h) In the foregoing it has already been indicated how the moment of faith and the moment of self-surrender in the religious relation stand in the closest connection with one another. Their concepts presuppose one another, and in their full and true

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<sup>\*)</sup>With S. Kierkegaard religious suffering and self-annihilation are set in opposition to the ethical self-assertion in which the existing individual, by "repenting through", is to find himself again. This opposition hangs together with the conception of the ethical stage as a stage of transition. If the ethical is apprehended in that original unity with the religious which has been shown above, then already the ethical self-assertion becomes a self-assertion through unity with the self's absolute principle, and the opposition between the religious and the ethical relation is abolished.

significance they cannot be thought without one another. Faith presupposes, as was shown (p. 39 note), self-surrender in order to be able to be faith in the in truth infinite; it presupposes self-surrender in order to be able to grow its own growth; and it bears self-surrender within itself, since as a grasping and a holding fast of the eternal — which in faith's certainty is lifted out of the uncertainty of doubt — it is a self-giving of spirit to the eternal truth in which human life as a whole finds rest. And just as faith presupposes self-surrender, so self-surrender presupposes faith, precisely in order to be able to be self-surrender to the *true* divine, i.e. in order in truth to be able to be self-surrender; and that action of self-surrender by which the self wins its life through the surrender of its life's selfishness is such that life can be regained in its truth and eternity only through faith in the eternal, to which life can thus be surrendered.

i) If we sum up the given determinations of the essence of the religious relation, then religion, according to its ideal significance, becomes the absolute relation to the Absolute as the true infinite standing in a relation of essential unity with us. It becomes a relation which, as grounded in the human being itself, comprehends the whole of human life, all the fundamental activities of spirit. It becomes — since man is seen as a unity of infinity and finitude — a relation of faith and of self-surrender; a relation through which the human spirit, entangled in finitude and bound in guilt, finds reconciliation within itself and with its own origin.

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The relation between religion in the sense indicated and the *positive* religions is indicated in its main features in the “preliminary determinations of concepts” in the earlier work; it will emerge more determinately from the developments that follow.

The relation of the conception developed above to S. *Kierkegaard's* determinations of the essence of the religious has already been partly touched upon. It shows itself at first glance that this conception has essential points of connection in his determination of that stage of religiousness which is not yet that of the paradoxically religious; but an incisive difference came forward in the difference of conception of the religious's relation to the ethical, of the absolute relation's relation to the relative ones. From *Kierkegaard's* determination of the religious as the *paradoxically* religious that conception must of course diverge still more decisively. What sharpens the difference here is the opposition between immanence and abstract transcendence; between the view of the human *being's* imperturbability and man's *essence*-transformation through sin; between the maintaining of cognition in the religious relation and its annihilation through the paradox, the absolutely incomprehensible; between the acknowledgement of the real's essential validity

and essential unity with the ideal in existence's principle, in existence's wholeness and in the human being<sup>\*)</sup>, and Christianity's absolutely spiritualistic conception, which with Kierkegaard becomes manifest in the negative consequences with which he concludes. With these oppositions an essential difference in the conception of reconciliation will also show itself to stand in connection.

## **2. Cognition's Relation to the Religious according to its Ideal Determinateness.**

In order that cognition's relation to the religious, in the ideal sense of this concept, may show itself as a relation of unity, it must be established that cognition, by its relation to the human being and by the form in which it expresses the being, can become the medium for a relation of infinity, an absolute relation; that it can have absolute significance for the human spirit; and that it encloses within itself that moment of faith and of self-surrender which showed itself to be an essential mark of the religious.

a) The condition for cognition's being able to become, for the human spirit, the form of an absolute relation is that it can preserve the object's true infinity within the relation. That it must be able to preserve the determinateness by infinity lies already, so far, in cognition's form, in that this form is determined by the universal; and this universal — whose being as universal for human consciousness is conditioned by the being's inner infinity — stands in essential connection with the infinite. But in order that through this form of cognition the infinite may be preserved as the in truth infinite, cognition's form of universality must be in concrete unity with the other fundamental forms of the concept. In order that it may be this, it is presupposed that cognition in the relation to the Absolute does not stand in abstract opposition to what is just as fully a fundamental function of spirit, and that it does not become a one-sided form of spirit's activity, isolated from what supplements and totalises it. As such it would, for example, unavoidably have to be apprehended if it were separated from the will by an absolute heterogeneity of principle; for in this separation the will would appropriate the determination of singularity as its fundamental form and let cognition's form of universality become that of abstract universality, while the will's form of singularity, in its separation from the universal, would become precisely only the form of immediate natural singularity. In this abstract opposition neither of the functions of spirit would be apprehended according to its truth, i.e. as an expression of the undivided, total human

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<sup>\*)</sup>Cf. the following Section (III).

spirit, and neither of them would come in truth to relate itself to the infinite, because the infinite in its true infinity could not be for either of them.

With respect to the relation between the formal determinatenesses of the primitive functions of spirit, what is needful has been developed in the previous Section and in the earlier work, pp. 134 ff. It has been shown in what relation cognition's determinateness by universality stands to the particular and the concrete, and how the will's determinateness by singularity — precisely because the *will's* singularity is "singularity of spirit" — unfolds the determinateness of the universal out of itself. Of what nature the will's determinateness by singularity is shows itself already through the fact that the will has its limit in the organism against the singularity and immediacy of nature-determined reality; and the will's psychological relation to that determinateness by drive out of which it unfolds itself in the course of the development of the life of spirit, and into which it is unconsciously converted as acting upon the self's natural side, its organism — as for example when an act of will calls forth a momentary or a mechanically continued movement — points to a limit of the will as will, by which its form of singularity is determined. If, however, in order to maintain the absolute heterogeneity, one were to let the will's universal set itself up as something absolutely heterogeneous from cognition's universal, then such a doubling of the universal into two absolutely heterogeneous kinds of universal, yet designated by the same common determination, would immediately enclose a self-contradiction, an absurdity. From what has been developed in the foregoing it therefore emerges that for that cognition which, as an essential expression of the human spirit undivided within itself, cannot be held fast in abstract separation from what is just as fully a primitive expression of spirit, and which is therefore not one-sidedly determined by a single fundamental form of the concept — for such cognition the Absolute can be an object according to its truth, as the in truth infinite; and its infinity can be preserved under the relative abstraction. It can therefore be present for cognition in the form in which it is the object of religion according to religion's ideal significance, in which it is the object of faith as that which is demanded by the human spirit, as that goal of spirit in which the being's claim finds satisfaction, in which spirit first finds rest.

b) That cognition can have *absolute* significance for the human spirit — that significance, therefore, which it must be able to have in order to be able to express the religious relation — shows itself first through this, that cognition, in virtue of its relation to the human being, must be *an end in and for itself*. It becomes an end in that it is a realisation of a fundamental determination in the human spirit, and more closely, of the determination which is according to the concept principal in spirit; but this means: it

is an end as the being's realisation in one of the being's fundamental forms. But since it is a form for the realisation of the universal being, it is the form for the individual spirit's expansion so as ideally to take up the whole of infinite existence; it is the energy which ideally binds the individual spirit together with this whole of existence. Thereby cognition's absolute significance shows itself from a new standpoint; for in realising spirit's determinateness by universality, and in ideally binding spirit together with the whole of existence, it binds spirit together with existence's principle, the Absolute, which as such is cognition's principle and moving power, that upon whose cognition all true cognition rests. Cognition therefore acquires, from this standpoint, absolute significance because it realises that relation of spirit to the Absolute which is laid down in the human being; and since this realising of the human being's deepest relation is seen as being only through the working of the indwelling Absolute, cognition's absolute significance shows itself once more in a new light, which makes it still clearer how spirit can relate itself religiously in cognition and to cognition.

From the standpoints emphasised, cognition has as yet been directly regarded only according to its significance in the *theoretical* respect, through which it already shows itself as a self-valid end for that being which in cognition realises itself according to a fundamental determination within itself, and which precisely only in relating itself to cognition as an end can be present in cognition with spirit's whole power, with that love of cognition by which alone cognition becomes productive and creative, animated by the idea. But since now the human being — which in cognition realises itself and realises its ideal unity with existence and with existence's principle — as a being which comprehends a *totality* of functions, enters as an active *member* into a whole of existence and becomes conscious of itself as such, cognition's absolute significance is also to be seen from the standpoint of *action*. How it is to be apprehended from this standpoint emerges from what was developed in the previous Section. Only through cognition does that action become possible in which the individual works according to its absolute determination, which is the being's realisation through the will's freedom. Cognition showed itself to become the presupposition of such an action, partly by its clarifying, liberating, purifying influence upon the will, partly as determining the content of the true will. From this standpoint — where cognition shows itself as a function within an organic wholeness of life, while it works as a condition, as a means, for the ethical — it is at the same time to be seen as an ethical *end*, and as working towards its own realisation in working towards the realisation of that unity of life in which it has its truth. And since cognition exercises upon the other activities of spirit, upon the life of feeling and

the life of imagination, the same purifying and clarifying influence which it exercised upon the will, it shows itself in its relation to them too in its significance as realising the inner unity and harmony of the total human being; and this standpoint thus leads back to the first, from which cognition was seen as a realisation of the human being.

c) That there is in cognition a moment of *faith* — not in the Jacobian sense of an immediate certainty of being, but in a sense in which the fundamental determination of the religious relation of faith is preserved — shows itself at *every* stage of cognition's development. This moment of faith is covertly present in the lower forms of cognition everywhere where a universal is asserted on the ground of the particular that is incongruent with it. Where a universal law asserts in virtue of the incompletely given particular, where the incomplete premiss of induction is therefore given validity as a complete one, there the universal is brought forward in that the empirical is supplemented in virtue of something a priori, that is, in virtue of a claim of the *being* to unity and lawfulness. And what thus already shows itself where in a lower sphere a *relative universal* comes forward, shows itself still more plainly where the *universal in the highest sense*, the *total existence's* universal principle, is grasped by cognition out of incomplete presuppositions. For since one goes beyond experience's unavoidable incompleteness, the unity-principle of an existence not exhausted by experience is grasped, not as that whose certainty experience secures, but as that which is reached by a necessary postulate out of the individual consciousness, which without it would lose its hold upon itself, become uncertain of its own unity, be confused within itself. This postulate of the principle — which as existence's principle is the human spirit's principle of life — comes forward also in that cognition which is the presupposition of the primitive ethical choice by which the self constitutes itself as an ethical self; and just as, therefore, the cognition upon which this choice rests encloses the moment of faith, so this moment is present also in that cognition for which the incomplete premisses of the particular ethical action acquire validity as complete ones, as an action's *ratio sufficiens*.

In this — that it is a demand proceeding with necessity from the being's own source, and a demand which encloses the immediate acknowledgement of what is demanded — the faith which cognition encloses agrees with the faith which has been determined as the distinguishing mark of the religious. But the faith which is present in cognition itself must have the character of the *rational*. In demanding the Absolute, its demand rests upon the thinking human being's consciousness of itself; it does not come into conflict with that consciousness, but confirms it. Faith as rational faith becomes a faith in that which is higher than the individual, in that it is the principle which grounds the



individual spirits and the whole of existence; but which, in being determined as higher, is at the same time determined as of the same essence, precisely because it is the *principle* of the human being and of existence. And since the being from which the religious demand of faith proceeds is an indivisible unity, there lies in this incontrovertibly that this demand, in order in truth to express the being's claim, cannot stand in conflict with any true expression of the being, and therefore not with thought, with cognition. Faith in the sense of the in truth religious can therefore not be a faith which stands in principle opposed to knowledge; by this disharmony in principle it would show itself not to have its source in the essential. This faith must, in virtue of the being's unity, stand in harmony in principle with knowledge; but in virtue of the human spirit's determinateness by finitude, faith must, as *anticipating the result*, acquire an *abiding* significance as something necessary for the human spirit. It is the form of the indispensable anticipation of certainty; it is the demand grounded in essence, which has the being's own necessity; it is therefore not like an uncertain knowledge, but like an inference without premisses which nevertheless has incontrovertible certainty, because the premisses are hidden in the being itself. But precisely therefore, precisely because faith draws its certainty from this source in the being, it cannot come into conflict with what springs clearly and transparently from the same source. Where, therefore, that which is posited as a determination of faith incontrovertibly conflicts with knowledge — and it does so when it conflicts not merely with this or that determination of knowledge, but with what makes knowledge knowledge, with *knowledge's principle, the principle of grounding and of necessity* — there it cannot have truth. But in such conflict with knowledge's very principle stands, for example, faith in the miracle, when the miracle is taken in the sense in which positive religion takes it, not in the effaced and falsified sense in which it is taken by a half-theological inverted speculation.

When "faith" at the stage of the positive religions appears with a claim to unconditional validity, then it must support this claim either upon its divine origin or upon its springing from what is innermost and most essential in the human spirit. If it supports the claim upon its springing from the transcendent divine — and only when the divine is so apprehended do the two standpoints fall outside one another — then faith with its supernatural origin and its supernatural content must be posited as raised above all knowledge and at the same time as standing in opposition to all knowledge. But since knowledge is seen as an expression of that human nature which has its springing from God, there arises not merely a discord between the divine's opposed forms of revelation, in faith and in thought, but there arises an unabridged and unabridgable discord in the

human spirit, which is to deny one expression of essence in order to acknowledge an effect proceeding from the same source from which the human being itself has sprung. If then, in order to maintain the necessity of acknowledging “revelation”, reference is made to the demand of personality, to a norm within personality, then the last of the standpoints indicated above has hereby been put in the place of the first. But when faith then rests upon the being’s inescapable claim, then what was said above holds again: that this being’s unity must preserve the harmony between the expressions of the being; and a harmony is then required between faith’s content and what is essential in knowledge. As surely as there have been, and constantly can be, false forms of the positively religious — forms of doctrine and cultus which most deeply offend the moral consciousness<sup>\*)</sup> — and as surely as conscience can be entangled and unclear in the individual, so surely is a norm required which cannot be sought in something absolutely heterogeneous with knowledge, but must be sought in knowledge’s negative corrective, in that veto of knowledge which must retain its validity; because, when knowledge is denied, that regulative is lost by which a distinction can be drawn between the true faith grounded in the being and that which is only an expression of finite craving and desire, of something unessential and particular in human nature. Knowledge’s relation to the proposition of faith may be such that knowledge must halt at a *non liquet*; but knowledge’s relation can never become such that it must approve what indisputably contradicts its *principle*, annihilates it as knowledge.

d) In cognition, as cognition is according to its truth, there is finally present that moment of *self-surrender* which characterised the in truth religious relation. In all true cognition there is a purification of thought, a surrender of individual entanglement, opinion and prejudice — in one word, of thought’s selfishness; there is in it a self-surrender to truth’s absolute power. And this self-surrender, which is present in all true cognition, shows itself most clearly in that relation in which cognition, in virtue of the being’s demand of faith, surrenders itself to the infinite that satisfies the being’s need. In this surrender, which is conditioned by an inner necessity of the being, cognition is in unity with the will; and in being itself infinitised in the surrender, cognition clarifies that will whose choice is determined by the same power of the being.

e) The result of what has been developed is therefore that cognition in its truth stands in an essential relation of unity to the religious in its ideal determinateness, to the religious faith which is the expression of the human being’s infinite demand. Under the conditions of finitude of the human spirit there is indeed as it were an interval between

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<sup>\*)</sup>It is here sufficient to recall the Near Eastern religions.

faith and knowledge, but an interval which must be able to be traversed by knowledge. A discord in principle, unabolishable, becomes an impossibility, because that faith which abolished knowledge's essential determination would precisely thereby show itself as not according with faith's own essence. Under the changing of its historical forms faith has a development, and its essential connection with knowledge shows itself in this, that this development of faith is not torn loose from that of knowledge, is not without the liberating knowledge.

### 3. The Relation of the Will and of Action to the Religious according to its Ideal Determinateness.

In determining the relation of the will and of action to the religious, the same standpoints will have to be brought to bear as were emphasised in the foregoing with respect to cognition.

a) There is then first to be brought out that the possibility of an absolute relation to the Absolute through the will is present, in that the will, in its harmony with cognition and in its being clarified through by the universal, has the capacity to preserve its object's true infinity — a capacity which would have to be denied if one let an absolute heterogeneity separate the will from cognition, or if, on the ground of an unclear representation of the being's "defectiveness", an *abiding* irrational element in the will were postulated. The Absolute is present as absolute in the will's form as *the good*, and man's willing of the good is in unity with the cognition of it. As this willing of the Absolute as the good impresses itself in action, this action acquires — as will be more closely developed in what follows — the shape of a realisation of the good in the form of the human being, governed by the will's unconditional submission to the Absolute's demand; so that this realising, through the unconditional submission, becomes the expression of the realisation of essential unity with the divine (ὁμοιωθῆναι θεῷ), and therefore the form of an absolute relation of will to the Absolute.

b) The *absolute significance* of true willing and of true acting for the human spirit shows itself immediately, in that the will as *essence*-willing conditions the unfolding of the human being's endowment in real actuality, and constitutes the true relation to the Absolute. As shown above, this twofold standpoint comes together into an inseparable unity.

When, in the development of the ethical's coming into being in the individual, the expression was used that the self in the ethical choice chooses and wills *itself absolutely*,

there was a pointer to this: that such choosing is possible only through the self's standing in a *relation of essential unity to the Absolute*; for only in virtue of such a relation can it be chosen absolutely. That expression must be taken as the starting point, because, if we determined the object of the choice as the absolute idea of the good, the choice of this as that which is to be realised in *human* action would be identical with the choice of the *humanly good*, of the *ideally human*. In this the absolute idea is for man in *the determinateness of his essence*, and in being realised through the free will, actuality is given to the idea. Beyond the determination of the ideally human as the task of human action we cannot come. We can realise only that Absolute which is *our* absolute essence, actualise only that ideal which is *our* ideal. From the determination of the ethical task as the realisation of the idea of the good as such we are at once led back to the limit indicated, by the fact that what realises must be congruent with what is to be realised; the Absolute can then be *positively* realised by us only in so far as it expresses itself in the determinateness of our essence. But this limitation of the positive expression for the idea's realisation through the will does not exclude, but precisely presupposes, another negative form of realisation, in which the idea makes itself felt *as such*. If we see the human individual ordered as a member into a principle-determined organised totality, then it follows indeed from its determinateness as a single organic member that it can positively express the principle only through the active unfolding of the individuality's own essence; but in the form of negation (self-surrender) it expresses the whole as whole, the principle as principle, in virtue of the whole's and the principle's presence within it in the abstract form of possibility. Through that determination of the ethical choice and the ethical task which was our starting point there is therefore a pointer to the relation to the Absolute as that by which the self in its ideality can become an absolute task to itself, and which acquires presence in the ethically unfolded self; and the absolute significance of ethical willing and acting therefore shows itself from a twofold standpoint.

To the same result we are led when we start from the other expression for the ethical choice: that the self in that choice chooses *itself according to its essential determinateness*. For the choice of the self according to its essence is a choice of the being *according to its total concretion*, and therefore according to its determinateness *as an organic member in a totality of existence*. In cognising itself in this determinateness, the self is from the beginning in relation to that principle which is the governing principle of life of the total existence. The I's self-assertion in the ethical choice is only through the principle's working through the I, and in that the I asserts itself, but asserts itself in its being ordered into the totality, its self-assertion is only as self-surrender to the principle. And what

holds of the I's relation in the ethical choice holds of its relation in the particular ethical action, for which this choice forms the foundation. As the ethical wins concreteness, and ethical willing forms itself as that willing of the being according to its completeness which has been clarified by true cognition, the relation is at every point posited to that totality into which the self as ethical freely orders itself, and to the totality's principle. The relation which was posited in the ethical choice, when the ethically a priori first acquired validity for the will, is preserved as this a priori wins fullness in the concrete action. The twofold standpoint for the ethical's absolute significance thus gathers itself once more into unity.

When the relation to the Absolute which is constituted in the ethical choice is posited as preserved everywhere in ethical action, this leads to an essential consequence — already drawn above from another standpoint — for the conception of the *particular* ethical relations. From the fact that in these relations in their singularity there is at every point a relation to the Absolute working through them, it follows that the particular ethical relations, which in their isolation would have to be determined as merely relative relations, become relations with absolute significance, expressions of the absolute relation. The absolute relation is seen as comprehending all the ethical relations, as indwelling in them, and as unfolding through them a concrete content and winning the shape of actuality. Thereby the particular ethical relations acquire a higher significance; and in apprehending them in this significance the subject relates itself religiously to the ethical, which now in its articulation acquires absolute validity, becomes an absolute end for the subject.

It is only another expression for the same thing when it was said that the ethical can never as a whole be given up for a religious τέλος which as an absolute should raise itself above everything ethical. It cannot, because the ethical is an expression of essence, because through its relation to the Absolute it has absolute significance, and because it stands in indissoluble connection with the religious. In the collision in actuality between the different forms of the ethical, the ethical from one sphere may give way to the ethical from another which comes forward with the right of the higher universal; but in resigning a single one of the ethical relations — which, as members in the ethical totality, are according to their essence absolute relations — the resignation of the particular relation is in virtue of the ethical totality, which in the resignation *integrates itself*. The resignation of the particular ethical relation is therefore in virtue of the ethical itself; there arises no absolute relation outside the ethical, but the Absolute becomes omnipresent within the ethical.

c) In the ethical thus apprehended — the expression of true, essential willing and acting — the moment of faith has already been shown to be present. It has been shown that it comes forward not merely in the ethical choice's first grasping of the Absolute, but everywhere in the choice's confirmation in repetition, in every ethical resolution in which the individual determines itself to action in spite of cognition's incompleteness and the uncertainty of realisation, of the outcome; and it comes forward likewise in that the individual, under the incomplete realisation of the ethical demand, acknowledges in the indwelling, through-working principle — with which it is in unity through love's self-surrender — that which ethically completes.

d) The moment of self-surrender in the ethical has already been touched upon, in that the negative form for the realisation of the absolute good was indicated, and in that it was shown that the self's assertion of itself, as an assertion of the self according to its essence's *complete* determinateness — according to which it is a moment in a whole governed by the principle — became one with a self-surrender of love and of resignation to that principle by which the self's essence is, and in which it first finds itself again according to the truth of its essence. This holds with respect to the first ethical choice and to each particular ethical action. Since now ethical self-assertion is self-assertion through self-surrender, *love* is the principle of the ethical; and since the self is seen in relation to the Absolute and to the spiritual wholeness of life into which it is ordered, love's object becomes the Absolute, the principle, and man *as man* (the neighbour). In the relation of love to man the relation of love to the Absolute is revealed: in the ethical-religious relation to humanity there is a relation to the Absolute, which is humanity's ground of life. In this love of the Absolute and of man *as man*, self-love is transfigured and man's innermost essence revealed. "Only that man is something who loves something, and what a man is shall be known by what he loves". (Feuerbach).

e) Thus the result with respect to the will's relation to the religious becomes the same as with respect to cognition's. The relation between the will in its truth — the essence-willing at work in ethical action — and the religious according to its ideal determinateness is a relation of unity, and must be so, because a fundamental function of the being cannot contradict what expresses the human being's deepest claim, its infinite demand.

#### 4. The Reconciliation of the Human Spirit in the Ethical-Human Life Resting upon True Cognition.

When human life is unfolded in harmonious unity of true cognition and true action; when cognition in its truth bears within itself faith according to the ideal significance of that concept; when the ethical action, in which the human being according to its concretion finds its realisation, has as ethical action the true stamp of the religious; and when finally the human being through cognition and action stands in relation to an existence and to a principle of existence from which all dualistic dividing has been removed — then the conditions are present without which spirit cannot find rest and reconciliation. What proceeded immediately from the essence of the human spirit was a striving after the realisation of its inner infinity as a true infinity; and this realisation can take place only on the conditions that spirit's activities are not divided, that they do not follow heterogeneous laws, and that spirit in its relation to existence and to the principle is not hindered by the finitude-barrier of a dualism. But in the true cognition of the Absolute, of the totality of existence and of the self; in the true ethical willing, which equally accentuates the self's self-assertion and its ordering into the totality, its spirit-side and its nature-side; in the true religious relation, which as the absolute relation penetrates the relative ones and in them wins concretion — in these this concrete infinity is present; and since cognition, morality and religiousness are harmoniously bound together, the condition is brought about under which spirit's original striving can come to rest, under which spirit's reconciliation with itself in its actuality can take place — a reconciliation which must be lacking so long as spirit is divided by conflicting powers, so long as consciousness is split within itself, at every moment torn asunder by doubt about cognition's truth and about action's validity. Only through that harmonious realisation of all the powers of the life of spirit does human life also become in truth a *human* life according to the full significance of that concept; and the character of humanity reveals itself in the *universal* love of humanity, of the human *as* human.

When at this point of the development — where *guilt*, the breach in the ethical, and the possibility of restitution in spite of that breach, have not yet been treated — reconciliation is spoken of, then of course this concept is partly to be taken in a more abstract, more metaphysical sense: in the sense it must acquire when one starts from infinity as an essential determination, and when the form is sought under which the striving after infinity that has proceeded from the ground of the human being can find its satisfaction. And partly the actuality of reconciliation remains as yet only *hypothetical*, in

that only the general conditions are indicated *without which it does not become* thinkable. But when in what follows reconciliation is developed in more concrete determinateness as *the reconciliation of guilt*, then this more concrete determination must have that more abstract one for its presupposition and condition; it will not abolish it, but fill it out.

In the sense in which reconciliation is spoken of at this point of the development, this concept designates first *spirit's reconciliation within itself*, as grounded in spirit's inner harmony, in the inner unity of all the functions of spirit, in the being's undivided working. This conscious harmony, resting upon true cognition, and the reconciliation which it encloses, differ essentially from the immediate harmony of beauty of *the Greek consciousness* with its illusory reconciliation. In the Greek spirit's harmony of beauty the oppositions were brought to unity only in an illusory manner, precisely because the form of union was beauty's immediacy, the *immediate* connection of the *originally different*. As soon as this harmony, which was there for intuition, was to be determined by thought, the oppositions parted; and Greek thought's determinateness by the form of intuition let the parted oppositions become fixed in the separation without being able to bring about a higher reconciliation. Therefore Greek consciousness hovers between the immediate unity of beauty and the unreconciled opposition which unavoidably succeeds it; and because that unity of beauty in its immediacy does not have the true form of the life of spirit, spirit lacks in it the deeper inwardisation, and precisely therefore that inner infinity which is the condition of the in truth ethical; and likewise there is lacking the possibility that life's concrete content can unfold itself for the ethical consciousness as a principle-determined unity. Since that unity which we have determined as the unity of the in truth human life — as a freely acquired unity, transparent for cognition, resting upon another determination of the fundamental relation in the human and in existence — is secured against dividedness, it encloses the possibility of that reconciliation which the Greek spirit, in virtue of its form of consciousness, had to lack.

To the determination of the human spirit's reconciliation within itself there attaches itself then the determination of its *reconciliation with its divine principle*; and this determination of reconciliation shows itself to stand in necessary connection with the first, in that only in spirit's reconciliation with its indwelling principle can its inner reconciliation become complete — just as, conversely, the reconciliation with the principle, which is the undivided spirit's reconciliation, can be accomplished only as spirit wins the inner reconciliation. Reconciliation with the principle takes place in that the unity of essence becomes conscious and finds its expression, negative and positive; it takes place in that man's relation to the Absolute becomes an absolute relation, through the



unconditionedness of faith and of self-surrender. For the reconciled consciousness the Absolute is the through-working power of life which, in virtue of the unity of essence, can unconditionally govern human thought and determine human will, and in which the self in the highest sense can find itself again. How this finding-again becomes possible in spite of guilt it will be the task of the following Section to show.

The human spirit's reconciliation is finally to be apprehended as its *reconciliation with existence and within existence*. It acquires this determination in that man becomes conscious of himself as ordered into an organic existence whose principle is the human being's principle, whose governing laws are reason's inviolable laws, and in that he joins himself in love with that wholeness of life in which he constitutes a member.

When it has now become clear from the foregoing that what is the *conditio sine qua non* for spirit's true reconciliation, for its reconciliation in actuality, is present in that form of religiousness which we may call *the religiousness of humanity*, then it will also become clear that it cannot be found within the positive religions.

What prevents this is, in one word, the limitation by *finitude* in the positively religious. The striving after the in truth infinite, which is the distinguishing mark of the religious in the ideal sense, is also the moving power in the historically appearing positive forms of religion; but this striving acquires, as has been shown in another place<sup>\*)</sup>, its limitation by finitude through the peculiar formal determinateness of the theoretical and practical spirit at the stage of these religions.

That the human spirit, at the stage of the positive religions, must lack the conditions for reconciliation shows itself from the various standpoints from which the concept of reconciliation was apprehended above.

The human spirit at the stage of the positive religions *cannot* attain the *inner reconciliation*, spirit's harmonious unity with itself. It cannot, because the functions of spirit are in conflict with one another and within themselves, and because this conflict is such as cannot be abolished. Cognition and will, both of which are held fast in a determinateness by finitude, must abidingly diverge; between knowledge and faith there arises an insoluble contradiction, and likewise between the action determined by the true cognition of the being's law and the action which is fulfilment of the supranatural principle's arbitrary command. This finds its expression also in the fact that the positive religion's determinateness by finitude makes the religious relation — the relation to the transcendent divine — into a *particular* relation, which separates itself from the other essential and, as such, warranted human relations, and negates them in laying claim

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<sup>\*)</sup>Cf. Problemet om Tro og Viden, p. 33.

to spirit's whole power. The reconciliation which spirit was to attain in the exclusive God-relation would — if a reconciliation could be thought where something essential is sought to be negated — at all events not be able to become a reconciliation *within actuality*, not the reconciliation within itself of the spirit existing in the concretion of actuality. It would become a reconciliation in a faith which, as relating itself to the supranatural, loses knowledge from sight, and in an action in which the ethical is absorbed into an abstract asceticism or into an arbitrary statutory element.

Nor can the human spirit at the stage of the positive religions attain the full reconciliation *with its principle*. This shows itself whether we look to the human spirit's conditions or to the determinateness of the divine. If, with respect to the human spirit's conditions, we leave aside what has already been touched upon — the opposition of the functions of spirit, which must prevent spirit from entering into the in truth absolute relation — then there is a particular hindrance to such a relation in the unclarified drive-like element which, in virtue of the determinateness by finitude of cognition and will, and in virtue of the divergence of will and faith from cognition, remains over at this standpoint. For the drive-like as such, which is preserved in the affect of fear and hope in the form in which that affect comes forward in the religions, conceals unconsciously, in seeking its satisfaction, a residue of egoism, which can be removed only by the clarification of the drive through true cognition, by the bringing about of spirit's inner unity, transparent to itself. — If we look to the conception of the divine at the stage of the positive religions, then it has been shown<sup>\*)</sup> how the form of representation brings an abiding determinateness by finitude into that conception. And this determinateness by finitude in the transcendent divine then unavoidably entails that man's relation to the divine cannot become in truth absolute. The unconditional self-surrender, freed from all egoism, must be lacking; for it can be found only where man relates himself to the in truth infinite. At the stage of the positive religions the true relation of subjectivity can find no place either. The subject is here, in the religious relation, determined by an other for the subject, which therefore — although itself determined as subject, as personality — becomes, on account of the transcendence, of the separation of essence, something objective for the subject. Only when the relation is determined by immanence does the relation of subjectivity become in the fullest sense a relation of subjectivity.

Finally, the human spirit at the stage of the positive religions cannot attain reconciliation *with and within existence*. What hinders this in this respect is first and foremost the representation of *the miracle*. By this representation, which, as has been shown in

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<sup>\*)</sup>Cf. Problemet om Tro og Viden, pp. 35 f.

another place<sup>\*)</sup>, finitises the divine and brings a discord into God, there is brought also a discord and a contradiction into existence; and this inner contradiction of existence — its essencelessness, posited by the miracle, which yet must at every moment as it were be revoked<sup>\*\*)</sup>, if only to be posited anew — prevents spirit from finding rest in this existence, which shows itself as in a confusing double light for thought and will. And were the religious consciousness, out of this doubleness, to grasp the representation of the natural's essencelessness, then spirit would be referred to seeking its life's goal through a flight from natural existence, through a denial of it; but of a reconciliation within natural existence — back to which the human being's nature-side *must* constantly draw spirit — there could be no question.

From the standpoint here brought to bear it therefore becomes the *provisional* result that what is the *indispensable* condition for the possibility of reconciliation is present only in that form of religiousness which is the highest expression of the human. So far, then, as this provisional result is not overturned by the *definitive* determination of the conditions of reconciliation, this form of religiousness will show itself as the realisation of religion's concept, as the adequate expression from that which is striven after in the positive religions.

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By this result there is a pointer, then, to our last and most difficult task: through a treatment of the central ethical-religious problems — the problems of the freedom of the will, of the possibility and actuality of evil, and of evil's abolition in reconciliation — to maintain the life-significance, the actuality-significance, of the standpoint indicated. From a starting point in knowledge there is to be sought a solution of these problems which satisfies ethically and religiously; and the given conception of the fundamental relation of the human is to be made more concrete and deepened in such a way that, in fulfilling the demand of the knowing spirit, it fulfils the deepest demand of the moral and religious spirit. While the breach in the life of the human spirit through guilt is acknowledged, the in truth absolute relation to the Absolute is to show itself as capable of being preserved, and the possibility of the true and full reconciliation is to be maintained — and maintained as something that can become an object of cognition. Reconciliation, whose possibility was shown from the human spirit's universal essential determinateness, is to be maintained also from its most concrete determinateness in actuality.

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<sup>\*)</sup>Cf. Problemet om Tro og Viden, p. 35.

<sup>\*\*)</sup>The same work, pp. 79 ff.



### III.

## The Central Ethical-Religious Problems, Apprehended from the Standpoint of Knowledge.

The presupposition and foundation for the solution of these problems from the standpoint indicated must be the development of the mutually conditioning concepts: *the concept of the Absolute*, and the concept of *the human being*. The determination of the concept of the Absolute must have a footing in the determination of the human as that which is the highest form of finite existence, and particularly in the determination of that form of subjectivity which appears in liberated form in human self-consciousness. The human then becomes, from this standpoint, *principium cognoscendi* for the divine. But when the human being is definitively to be determined according to its peculiarity and its fundamental relations, then the concept of the Absolute as the human being's *principle* must become the condition — so that what as *principium essendi* has the priority definitively acquires it also as *principium cognoscendi*, since for thought, which reaches the Absolute from finitude, the Absolute becomes that which, as resting in itself and having certainty in itself, explains what has being through it. The concept of the *Absolute* becomes therefore the fundamental one.

### 1. The Concept of the Absolute.

For the concrete determination of the concept of the Absolute, finite existence as a whole becomes the foundation, since the Absolute is to be apprehended as this existence's principle, and is to be so determined that it explains the fact of the existence grounded by it, while it is cognised as that which, as principle, explains itself, in that it is its own

ground and rests in itself.

That the Absolute is apprehended as existence's principle acquires partly the significance that it is apprehended as the *principle of being* for existence, i.e. as existence's springing-forth, its ground; and partly the significance that it is apprehended as existence's *goal*, its law and its norm. And as existence's τέλος the Absolute is again determined partly as the teleologically working, partly as the ethically determining (as ethical ideal). But these different ways of viewing the apprehension of the principle are to be seen in their inner unity.

Since the Absolute is to be determined as *principle of being*, there comes forward first the relation between the *ideal and the real* in existence. The existence which is immediately given for human consciousness, and which provides the filling for the self's first consciousness of itself in time, is real, natural existence. This existence is to be explained by the Absolute, and the springing-forth of its being is to be sought in the Absolute's determinations. But the determination of reality points back, beyond itself, to the ideal. If the determination of reality is held fast in its isolation, and in the form which is necessary for the explanation of actuality's concrete manifoldness, then it leads us to the concept of *the atoms*, as the original independent realia which in their unchangeableness are what lies at the foundation of all existence's manifoldness. But precisely this concept — which immediately encloses a contradiction in that the atom as independent, eternal and unchangeable is posited in a being absolute and closed within itself, while in its manifoldness and its finite determinateness by quality it is posited as something relative — leads, when the relations into which the atom enters are thought through, beyond the merely real to something ideal. In order that the phenomena of existence may be explained, it must be laid down that the atoms enter into constantly changing connections, and that through mutual communication of motion they become members in that infinite chain of causes and effects which comprehends all real existence. But in the atom's nature as closed within itself and unchangeable no impulse to such relations — relations enclosing a change — can be thought to lie; for even if the atoms are equipped with original forces, the atom's unchangeableness will condition the unchangeableness of the working of force. The constant change in real existence, which as a fact is indisputable, must then unavoidably be thought to have its source outside the atoms as single ones; but this would — since at this standpoint the thought of a supranatural factor must fall away — be in the totality of the really existent, in nature as a whole, so that the change would come about through an activity of the whole. But as soon as the determination of totality is brought in, as the expression of a

real unity and not merely of the aggregate's apparent unity, which could not explain the fact, then one goes beyond the *merely* real and posits something ideal; for the totality *as totality* is *ideally* determined in that it is and works in its parts, its moments, *as totality*, and thus relates itself through them to itself, and in the self-doubling within this relation — which is the fundamental form of ideality — asserts itself. The fact of change therefore points to the totality with its ideal unity, for which the atoms — which as the original principles of real existence had to be posited as independent and unchangeable — become serving moments. — To the same result we are led also through the consideration of the relation of causality, which in spite of the atoms' independence and unchangeableness acquires validity for them, in that the atoms, as communicating motion to one another, are apprehended as functioning members in a chain of causes and effects, even though the relation thereby posited becomes as it were a superficial one, not touching the atom's interior. The concept of cause is then here reduced to the concept of the exclusively real cause, the thing-cause, the finite cause. The cause so determined must have the impulse to activity from outside; its working is cause of another in that it is effect of an other: it is cause and effect with respect to something different.

Since now what is acted upon is, in virtue of the conceptually necessary connection between action and reaction, seen as reacting, the concept of cause leads to the concept of a *reciprocal action*; but at the standpoint indicated the relation of reciprocal action, like the relation of cause, must become a superficial relation, in which the members of the reciprocal action — even if the substrates of the activity are represented as in inner unity with the activity — are not to be absorbed: they are to preserve a being as given outside the reciprocal action, are to enter with only one side of their existence into the determinate relation of reciprocal action. As soon, however, as a reciprocal action is laid down — which must necessarily happen as soon as the concepts of cause and effect are laid down, however far the origin of the activity remains inexplicable on the presupposition — it encloses consequences which unavoidably lead beyond the finite relations and the finite thing-causes, to an apprehension of the concept of cause answering to that concept of totality which stepped into the place of the concept of the atom as the concept of what is primitive in existence. What can enter into a relation of reciprocal action with another points, by that very relation, to an essential connection so far as the reciprocal action reaches. But when now every thing whatever is only what it is in its relations — when a holding fast of it as a thing in and for itself, as a relationless thing, makes it a contentless abstraction — then the thing must according to its *whole* essence enter into a comprehensive active relation, into a *total reciprocal action*. And

since reciprocal action thus comprehends the whole of real existence, there is through the comprehensive reciprocal action a pointer to a comprehensive connection of essence; and the single thing, the single real cause, which at every point is at once conditioning and conditioned, presupposes its own condition, standing in essential connection with it, just as it is presupposed by that condition as a condition essentially bound up with it. Since now none of the real things standing in essential connection, as mutually presupposing one another, becomes *primitive* cause, the relation of causality points back, through the reciprocal action of the conditioned finite thing-causes, to something which comprehends the essence of them all, conditions them all and determines their reciprocal action, as primitive cause. In the relation of subordination to this primitive cause, which works through them as *indwelling*, the finite real causes become *secondary* causes, *intermediate causes*, causes in a *derived* sense. As the principle for the active totality of the essentially connected reals — for that totality which, as being in its moments, is itself — the primitive cause becomes *ideal* cause; it becomes cause in relation to itself (*causa sui*) and end for itself (*causa finalis*). By its relation to the conditioned causes the ideal cause asserts itself as the *unconditioned*, i.e. *that which conditions itself*, that which posits its own conditions: the system of the real causes. Comprehended by the totality, as its members, these become, in another sense than in the finite reciprocal action, at once cause and effect: the series of causes and effects is bent back into itself in such a cycle that the single members, in relating themselves as moments of the totality to one another — not in relation to something different, but in relation to the same, namely to the totality — are at once causes and effects, conditions for the unconditioned, but conditions posited by the unconditioned, which through them relates itself to itself and is *principle for its own teleological realisation* in that it is *principle for all actuality*.

When thus real existence, even when apprehended one-sidedly from the standpoint of reality, pointed back with necessity to something ideal as that which unites and grounds it, then its explanation is to be sought in an *ideally* determined Absolute; but in order that this may be *the ground of real existence*, the point of attachment for the real must be shown in the Absolute's own determination of ideality, so that the ideal principle is seen as an *ideally-real* principle. This connection between the determination of ideality and that of reality in the Absolute shows itself first *in abstracto* through this, that the determination of ideality itself encloses the relation *to the other*, through which the ideal is in relation to itself. If, then, the ideal's other, its opposite, is *the real*, then we must posit this determination — from which we *cannot abstract*, and which we saw as pointing back to the ideal — as *essential to the Absolute itself*, as demanded by it,



and as an original determination in it. But when in this way, through the concept of *otherness*, which encloses the *necessity of opposition*, we come to the determination of the real, then this opposition between ideal and real is as yet *only formal*; the real's *concrete determinateness* is not yet explained, and only when that too is explained by the ideal principle's fundamental determinations is the principle in actuality the ground of explanation for real existence. The explanation of the real's essential determinations we find in accentuating that the ideal principle, as such, in asserting itself as *principium sui* through its other, is *energy*. The determination of energy, which lies in the determination of ideality, presupposes, like that determination, *the other*, through the relation to which energy asserts itself as energy. This inner opposition of the ideal energy, which is grounded in its *essence*, is the *passive*; but this determination of the passive, grounded in energy, does not denote absolute passivity, but a passivity which has the possibility of activity within it, which is like a slumbering activity, like an activity which, having gone to rest in passivity, bears energy within itself as real possibility. A passivity of this kind is demanded by energy, is the condition of energy's actuality, and is only through energy, is thought only through it. But such a passivity, such a hidden energy veiled beneath inertia, is the fundamental stamp of the *material*, of that which mechanism determines as *dead being*, as *passive matter*. Dead, passive in an absolute sense, an existent cannot be; for all being requires, in order to *assert* itself, *being, working and activity*. But the concept *passive matter* can acquire its validity in the sense that activity is present only as possibility while its actuality is conditioned by what falls outside the material so determined. And the concept of the material coincides with that of the *totality-less*, since totality — also as *relative totality* — by its ideal relation to itself, by its being for itself, points immediately to the determination of energy, so that the passive can only be that which lacks totality. But the lack of the ideal relation to itself which lies in the determination of the totality-less encloses in turn the determination of *externality*, a being bound by externality's forms, governed by *the separation of space and time*. As determined by these forms the material exists as material in the separation of the objectively single elements of matter; and the being of these as isolated is not merely for the abstracting thought which disregards the conditions of concrete existence and separates the element from the totality; rather it has its relative validity in the objective, the real, in virtue of the fundamental relation in the principle itself.

Thus there shows itself, in the principle's own determination of ideality, a point of attachment for the determination of reality in existence. How this determination of reality is now governed by the ideal, is *idealised*, but *without losing its essentiality*, and

how *the real* as a determination *in the Absolute* is related to *the real in existence*, will emerge from developments in what follows.

At this point the conception put forward is to be more closely elucidated through comparisons. From those conceptions which from the outset postulate ideality and reality as primitive determinations in the Absolute, but which *merely demand* this union, or restrict themselves to substituting the concept of reality for the otherness demanded by ideality, the conception indicated distinguishes itself in this: that it deduces the *peculiar* determinations of the real from the determination of ideality, and that it can therefore lead to the cognition of a unity in which the real is governed by the grounding ideal, without being compelled to postulate a contradictory uniting medium between oppositions originally separated in their peculiarity — separated by the lack of a conceptual connection — and irreconcilable in their immediate heterogeneity.

To the representation of a *creation* the conception indicated stands in this relation, that it appropriates from that representation the truth *that the real is grounded in the ideal, the spiritual, and determined by it*; while it sees what is untrue in the representation of creation in this, that it does not let the real be of essential significance for the ideal's being, does not let the ideal Absolute in its unconditionedness condition itself through the real, and does not acknowledge this real's essential unity with the ideal. It holds fast that the unconditioned is unconditioned only as that which conditions itself through a system of real conditions; that the Absolute is *principium sui, causa sui*, in that it is principle for an other, and that this other, as the principle's other, can be only that ideal principle's *own* determination.

Already when we started from the side of reality — and more determinately, from the abstractly apprehended side of reality in existence — we were therefore referred to the determination of ideality in the Absolute, and the immanent development of this concept led to more concrete determinations. But these come forward *directly* when existence is seen from the standpoint of the *highest forms of existence*, from the standpoint of *the living*, which is inexplicable by the merely real, and more closely: from the *standpoint of the psychical and the spiritual*. Since life acquires its highest expression in human life, and human life becomes *self-conscious* life, self-consciousness — when its *ground* is to be sought — points back to the Absolute's determination as *absolute subjectivity*. To this determination there has already been a pointer above, through the determination of the principle as *causa sui*, as the unconditioned which, in relating itself to itself through the totality of the real conditions, stands in a relation of freedom to itself. Of this determinateness of the principle, the determination of *self-*

*consciousness* is an impress, but in the *form of finitude*. This determinateness by finitude of self-consciousness shows itself from various standpoints. It shows itself in that the determination of self-consciousness encloses and presupposes that of consciousness, and thereby the I's separation from the object and from the other I's as the limiting other. It shows itself in that self-consciousness is in its actuality conditioned by the *individual organism*, and thus becomes a determination of *individuality*. And it shows itself in that self-consciousness's being-for-itself, since it rests upon a concrete but individually limited foundation, is an *abstract* doubling of the self, a being-for-itself in the form of abstract universality. Self-consciousness, as we know it in *man* — and that is, as we know it *at all* — thus shows itself as the form of limited spiritual individuality. *Immediately*, therefore, we cannot transfer the determination of self-consciousness to the Absolute without finitising the Absolute; the concept must undergo a necessary *metamorphosis*, which happens in that the finitising determinations are removed; and these are removed in that the concept of *absolute subjectivity* designates the Absolute as that which, as freed from self-consciousness's finite limitation, can be *principle for self-consciousnesses*. We can give the concept of absolute subjectivity its content by starting from the relation between reason-determined objective existence and the finite subjective. What in the latter comes forward in the form of reflection, in the relations of the relatively abstract determinations of concepts, comes forward in the objective as the objective connection of the really concrete; what comes forward in the ideal — which is according to its essence universal and exists in the form of individuality — in the form of the I's abstract universality, has its concrete counterpart in the objective in the real totality. But in this real totality's *principle of unity* this objective real, which encloses within itself the whole of the objective relations, must be reflected in a form of ideal reflection which differs in a twofold respect from the form in the human. For since this ideal reflection does not rest upon an *individual* concrete which, in excluding the rest of the concrete, could give it only the form of negativity and of relative abstraction, but since it is the form for the principle which bears the whole of the concrete within itself as its own determination, posited by it, the principle has in that reflection a being-for-itself in the form of the absolutely *concrete universality*, and is not merely reproducing in the form of abstraction but positing, producing, in the form of actuality; it does not have the opposition within itself as an abstract, formal opposition, and outside itself as a concrete, real one, but comprehends within itself, in infinitely concrete being-for-itself, the opposition of otherness unfolded in the manifoldness of real existence. In the Absolute as absolute subjectivity we therefore see that power which comprehends, bears

and works through all existence and with it all the finite existences of spirit; in whose infinitely concrete, energetic being-for-itself the source of self-consciousness lies, and in whose eternal being the infinity of space, of time and of matter is gathered together into ideality's living, content-rich unity. In this gathering into ideality's content-rich unity the Absolute is *absolutely knowing subjectivity*, as a knowing of *itself in all things*.

In the Absolute so determined we seek the explanation of the finite self-consciousness's essence, taking as our starting point the relation developed above between the determination of ideality and the determination of reality. Since existence was apprehended as the *universal totality* determined by the ideal principle, there lies in this concept the possibility of *relative totalities* within the universal one, in that the unity of the universal totality, as articulating itself, posits *particular* determinations which, precisely as *determinations of totality*, can *themselves* have the determination of *totality* within them. This concept of the relative totality, which expresses the determination of the *organic* and forms the middle term between the concept of the totality-less, the inorganic, and that of the universal totality, finds its *most adequate* expression in *human nature*, which by its inner *universality* has the possibility of becoming the foundation for that being-for-itself of the ideal which is in *self-consciousness, in the form of liberated universality*. In virtue of the being's *universality* the individual human soul has the possibility of self-consciousness, and through it the possibility of a consciousness of existence and of its principle; but since the human individual is a *relative* totality, the universality which is for-itself in consciousness acquires the form of *abstraction*, though of an abstraction *constantly integrable*, precisely because in the relative totality, as an organic member in the universal one, the universal totality and the remaining members can be present only in the form of *possibility*, not in the form of unfolded reality, in which they are only *as* universal totality and as those determinate, really formed members. Therefore self-consciousness becomes an *abstract* image of the absolute subjectivity's infinitely concrete being-for-itself: it has a determinateness by finitude within it which is explained by the principle but cannot be immediately transferred to the principle.

Through the determination of *absolute subjectivity* the Absolute shows itself, as already touched upon, as that which, in reaching out beyond the objective, relates itself to itself *and rests in itself as the unconditioned which is its own ground*. And it is in this determination of the Absolute that the connection is to show itself between what has been wished to be separated as a *merely logical-metaphysical and an ethical* determination of it. The ethical determination must have its foundation in the metaphysical, and comes forward as an ethical-metaphysical determination. With respect to this,

the connection between the *twofold* determination of *the Absolute as existence's* τέλος acquires its significance, since the determination of the Absolute as τέλος points partly to the standpoint of the *organic*, partly to *the standpoint of the ethical*; and precisely in the *organic* apprehension of existence lies the starting point for that determination in which *human freedom* is grounded.

In the determination of the Absolute as *absolute subjectivity* and as *ideal-real principle* there lies enclosed the determination of that which posits reality as determined, in its real being, by the ideal. Since the emphasis here falls upon reality's being *as* reality, as being in the fundamental forms of real existence, its determinateness by the ideal becomes a *teleological* determinateness, and the Absolute is seen from this standpoint as teleologically working. It is seen as τέλος for that development in real existence through which existence lets ideality acquire actuality within it. But in this determination the point of attachment is given for a higher one. In the teleological conversion of the determination of reality into that of ideality the concept of the *relative totality* acquires its significance: it becomes the middle term through which the conversion, the leading back, is realised. But the concept of the relative totality first finds its *completion* in the concept of the relative totality *determined by essential universality*, i.e. in the *self-conscious* human individual existence of spirit. In this the teleological working of the ideal becomes *conscious and free working*: a conscious idealising, in progressive development of thought, of the real that has been taken up, i.e. a *theoretical* working; and a conscious free forming, under progressive development of will, of reality by ideality, i.e. a *practical* working. The determination *with freedom to give ideality actuality in the real* is the *ethical's abstract* expression, but an expression which does not yet distinguish the ethical from "practical" and "poietic" activity in general. In order to express the ethical's *differentia specifica* the more abstract determination must acquire a more concrete form. Ethical action is essentially a realisation of the ideal in *the personality's side of reality* — in the drive determined by natural energy, which acquires the form of the ideal — through a *free resolution*; and the realisation of the ideal outside the personality is ethical only by being the expression of the personality's inner acting. Without this connection the ethical becomes something historical, or something practical in the ordinary sense. Since reality's being determined by ideality is posited through ethical resolution and action, and since the will, in order to be able to realise this determining, must go back to its own infinity and thereby to *its principle*, the Absolute, the *logical-metaphysical* concept of the Absolute determines itself into an *ethical-metaphysical* one: the Absolute is apprehended under the determination *the idea of the good*.

The *abstract* foundation for this determination of the idea is *ideality's relation to itself as the goal of its own energy*. But this abstract foundation acquires a more concrete shape in that the ideal's relation to itself is seen as a relation *through the real*, and in that the *real* is apprehended according to its *concrete* essential determinateness. The Absolute is seen as *the good in the metaphysical* sense, in that it is seen as that towards which the whole of real existence strives as towards *the ideal goal* by which this striving itself is; in that it is seen as that which in essential communication gives to the existent a being which is being only through the relation to the ideal. It is seen as *the good in the ethical-metaphysical* sense, in that it is seen as *the goal and norm of ethical action*, as that which in the form of individuality is to be realised through free action, as that which, as something unconditionally valid for the will, is to govern and fill out the will. That the relation to the *human will* is reflected in the Absolute's relation to itself is the condition for the Absolute's being seen as *the idea of the good in ethical* determinateness. This relation comes forward whether we determine the Absolute as that which is the norm, the law, for the human will, as that which is to be expressed through it, or whether we determine it as that which in its eternal self-realisation grounds the human wills in which it gives itself shape. Given this relation to the will, it lies near to transfer the will's determination to the divine. It has however been shown in the earlier work (pp. 165 f.) what metamorphosis must take place with this concept, as with that of knowledge, in order that it may find application to the eternal and infinite. Just as in the eternal we sought a ground of self-consciousness, so we seek in it also a ground of will; but we seek the ground of will in something freed from finitude.

With the determination of will there comes forward the determination of the Absolute as *absolute personality*. What is sought to be maintained through this determination on the side of *theology* has already been shown<sup>\*)</sup>. It is on the one side the separation, in representation, from the human; on the other side the unboundness by the universal law of necessity. What is aimed at on the side of *philosophy*, when this concept is applied, is partly the same; but partly it is also this: to obtain in the divine an ideal of will answering to the demands of the personal life; and partly, finally, this: to keep the eternally complete divine personality out of the world's becoming and development.

When there is demanded in the divine an ideal of will answering to the claims of the personal life, this demand is more closely understood thus: that since the good is to be realised in the individual's personal life, and the personal life has the form of singularity, there is to be in the ideal of the good a corresponding form of singularity; and that the

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<sup>\*)</sup>Problemet om Tro og Viden, pp. 68 f.

good is to be apprehended as a divine person with determinations of will which express personality's essence, heterogeneous with the determinations of knowledge. But in understanding the demand thus, one has partly brought to bear that abstract opposition between cognition's determinateness by universality and the will's determinateness by singularity whose falsity has already been shown; and partly it has been overlooked that the carrying through of the determination of *absolute* personality, by making God the *absolutely singular* being, would precisely annihilate the determination of God as the will's ideal; for the determinateness of the absolutely singular being can have validity for no other being than precisely for that being itself. To have recourse to a combination of the determination of omnipotence with that of the ideal of will, and to apprehend the divine will as the omnipotently commanding will whose commands, as omnipotence's commands, were to become laws for the finite will, could be of no help; for omnipotence's *arbitrary* commands cannot become the absolute ideal for the will's *essence-determined* relation of freedom.

In the application of the determination of personality to the divine, both in theology and in the various philosophical systems, the necessary *metamorphosis* which that determination must undergo in being transferred to the Absolute is either wholly forgotten or carried through only inconsistently. It has already been partly elucidated through the earlier developments, and in what follows it will be indicated what significance the determinations of *holiness*, *righteousness* and *love*, which are posited as predicates of the absolute personality, can acquire in their application to the Absolute, on the presupposition of that metamorphosis.

When, in the determination of the Absolute as personality, a particular emphasis is laid on this, that by this determination God as the eternally existent is to be kept out of the becoming and development of natural existence and of the finite spirit — which, however, from the nature of the case, none of the philosophical systems that have accentuated that determination has been able to carry through — then it will be shown in what immediately follows how, starting from the given determination of *absolute subjectivity*, it will be possible, by laying down the relation of *immanence*, to free the Absolute from becoming's imperfection and to maintain it in its absoluteness, while avoiding those contradictions which are inseparable from the determination of absolute personality. This will emerge from an investigation of *the essence of pantheism*, of its *truth* and of its *one-sidedness* in the ordinary conception.

To the name *pantheism* there clings as it were a stain, and the immediate consciousness, and particularly the religious consciousness, has an instinctive shyness of it. What

frightens one back is, on the one side, the individual's resistance to being absorbed into the Absolute — an absorption which, even when the Absolute is determined as absolute subjectivity, shows itself to consciousness as a losing of oneself in the

self-less; and on the other side it is this, that the divine, in having to comprehend all existence, seems to be degraded, to be drawn into the finite's lowliness, to go together with the transitory, even with evil. But as regards the *latter*, the pantheistic conception has never — not even where it appeared at the lower stages of development of spirit, as in the Orient — been to be understood in such a way that God should be all, in the sense of the sum total, the collective sum, of all the finite, single things. When it apprehended God as all, what was thereby understood was that God was things' abiding essence, in relation to which the finite was only as vanishing accidents which eternally alternate while the essence abides. They were to proceed from the substance and to go back into it, and through their vanishing they were to show its exaltedness and the untruth of finite being as finite. And when this essence was to find an expression in the finite, it was the most glorious thing in each kind of the finite that became the image, the symbol, for it: the excellent stands nearest to the essence and was therefore used for its designation. When it was said, then, that God is all, what was meant was not: God is the finite things; for these have, as finite, as accidents, no being: in their transitoriness their essence is revealed, and the substance shows itself as what abides in them. But by this — God is all — it was expressed that God is existence's universal essence, the absolutely universal which is indwelling in the single existences, but in such a way that to these as single no real reality belongs. Even at that standpoint, then, where spirit did not yet know how to distinguish its own essence from nature's, pantheism was not a doctrine of God's identity with the sum of the finite, but the doctrine of God's identity with the universal power of nature, over against which no finite thing has subsistence, no imperfect thing a right to be called existent. God is therefore not finitised, not drawn down into what is lowly; rather the finite is abolished over against the divine: the world, not God, vanishes. And what holds when God is apprehended as the universal power of nature, the substance of nature, holds also of the higher forms of pantheism that have appeared within the domain of philosophy, which determine God as *subject*, as *spirit*, but which let the finite spirits be taken up and abolished as moments in his essence as absolute spirit. In these forms too — whose originators, by an *arbitrary* limitation of pantheism's concept, seek to keep them outside it — God is not drawn down into the finite, but the finite vanishes in God. And as regards God's relation to *evil*, it will be attempted in what follows to show that, even though the historically given pantheistic systems have remained standing



at the dilemma of either abolishing evil's actuality or making it a determination in the divine, there is a possibility of holding fast evil's actuality *within a pantheistic view*, without letting it abolish the determination of the Absolute as the ideal of the good.

As regards the *first* of the motives emphasised above for a shyness of pantheism — the fear of letting the single being be absorbed into the divine's unity — it shows itself, on closer consideration, that this shyness is conditioned not by anything universal and pervasive in human nature, but by something peculiar, developed under determinate historical conditions. When the Indian longs for liberation from the barriers of single existence, and in order to attain it lets himself be crushed under Siva's car, or swallowed by the waves of the Ganges, or sinks his soul into the formless nothing, then that shyness is not present. When Persian poets develop a pantheistic mysticism, then self-surrender to the infinite One is a source of enthusiasm. And if we go from the Orient to Greece, we find, among that people whose peculiarity was a stamping out of the beautiful individuality, that virtually all the greatest representatives of its own peculiar thinking — including such as whose systems do not have pantheism's character — let the individual vanish, without loss and without craving, over against the eternal divine thought which animates the universe. When the Eleatics posit the One — whether it be determined as God or as the existent — as existence's wholeness, they find precisely rest and thought's repose in this thought, and Parmenides becomes a poet in uttering it. When Aristotle seeks an immortality for the human spirit, it is only for that highest form of spirit which is in individuality-less unity with the eternal divine thought resting in a νόησις τῆς νοήσεως. When the Stoics in their striving after unity let the Aristotelian Νοῦς become the world's indwelling force, and let this rational force go together with matter, then within this pantheistic unity they let individuals stand governed by a world-law which they willingly follow and under which they bow with resignation's repose. And when the Neoplatonists strive towards ecstatic unity with the divine One, then so far is it from being the case that the abolition of individual existence by this unity has anything deterrent for them, that it is on the contrary the goal of the whole life's burning longing. And within Christianity the same holds of the mystics' suffering of God, of their striving after a union in which the soul "makes itself simple" so as to have no determination separating it from the divine.

It is essentially in the modern age that we find that longing after the preservation of individuality — often appearing in sickly forms — which has the instinctive abhorrence of pantheism for its consequence; and this longing has, in the immediate consciousness, its ground in that emphasis on subjectivity peculiar to the modern age, which from the first

assumes that form, in that the spiritualistically determined individual is apprehended as infinite in its being torn loose from its natural conditions. And once such an emphasis has been laid on the preservation of individuality, the craving after it comes forward most strongly precisely in those times and among those peoples where the individual — its finitude being infinitised by egoism's interest — becomes the centre of existence, and where the infinite is pushed aside as incomprehensible or indifferent. The period of enlightenment was thus hostile to pantheism, and among the Romance nations the antipathy to it has been strongest.

When thus that instinctive shyness of pantheism has shown itself to be grounded not in a necessity in human nature but in a determinate development conditioned by peculiar historical presuppositions, then we can, unaffected by it, investigate pantheism's *essence and truth*. And when we do not limit pantheism's concept to the *imperfect and one-sided* forms of it, then we must acknowledge the pantheistic conception as *essential and necessary for philosophy*. A pantheistic element there must be in all philosophy, because no philosophy can think the infinite as being separated from and outside the finite, but — if the infinite is to preserve its infinity — must think the finite as being in it and as having truth only in it; and because all philosophy seeks cognition's unity and connection and is philosophy only so far as it pursues that unity. When thought sets about the task of finding reason in existence, then everything to which thought attains must form a unity, a connection in which no breach of immanence is found. For every higher thought to which one ascends is precisely the higher only in this, that it comprehends the lower ones, that it, as the richer and fuller, has them within itself as its moments. And what holds of every higher thought holds also of the highest: it cannot for thinking separate itself from the thoughts which are enclosed in it as its moments and which find their final grounding in its comprehensive wholeness. But this highest thought, the thought of the idea, is precisely thought's expression for the Absolute, for God. The Absolute, then, which comprehends and bears within itself the single thoughts, the thoughts of rational existence, must be thought in essential unity with that existence itself. In finding reason in existence, and in having the Absolute in reason, thinking seeks nothing outside the universe, outside the unity of existence, the corporeal and the spiritual. In this sense, then, all philosophy is pantheistic: it must hold fast the Absolute's immanence; it cannot think the Absolute outside that existence whose principle it is; it cannot think an abstract transcendence's separation of the divine, for thereby infinity would be lost. By its own nature thought is not led away from immanence's unity; but it can, through consequences of one-sided presuppositions (for

example Aristotle, Descartes), and through foreign influences, be led to break the unity; and within the pantheistic conception the unity of thoughts can take a different form. But all real philosophy is as such pantheistic in the sense indicated, as holding fast the Absolute's immanence and the untruth of finite being when, as finite being, it is separated from the abstractly transcendent divine.

In order to determine pantheism's *true* form, we single out the main forms of a *one-sided* pantheistic conception whose possibility is given in the relations of the concepts.

As the *first* one-sided form we bring out that in which the fundamental concept is the concept of *the power of nature*, more closely apprehended as the mighty one substance of nature in relation to the merely vanishing accidents. In this form of pantheism the one-sidedness comes to light *immediately*, in that the existence of spirit, the human self-consciousness, is to be set in relation to a substance which does not explain it, and in this relation to come under the determination of the vanishing accident; and *mediately* the one-sidedness shows itself in that the conception of the accidental as the merely vanishing, the powerless, reacts upon the conception of the Absolute, the substance, which — when it posits only something vanishing and reveals itself only as power over the merely powerless — itself becomes the empty and the impotent.

As the *second* one-sided form of pantheism we apprehend that in which the Absolute acquires the determination of the substance's infinite unity, which binds together within itself thought and extension. Here, indeed, through the determination of thought, the determination of spirit has been brought into the substance, the Absolute; but since the substance in its unity is to unite the *merely disparate* attributes, it becomes *as* substance the purely determinationless, that in whose differenceless unity everything merely vanishes; and its accidents, the modifications, come to occupy the same position towards it as the accidents of that substance of nature. The form of self-consciousness is not so clarified in the single thinking *modus* that it could, reacting back, determine the concept of the Absolute; self-consciousness becomes in reality only a postulated accessory to natural causality, as it were the expression of natural causality's sensing of itself.

As the *third* one-sided form we apprehend, finally, that in which the Absolute is determined as *subjectivity*, but *in such a way* that in this subjectivity's eternal process nature — whose mode of being is the untrue — becomes an eternally abolished moment, and the finite spirits — whose individuality is apprehended as resting only upon a vanishing ground of nature — become only vanishing forms in the absolute unity's eternal movement.

For the one-sidedness in these forms the corrective is to be sought in the *concrete* de-

termination of the Absolute as *absolute subjectivity*, and in such a way that the corrective is applied *within* the pantheistic conception.

The task becomes, with respect to the *Absolute*: to maintain a moment of transcendence *within* immanence; and with respect to *that which is grounded by the Absolute*: to secure to real existence and to the finite spirit a relative independence.

This twofold task is solved when the consequences are drawn of a distinction of concepts which in the foregoing has only been touched upon, because what mattered there was above all to maintain the validity of the ideal at all — of that determination which is common to the totality and to the principle by which the totality is constituted. This distinction of concepts is the distinction between *the totality of existence and the principle of existence*.

Between the principle determined as ideal-real and the whole of existence grounded by it there appears that distinction by which a moment of transcendence — in the sense in which transcendence can have validity for philosophy at all — is brought in, the emphasis falling upon *the moment of otherness*: the real, and upon *the real's form of being*. Since, as was shown above, the Absolute as ideal encloses in its concept the determination of *otherness* — as energy, energy's opposite: the passive — it must be comprehended as that which in its eternal positing of itself posits what is characterised by the determinations of otherness and of passivity, and posits it as being in reality's *essentially valid, conceptually necessary forms*, while it is at the same time thought as that which, in this relation, is eternally in a relation of unity to itself. There is therefore posited at one and the same time a twofold relation: a relation of *eternity* and a relation of *time*, a *gathering of reality into the concrete ideal's unity* and an *existence of reality in the separation of externality*; and by this twofold relation, by this twofold determination of reality, the possibility of solving the task set above is conditioned.

The separation of externality which, as essential to the real, is inseparable from existence, makes itself felt as a pervasive determination in *all* forms of the real single existences. The primary single existences, the real fundamental parts, become — as determined by the opposition of ideality and energy — materially separated elements, self-less (totality-less) and passive in the sense indicated above. And since within real existence the ideal's determining reveals itself in this, that its material elements are joined together into the relative totalities of the organic, in which a principle of life with the determination of energy and of ideality is realised, the material foundation for the realisation of this principle of life preserves, under its determinateness by the ideal, its own essential mode of being.

In the material elements, and in the relative totalities realised in temporal determinateness and spatial separation upon a material foundation, the separation of finitude in real existence comes into its right: by it the members of real existence acquire their relative independence and can assert their individual existence. The relative independence is conditioned by the form of existence, by this, that each single member has stepped out into separateness and works out from this separated being. Since all being is working, all individual being — and this has actuality only through the separation of reality — becomes a working out from an individual point of action; and such a working is what lies abstractly at the foundation of the determination of freedom, and also of the concept of freedom in the pregnant sense: of human freedom, of the will's freedom, which is the expression of the universal being's ideality and is an energy that can with consciousness be asserted against the Absolute itself.

But when the separation of finitude thus comes into its right, and the real members' relative independence makes itself felt, then, in virtue of the original relation of essence, there is through the separation a pointing back to the unity, through the relative independence to the being worked through by the universal principle.

The material elements of matter, whose being expresses the greatest opposition to the principle's unity and ideality, lack in their self-less being energy's actuality and originality and are determined by inertia, so that they express the activity slumbering in them only in relation to an other and in virtue of an impulse from outside which wakes the slumbering activity into life. But this relation to the *homogeneous* thing which wakes the activity, and which itself in its singularity does not have the source of activity within it, points back to *the aggregate of the material elements*, which, as already developed earlier, is to be determined as a *totality* which as such has the determination of energy and the conditions for the continuance of activity within it.

The single members in real existence give their individually determined being expression in an individually determined working; but this individual being is drawn into the whole's connection and determined out of it, and the single member's working, which is actualised by the working of the other members, becomes enclosed by the whole's necessity. The single starting point for an individual working therefore becomes a point of passage for a universal working, and its working is converted, through the effect of totality resulting from all the single individual activities, into the working of the principle of totality. Since what results from the working of the single acquires the determination of *activity of totality*, this determination expresses that what results is, according to the relation of essence, what grounds, the primitive; the end by which the working of the

single is determined.

When the infinity of time and of space is the form for the being of real existence, then the relation of eternity to itself is the form for the being of the ideal principle, and in the principle's being-for-itself the real, the material side of the whole of existence, is idealised. But the principle's ideality would become abstract if the determination of eternity did not reflect within itself the determination of time, and thereby ideality reflect the real's form of actuality. In that cycle of eternity in which the real proceeds from the principle in order to give the principle's ideality fullness and actuality, time and the determination of reality generally are so reflected that reality preserves its significance as actuality. The real in God is an actuality, not a fantasy-image of a "Physis in God", and in the eternal unity of real existence in God there is taken up as a moment that unity in natural existence by which natural existence at *every moment* reveals its indwelling energy. The real, which in each element of time is joined together into a whole and in that whole ideally determined, is converted through this intermediate determination, in each element of time and with reality preserved, into the absolute ideal. It is precisely upon this conversion in each element of time (time-differential) that the emphasis here falls. The totality through which it takes place becomes the intermediate determination between the real's being in the form of externality and its eternal unity in the Absolute: that intermediate determination through which this eternal unity acquires concretion by the reflex of the determinateness by externality which is preserved in it.

The relation in the Absolute between the real — which even as idealised must not be annihilated but must retain its essentiality — and the ideal can receive an elucidation through analogies from the finite, through psychological and physiological facts. In the ensouled organism spatial extension is idealised, in that in the unity of self-feeling the externality of the points of space is abolished; an affection of a single part of the organism is sensed in the ideally concentrated self; the physical, spatially determined impression is transformed into an ideal moment in the self-sensing. But the organism's being in space is not thereby annihilated, and the idealisable space subsists *as* space for sensing and sensation. — Matter is idealised in the organism, in that the sensing organism in its normal state is for itself an imponderable; but the organism does not thereby cease to be material, to be subject to the laws of gravity. — Consciousness binds the different elements of representation together into a unity of representation, to which there corresponds a unity of time out of the elements of time, in which the externality of succession is abolished; although of the elements of representation — which, as bound to a nerve-act, each require its own element of time — only one can at any moment be

at consciousness's focus, so that consciousness's affection by the single elements must have the form of succession. But while time is thus gathered into a unity of time, and in this gathering — in which succession is concentrated and thereby idealised — loses its externality, it continues to have its real validity for consciousness. — Thus these facts point to a preservation of the real's fundamental determinations while these are idealised. And when we now, with these facts as points of attachment, transfer by an inference from analogy what holds of the individual to the absolute principle of the totality of existence, then — apprehending this principle as that which according to its concept posits the real, which is its *own* essential determination, as something *essential and valid*, as a system of existence being in *essentially valid forms of existence*, and at the same time seeing it as that which, in asserting its ideality, joins this real system of existence together into that content-rich unity of ideality by which the system is grounded — we shall obtain space, time and matter, the real's fundamental determinations, as essentially valid for the Absolute, but at the same time as so idealised that a living presentness of eternity concentrates within itself the infinity of time, and that the Absolute's unity of life concentrates within itself, in a point of ideality and subjectivity, the externality of boundless space and the infinity of matter. The conception we have brought to bear of the Absolute's relation to real existence — existing with relative independence in its essentially valid forms — encloses, in the conceptual distinction between the absolute principle and the whole of existence, and in the determination of the ideal-real principle's relation of eternity to itself, a *moment of transcendence*; but in such a way that no breach of immanence is thereby made, for the connection of essence is preserved, and existence is apprehended as a totality only in virtue of the principle's indwelling. In virtue of the original relation of essence to real existence, the Absolute, when it is determined as *spirit*, is *eo ipso* to be determined as *principle of nature (idea of nature)* — by which expression it is designated as the principle for natural existence's ideal unity, for its universal totality.

By the Absolute's relation of eternity to itself the Absolute is, under its connection of essence with real existence in reality's fundamental forms, withdrawn from becoming. Its relation to the single finite thing — which, seen from the finite thing's standpoint, is in temporal determinateness — becomes, in being taken up as a moment in the Absolute's relation of eternity, an ideal-real determination in the concrete eternity, and as such freed from externality. And with the Absolute's freedom from becoming its freedom from finitising limitation stands in connection. By the idealisation of the real, which precisely confirms the real in its essential validity as real, the Absolute's infinity is maintained as concrete infinity; and in its relation of transcendence, enclosed by the

relation of immanence, that limitation is removed which is not avoided in the ordinary consciousness's conception resting upon the *representation* of transcendence, nor in those philosophical attempts which under the name of logical *theism* conceal theological *theism*. — In what follows, through the development of the problem of evil, the Absolute's freedom from finitude's imperfection in spite of immanence will be elucidated from a new standpoint.

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## 2. The Concept of the Human Being, Determined in Relation to the Absolute and to the Totality of Existence.

After the concept of the Absolute has been developed in its connection with the concept of the whole of existence, the task becomes to determine the concept of the human being in connection with those developments of concepts. In the determination of the concept of the human being the determination of the human *task of life* is enclosed, and from it and from those determinations of concepts the attempt at a solution of the decisive ethical-religious problems must proceed.

The *universal* concept which has been won in the foregoing for the determination of the human being is the concept of the *relative totality*: the concept which designates the living, the organic, in general, and which distinguishes it on the one side from the concept of the totality-less elementary, on the other side from the concept of the universal totality constituted by the principle, the whole of real existence. Within the universal concept of the relative totality the human being then stands as a particular determination over against the lower forms of the living: over against the plant and the animal. Plant life has for its fundamental determination the determination of *selfhood*, the *abstract universal determination* of the organic, which indicates ideality, the relation of the principle of totality to itself through its other; but it lacks the concentration in a *psychical self*. Such a concentration is attained in animal life; but animal life's highest determination is that *self-sensing* in which the individually-universal self is constantly only for itself in a determinateness of singularity, in immediate unity with that single determination, and by this relation betrays the limitedness of its essence. Only in human life is *self-consciousness* the fundamental determination: the self which according to its ideal essence is universal is as being for itself in the form of *liberated* universality; and this determination of self-consciousness is not an accessory determination, a determination of property in a really presupposed subject — or rather, substratum — but *an essential*



*determination* in the human. It expresses the ideal fundamental essence itself, which is for itself in its determinateness by reality. But in order that self-consciousness may become possible, the particular essential determination which characterises animal life must have given place to that of *essential universality*; only through it does the universal's being for itself *as universal*, which is self-consciousness's fundamental form, become possible, and only by it do *thought and will* become possible. And since self-consciousness thus points back to essential universality, it points back to *the being's infinity*: only the being which according to its concept is *infinite* is a *self-conscious* being.

This connection between the determination of *self-consciousness* and the *infinite* was first indicated by *Leibnitz*, in that he brought self-consciousness into connection with the cognition of the "eternal truths" which have their springing-forth from the divine. Only through the possibility of cognising these eternal truths, with their necessity and universality, does the self's perception have the possibility of reflexivity; only by it is self-consciousness, in other words, possible. For in that cognition, in which the object bears the mark of infinity, consciousness does not relate itself to anything foreign, is not bound by the particular, but relates itself in the object to itself, through the universal to its own essence as determined by the universal.

Since self-consciousness is man's *essential expression*, the form for the being's self-manifestness, self-consciousness encloses a relation to the human being's *ground*; and since the being which makes self-consciousness possible is the *universal* being, that ground of the human being to which self-consciousness has a relation is immediately determined as *existence's universal ground* (principle); and through the relation to it a relation is posited to *the totality of real existence*. In the human spirit's relation of self-consciousness to itself there is therefore enclosed *implicite* the twofold relation: to the Absolute and to that *totality of existence* which is grounded in the Absolute. This twofold relation must come forward for consciousness in the unfolding of self-consciousness into concrete self-cognition; it must show itself in concrete unity with the relation of self-consciousness where abstract self-consciousness, through comprehending cognition, has been unfolded into a reason-determined cognition of that which lies as inner possibility in the ideally all-comprehending human being. —

From the concept of self-consciousness — as the essential expression of the human, and as enclosing the self's relation to the Absolute and to the whole of existence — the *human task of life* must be determined. If we look to the kind of being which self-consciousness reveals, then the task in its universality is to be determined by that *unity of infinity and individual being* which is expressed in self-consciousness, and it becomes

thus: *a realisation of the being's infinity in the form of the given individuality*. And since the human individual, as originally endowed for self-consciousness and self-determination, is endowed for personality, the task can in other words be determined as *personality's realisation through the unfolding of the being's inner infinity*. But personality must then not be apprehended as the expression of a single side or a single form of activity of the human being, but as *the expression of unity* for the *total* human being in the aggregate of its fundamental functions.

*The universal* task must, as a task for a self which reveals itself in a plurality of primitive forms of expression, articulate itself into a plurality of essentially connected *particular* tasks; but the universal expression for the task must preserve its validity for these.

Thus the *task of human cognition* becomes: infinity's realisation in that cognition of existence and of its principle which is bound into unity with self-cognition. By such a cognition — in which the self ideally takes up the reason-determined, infinite, real existence and joins itself in unity with its own and existence's comprehended principle — the self's inner infinity is realised, and in the relation of infinity to itself freedom is realised.

The task of the human *will* becomes the self's ethical willing of itself according to its concrete infinity. In ethical willing the self asserts itself according to its infinity and makes its freedom felt, in that it is determining out of its own true infinity. But the condition for such a willing is that no dualistic, finitising separation divides the will from spirit's other forms of activity; for only so can the will will the being according to its total determinateness. Just as cognition on its side must preserve the character of universality, so that it does not, in relation to anything belonging to spirit, become a merely mirroring hiding-place, but can really make spirit's content transparent to spirit, so must the will too preserve this character of universality, and be able to have all spirit's essential forms of activity for its content. And this means, in other words: the ethical task must become an all-comprehending task, must enclose human life as a totality, so that the whole of human life, all the expressions of spirit, come under ethical responsibility.

To these determinations of the task we come in taking our starting point from the *infinity of essence* revealed in self-consciousness. But when we now accentuate the original *relation to the principle and to existence* which lies in self-consciousness, this leads us to a more concrete expression for the task.

In determining cognition's task we reached the concept of the unfolded self-consciousness's

unity with the cognition of existence and of the principle. In this cognition the self becomes conscious of itself *in its ordering as an organic member into the existence governed by the concretely determined principle*; and since the self — which through consciousness's self-deepening finds the Absolute as that in which its self-consciousness is first fulfilled — has in *self-surrender to the Absolute* the consciousness of *essential unity* with the Absolute, the Absolute's essential determination acquires validity for the self and for the totality posited by the principle. But the principle's essential determination was *the concrete unity of the ideal and the real, which excluded all dualistic separation*: this determination therefore acquires, since the relation of immanence is not broken, its validity for that which is through the principle.

When, then, the self is that which is divided by no dualism and which reveals itself in the essential unity of its fundamental functions, and when it is ordered as an integrating member into the ideally-real organisation of existence, then there lies in this that its task must become to develop the undivided personality in its inner harmony, to develop it according to the being's completeness as naturally-spiritual, in inseparable unity of the ideal and the real, and to develop it as a peculiar member in the whole of existence determined by the principle, by penetrating its peculiarity with the universal and making it into a peculiar expression of the universally valid. But since the human self becomes conscious of itself in its being ordered into the totality of existence, it becomes at the same time conscious, in virtue of its essence's universality, of its *relative independence as an integrating member*; and its task then becomes to will itself in this independence and to assert that independence through that harmoniously complete development of its essence's peculiarity. Man must will his essence as this concrete thing, in which the real foundation of nature is not to be negated but taken up into spirit, formed through with consciousness, so that the will acquires content and concretion through the individual's determinateness by reality, while it has what regulates it in the a priori, which in the domain of the ethical acquires the same validity as in that of the intellectual. But since the self wills itself *ethically* in its individual peculiarity and relative independence, this willing is in unity with its willing of itself as a member in the comprehensive whole, as subordinated to the principle; and by its willing it thus makes a movement of infinity, eternalises its acting while that acting preserves time and actuality as its stage. —

So apprehended, the task of life becomes a *task of infinity*, in that the self's willing is a willing of itself according to its essence's infinity, according to its relation of infinity to existence and to existence's absolute principle, according to its significance as an ideal moment in spirit's eternal unity of life. But since the task of life becomes a task of infinity,

a task of eternity, it acquires the closer determination of a task of infinity which is to be solved in finitude, of a task of eternity which is to be solved in time, under conditions of existence, conditions of finitude. Hereby an emphasis falls upon the *ethical choice as the self's choice in a moment of time*, and thereby upon the *individual free will's choice* as distinct from the eternal determining of metaphysical necessity; and an emphasis falls upon the significance which time acquires for the solution of the task of eternity and for the failure of that solution, upon the discord in the self which arises through the self's twofold relation — to the eternal and to the conditions of time — and upon the guilt which the self in this relation acknowledges itself to have incurred.

From this *standpoint* the determination of *guilt* will *not* be volatilised into a *metaphysical* moment; it will become an *in truth ethical* determination with decisive significance as *actuality*; and, as *the ideal's demand* is maintained, it will be seen as a *universal* determination in the human as conditioned by finitude. The ethical individual, which acknowledges the *infinite* demand, must bow under the feeling of *guilt*, must acknowledge the necessity of *repentance* and the need of a *supplementary assistance* in order that guilt may be reconciled, restitution take place. But since the whole of existence is seen as borne by the immanent principle, and its *harmony as a whole* can therefore not be thought as disturbed — just as neither can the single existence's *essence* be thought as transformed — the individual must not seek the supplementary help outside existence, but must seek the reconciling powers within this existence: in the other supplementary single beings, with which the individual joins itself in love, in mutual communication of essence; and, definitively, in that principle which is indwelling in the individual itself and works through it, and which joins it together with the other individuals in the being's unity. It will be shown in what follows how redintegration is definitively to be sought through the absolute self-surrender — to this principle working through it — of the self actualised according to its real ground in its resistance to the ethical; and how through redintegration the ethicising of the whole of life becomes possible.

Since the task of life is so determined that the personality in its free, harmonious self-elaboration is constantly to live itself into the whole and thus realise the relation to the whole's principle, the same thing is hereby expressed which has been maintained earlier: *that the religious relation becomes the concluding one*, in which the particular relations first find their completion. That the religious relation must become that through which the solution of the task of life is accomplished lies in the human being's fundamental relation; for the human being is grounded in the divine, and can as a self-conscious being come to realisation only in so far as this relation, by which the being is, comes to be for

the being's consciousness, and comes to be for it in such a way that the God-relation goes in unity with the self's relation to itself in self-consciousness.

But when the religious has thus once more shown itself as the concluding thing, then it is clear from earlier developments that the religiousness which rests upon the ground of knowledge and of the ethical will, and which has its content in the ethical that comprehends the *whole* of human life, becomes such a religiousness as does not separate itself off as an exclusive relation; rather its cultus becomes action, and its ideal is that the whole of life *as ethical* life is cultus.

For the ethical-religious self the Absolute becomes conscious in the determinateness of the *ethical*; for the self's being determines the form of the Absolute's being for the self: as man is, so is his God. Religion has its source in the human being itself: its content is conditioned by this being's manifestness to itself; its God-consciousness keeps pace with its self-consciousness. But religion has its source in the human being only because the human being is grounded in the Absolute; and in the self, which is posited by the Absolute and whose successive manifestation for consciousness rests upon the communication of essence to the human spirit, the Absolute is also in the religious relation that which works through and that which works primitively: in the *last* instance, therefore, we seek religion's source in the Absolute.

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The conception developed in the foregoing will be more clearly elucidated in its peculiarity through a comparison with theories with which it has striking points of contact, while it nevertheless differs from them in something decisive. With respect to the conception of the Absolute, of religion, and of the relation between the ethical and the religious, the comparison with *Feuerbach's* theory will be instructive; with respect to the ethical life's relation to the determinations of actuality, the comparison with the *Hegelian* way of viewing things will be so.

**Ludvig Feuerbach.** — Already in the preface to “Problemet om Tro og Viden” Feuerbach's standpoint has been characterised in general, and the essential points in which I diverge from it indicated. It will however, for the sake of the comparison and the critique, be necessary to enter more fully upon a presentation of his conception in its connection and in its inner development; and it will be so all the more since the utterances which have appeared in this country about Feuerbach almost without exception<sup>\*)</sup> betray not merely a highly incomplete acquaintance with his writings, but a slight insight into what is characteristic of his theory.

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<sup>\*)</sup>As such an exception I must particularly bring out a treatise which was printed many years ago in *L.*

What makes the apprehension and presentation of Feuerbach's view of the religious difficult — as of his philosophical view in general — is partly the aphoristic form of his philosophising, particularly at his last stage of development, and partly the constant movement which takes place in his thinking, and which lets every new writing mark a new stage in a development whose beginning and end points lie at an enormous distance from one another and belong to two wholly different directions of spirit. Only when the driving force of this restless development is found, and the development's wholeness surveyed, does the right understanding become possible.

*Feuerbach* began as a theologian, with a passionate striving to penetrate faith's content with thought. The form of theology which drew him to itself was therefore speculative theology; by it he was carried over to *Hegel's philosophy of religion*, and in apprehending this in the light of the Logic he soon became a stranger to theology: the divine became for him *the essence of reason*, reason's unity the eternal in which the transitory individuals are dissolved. In spite of beginning doubt he still held fast the fundamental view of the Hegelian philosophy: the view of thought as reality and truth existing in and for itself, so that *the thought as such* is actual, thought and being identical. But soon doubt of this view's truth gained power, and as he moved away from it his conception of the divine and of religion was transformed. *Indirectly* the Hegelian philosophy had acknowledged nature's essentiality and truth, by positing nature as a necessary moment in the idea's eternal process; but this acknowledgement was as it were revoked again, in that nature *as nature* became something merely untrue, vanishing. Feuerbach held fast that acknowledgement; he attributed to "the sensible" first truth and essentiality *within nature's domain*, and then *absolute reality*, since "the being which is opposed to sensibility as a heterogeneous being is nothing other than the abstract being of sensibility". What was primitive became for him no longer spirit but nature, no longer thought but being: a proceeding of matter out of spirit he declares unthinkable; therefore matter must precede spirit, nature be spirit's ground. "The true relation between thinking and being is only this: being is subject, thinking predicate. Being is out of itself and by itself — being has its ground in itself, because only being has meaning, reason, necessity, truth; in short, is all in all. Being is, because not-being is not-being, i.e. nothing, meaninglessness. Being's essence as being is nature's essence". And being, nature, has now for Feuerbach not the significance of a universal unity, but

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*Helweg's Fjerdingsskrift for Literatur og Kritik* (1845, 3rd number, pp. 1–17) and whose author was my late friend, the schoolmaster *Chr. Fenger Christens*, known as a writer on pedagogy. But this treatise lies in time before those writings of Feuerbach in which he has carried his theory through to its final consequences.

of the aggregate of the sensibly singular, of the “wholly determinate, individual, sensible things and beings” which become the one actual thing; while the universal becomes only a subjective common designation, just as “spirit” becomes only the unity of the senses.

This development of Feuerbach’s fundamental philosophical view, from *idealism* to a peculiarly formed *realism* — which by the acknowledgement of the human being’s original activity, and by the apprehension of the phenomena of spirit in which that activity manifests itself, separates itself from ordinary sensualism and materialism — had to become decisive for his *conception of the religious*. “God was my first thought”, he says, “*reason* my second, *man* my third and last thought. The subject of the Godhead is reason, but the subject of reason is man”. The transcendent God’s existence outside man transforms itself for him first into an *existence in reason*, i.e. an existence within reason, and God’s essence is identified in a *pantheistic* way with *reason’s essence*; then the religious representation is seen as an *unconscious projection* of the human self, which in God objectifies its own universal essence as something different from itself; and finally — as the reality of the *universal* is denied in a *nominalist* manner, and the essence of reason, which had been identified with the human race as nature’s conclusion, is absorbed by the single individuals — the religious representation becomes only a *mirror-image* of those individuals’ craving. In this process *pantheism* gives place to *atheism*, theology is dissolved, as metaphysics was before it, into *anthropology*, God vanishes, and only *man* remains as the true and the actual; and the *religious relation* which *positive* religion posits becomes *truth’s utmost opposite*. Only in a transferred sense is there still talk of religion as something valid.

What in the development of Feuerbach’s philosophical standpoint — which conditions the development of his conception of the religious — is the moving motive, is *the interest in actuality*. And while this interest, as an interest in real *natural actuality*, the foundation of concrete human life, guides his polemic against abstract idealism, it guides, as an interest in *the ethical demand of actual human life*, his polemic against the positively religious.

The writings which mark the stages of development in Feuerbach’s *peculiar* conception of the religious are essentially the following: 1) Philosophie und Christenthum; das Wesen des Christenthums; (cf. P. Bayle and the contemporary critical treatises) 2) Ueber das Wesen des Glaubens im Sinne Luthers; das Wesen des Religion; Vorlesungen über das Wesen der Religion; 3) Theogonie; Ueber Gottheit, Freiheit und Unsterblichkeit. — Of these writings the fullest account must be taken of *das Wesen des Christenthums*, in which Feuerbach’s conception of the Christian is developed in connection. To this

writing — which precisely marks the transition in his fundamental philosophical view, and is understood only when the stages between which it forms the transition are clearly apprehended — the writing *Ueber Philosophie und Christenthum* is the polemical introduction, and the treatise *vom Wesen des Glaubens im Sinne Luthers* the postscript. In the treatise on religion's essence what in *W. d. Christenthums* was developed with particular regard to Christianity is carried out with regard to the nature-religions, and their relation to the religions of spirit is determined. The lectures on religion's essence are a further working out of the fundamental thoughts of the last-named treatise; *the Theogony*, and the parts belonging with it of F.'s last work, *Gottheit, Freiheit und Unsterblichkeit*, are a development of religion's genesis and of its connection with the pathological in man — a connection which the treatise on religion's essence already strongly stresses. F.'s polemic against *theology* comes forward partly in various places in the writings named, particularly in those cited under 1), and partly in his critiques, as in his "Beiträge zur Kritik des modernen Afterchristenthums".

*The fundamental features of Feuerbach's conception of religion*, as it is given in "*das Wesen des Christenthums*", are the following.

*Since religion is found only in man, it must be grounded in that which is the human being's peculiar mark.* This is, expressed generally, consciousness; but consciousness in the strict sense is consciousness of one's species, one's essentiality. The animal is an object for itself only as individual; man is an object for himself also as species; therefore he has the capacity for thinking, for knowing; he can make other things objects according to their essential nature. Religion in general, *as identical with man's essence*, is identical with man's self-consciousness, with his consciousness of essence; and when religion is at the same time consciousness of *the infinite*, it becomes this as man's consciousness of *his own infinite essence*. A really finite being has not the remotest inkling, still less consciousness, of an infinite being; for *the barrier of the being is also the barrier of consciousness*. Consciousness of the infinite presupposes the infinity of the conscious being; therefore religion points back to *the human being's infinity*.

Man is nothing without an object: through the object the subject becomes manifest; but the object to which the human subject *essentially and necessarily* relates itself, the *inner and chosen* object, is nothing other than this subject's *own*, but *objectified* essence. Such an object is the *religious* object; in it, therefore, man becomes conscious only of himself.

In the case of the sensible object, consciousness of the object is separable from self-consciousness; in the case of the religious object the two fall immediately together: the



object is man's manifest essence, his true objective I, and its power over man is the power of his own essence.

*Man cannot become conscious of a being higher than his own.* Whatever object he becomes conscious of, he becomes constantly conscious of his own essence; he cannot affirm another without affirming himself. Since the powers of his essence, which constitute the essence, are realities, every working of them — and therefore also that by which they express the absolute object — is the immediate affirmation and confirmation of themselves; every expression of them must be accompanied by consciousness of them as perfections. If man could become conscious of himself, i.e. of his essence, as finite over against another being known as infinite, then he would in consciousness limit his own essence, i.e. negate it: *his consciousness would therefore reach out beyond his essence.* But consciousness is only the essence's self-objectification, and therefore its self-affirmation, its realisation of itself; it is precisely the highest form of self-affirmation; that negation is therefore an impossibility. But where, then, does the distinction between the finite and the infinite find its place? In the distinction between *individual and species*. *The species' essence is the individual's absolute essence*; beyond it the individual can only *imagine* itself able to reach. Every being is infinite for itself; its barriers exist only for another being outside and above it: the being's measure is the understanding's measure.

What holds of consciousness in general in relation to the object holds of course of *the single organs of spirit*. In that which is the essential object for a single organ of spirit, the organ relates itself to itself, objectifies itself. Thus *reason's object is reason objective for itself*, *feeling's object is feeling objective for itself*. Therefore the *difference of form* between the religious and the philosophical consciousness becomes of such *decisive* significance: *precisely the form*, which is the expression of the organ's peculiarity, determines *religion's essence*. The Absolute is *not* religion's object *as such*, but *as it is an object for the heart*<sup>\*)</sup> and for the imagination. What transcendent speculation about the religious posits as the merely secondary, as means and organ, has precisely the significance of the primitive, of the essence, of the object itself.

But when it is now said that man in the consciousness of the religious object relates himself to his own objectified essence, so that *consciousness of God is man's self-consciousness*, then, in order that the *religious standpoint* may be designated in its peculiarity, a closer determination must be added as essential: namely, that the religious man *is not conscious of this relation to himself*, and that the lack of such a consciousness

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<sup>\*)</sup>“The heart” F. sets on the one side in opposition to *reason*, as the individual to the universally valid; on the other side in opposition to “the Heart” as the subjectively arbitrary, limitlessly craving, over against the natural feeling and drive which acknowledges its own limit.

precisely constitutes religion's peculiar character. *Religion is man's first and indirect self-cognition*. Just as the child sees its essence, man, outside itself, so that man as child is an object to himself as *another* man, so also, in the course of historical development, man first places his essence outside himself before he finds it within himself; his own essence first becomes an object to him as *another being*. The historical development in the religions therefore consists in this, that what counted for the earlier religions as something objective is now intuited as something subjective — that is to say, that what was intuited and worshipped as God is now cognised as something human. For the later religion the earlier one is idolatry: man has in it worshipped his own essence. But every single religion of course excepts itself from this judgement; because it has another object, another content, it imagines itself raised above the laws which constitute religion's essence; it imagines that its object, its content, is *superhuman*. But philosophy sees through religion's essence, hidden from religion itself; it shows that the opposition between God and man is completely illusory, that it is nothing other than the opposition between the human essence (the species) and the human individuals, so that consequently the object and content of *every* religion, even the highest, are entirely human.

When it is conceded that God must *unavoidably* be determined by man through human predicates, and that consciousness therefore so far relates itself in God to something humanly determinate, but when it is at the same time said that God according to his essence *in and for himself* is infinitely higher than man, then this separation between what God *is for man* and what he *is in and for himself* not merely disturbs religion's peace but is in and for itself groundless and untenable. In this distinction man sets himself beyond himself, beyond his essence, his absolute measure; but this is an illusion. That distinction has significance only where an object really *can show itself* otherwise to me than it does, or where the object is given immediately to the senses and therefore precisely also for beings other than man; but it has none where an object which is exclusively for man shows itself to me as it shows itself *according to my absolute measure, as it must* show itself to me. If the representation of God answers to *the species' measure*, then that distinction falls away and the representation is absolute; for the species' measure is man's absolute measure, law and criterion. This *every* religion also holds fast with respect to *its own* representation of God: that distinction is sceptical and irreligious. Religion gives itself up when it gives up God's essence; it is no longer a truth when it renounces the possession of the *true* God. What for man has the significance of what is in and for itself, what for him is the highest being beyond which he cannot

represent anything higher: that is precisely for him the *divine* being. In the case of this divine object it can no longer be asked what it is in and for itself. To ask whether God in and for himself is such as he is for me is the same as to ask whether *God is God*; it is to raise oneself above one's God, to rebel against him. If one first doubts *the predicates' objective truth* and makes them anthropomorphisms, then one must consistently doubt also *the objective truth of these predicates' subject*, and make the subject too — that is, God's existence, belief in a God generally — into an anthropomorphism, a completely human presupposition. *The subject's necessity lies only in the predicates' necessity*; for the subject is only the personified, the existing predicate. The predicate is what is properly primitive. *The certainty of God's existence depends upon the certainty of God's quality*; only the predicate's reality is the guarantee of the existence. For the Christian only the Christian God's existence, for the heathen only the heathen God's, is a certainty. *God is man's essence, intuited as absolute truth*; but he is man's essence *apprehended in a determinate quality*, which, by being the truth, becomes the highest existence; for what man intuits as true he intuits immediately as existing.

*If the divine predicates are human predicates, then the divine subject too must be a human subject.* But here a phenomenon must be brought out which characterises religion's inmost essence. The more human the divine subject is in essence, the greater is apparently the difference between God and man, the more does theology — reflection upon religion — deny the identity, and lower the human as it *as such* is an object for man's consciousness. The ground of this is simply that, since what is *positive* in the intuition of the *divine* being is precisely the *human* determinations of essence, the intuition of the *human*, as it *directly* is an object for consciousness, must be *only a negative* one.

In order to enrich God, man must be made poor; he has *his essence* in God, how then should he have it in himself? Man negates with respect to himself only what he posits in God. Religion abstracts from man, from the world; but it can abstract only from the phenomenon, not from the essence, and therefore religion must unconsciously posit in God everything it has consciously negated, when that thing is something *essential* and *true*, something therefore from which it cannot abstract, which it cannot negate *at all*: thus sensibility, reason, goodness, moral activity. Through God man receives back, in infinitely richer measure, this which — by being posited in God, the essential object of spirit — has already been indirectly declared to be an essential determination in human nature. Religion's secret is that man objectifies his essence, but then makes himself an object for this objectified essence transformed into a subject. Man has indeed in religion God for his end, but God has no other end than man's welfare: the divine

activity becomes a means for this, and therefore man has in religion only himself for his end, in and through God. And what is posited, as it were by an act of a religious force of repulsion, as an activity of God — man's separated-off subjectivity, from whom the religious consciousness must let every impulse proceed — becomes again, by an act of a religious force of attraction, in that the divine activity is to work upon man, in man, to become the principle of man's good disposition and of his good actions, made into an activity human in its essence. Religion's course of development therefore consists more closely in this, that man constantly appropriates more of what he previously ascribed to God. What at the earlier stage was religion is so no longer at the later: what at the former counted as atheism counts at the latter as religion.

But when religion is thus determined as man's indirect self-cognition and as his unconscious objectifying of his essence, then the question must be answered: in what relation does the *religious* consciousness of the essence stand to the consciousness present in other forms of the life of spirit — in other words, *what part of man's essence* it is that essentially gives the religious consciousness its content. The answer to this question will emerge from a consideration of religion's character and essential standpoint.

*Religion's essential standpoint* shows itself immediately as the *subjective, practical* one. Religion's end is the individual's welfare, his salvation, his *blessedness*. Man's relation to God is only his relation to his own salvation. *God is realised blessedness, or the unlimited power to realise man's blessedness*. God as God, i.e. as he is an object *for religion*, is essentially *only* an object for religion, not for philosophy; for the heart, not for reason; for the heart's need, not for thought's freedom — in short, a being which does *not* express the peculiarity of the *theoretical, objective* standpoint but that of the *practical, subjective* one. This also becomes plain from the fact that religion attaches curse and blessing, damnation and blessedness, to its doctrines, to belief in them. It appeals therefore not to reason but to the heart, to the drive for happiness, to the affect of fear and hope. Doubt, the principle of theoretical freedom, becomes here a crime, doubt of God the highest crime. But what I cannot or dare not doubt without feeling disquieted in my heart is not a matter for theory but for conscience, not a being of reason but a being of the heart.

Now when religion's standpoint is the practical or subjective one, there lies in this that *only* the *practical* man — the man acting according to his conscious physical or moral ends, who regards the world only in relation to those ends and not in and for itself — counts for religion as the *whole* essential man; and it is in relation to man in this determinateness that religion's highest being is determined as a being of *the heart*, as a being which satisfies the need of the heart and of the imagination. All that

which lies behind the practical consciousness, but is the essential object of theory — of *theory* in the most original and general sense, in the sense of objective intuition and experience, reason, science in general — does not relate itself essentially to the religious consciousness. Religion, being exclusively practical, subjective, lacks the true intuition of the universe, of the really infinite, the true consciousness of the species. And since now the true universal essence of nature and of man makes itself felt for spirit as something that cannot be negated, that lack is indeed sought to be made good in God, in a separate, personal being: the determinations of essence of nature and of man, accessible only to the theoretical eye, are involuntarily transferred into God — but partly in such a way that they constitute only the outermost point of attachment of the religious consciousness, “religion’s mathematical point”, and partly in such a way that they are transformed, and in this transformation appropriated by the heart and the imagination. Since religion takes the apparent, superficial essence of humanity and of nature for their true, inner essence, and represents their true esoteric essence as one other being, it metamorphoses, under the personification, the true essence of man and of nature into a *superhuman* and *supernatural personality*, incomprehensible for cognition, working through *the miracle* and through it satisfying the religious individual’s practical need in contradiction with the law of reason.

Religion’s original separation of the divine and the human is involuntary and naive; it originally identifies God with man just as immediately as it separates him from man; it moves in the imagination’s quantitative differences, does not make the difference a qualitative and essential one. But as reflection awakens, the separation becomes deliberate and studied, precisely in order to suppress that consciousness of the identity which begins to dawn in the religious consciousness. The first way, according to the concept, in which reflection secures God as a being distinct from man is by *the proofs of God’s existence*. Their end is precisely to separate God off from man, by maintaining for him an existence as a thing in and for itself, which is not merely to have being in our faith, our feeling, our thought, but is also to have a real being distinct from these, an existence *outside* us; and this *outside* must be taken *literally*, for otherwise the existence itself becomes an existence in an improper sense. Such an existence outside us would however be nothing other than a *sensible* being. But God’s being does not have the peculiarity of sensibly real being: that I am involuntarily affected by it, that it is even when I am not, do not think it, do not feel it. God is only for man, in so far as man raises himself above sensible life, in so far as he feels, thinks and believes God. But since God is *only* an object for *man*, this will simply mean: God is only in so far as he is felt,

thought and believed. The existence one wishes to maintain for God would become a real being which yet was not real: a *spiritual* being, one calls it, as a way out. But spiritual being is precisely only to be felt, to be thought, to be believed. God's being is therefore a contradictory middle thing between sensible being and thought being: a sensible being which, by being deprived of all the determinations of sensibility, is reduced to a vague existence in general, and thereby abolishes itself, since to existence there belongs full, determinate reality. *A necessary consequence of this contradiction is atheism.* God's existence, which does not denote inner reality, truth, but outer existence, has the essence of an empirical existence, but without having its marks; it is in and for itself a matter of experience, and yet in reality no object of experience. It itself calls upon man to seek it in actuality; and when man finds experience in contradiction with the representations that existence has awakened, he is completely justified in denying this existence. Only sensation, not reason, can give the proof of empirical existence, and in the proofs of God's existence being has precisely the significance of such an existence. For religion, belief in God's existence without regard to the inner quality, the spiritual content, becomes at last unavoidably the main thing. God's existence in and for itself establishes itself as religious truth, and to it, as experience shows, the crudest and most unhallowed representations can attach themselves.

At religion's standpoint it is *the imagination* — the place for the absent existence, withdrawn from the senses but yet sensible in essence — that resolves the contradiction in an existence which is at once to be sensible and non-sensible. Only the imagination preserves from atheism; for in it the existence has sensible effects. Where God's existence is a living truth, a matter for the imagination, there apparitions of God are believed in as well. Where on the contrary the fire of the religious imagination is quenched, and where the sensible effects or phenomena which are necessarily bound up with an in-and-for-itself sensible existence cease, there the existence becomes a dead and self-contradictory existence, which falls irretrievably to atheism's negation.

The same contradiction which makes itself felt in the representation of God's existence makes itself felt in the determination of *God's essence generally*. All the positive determinations in that essence are human determinations; but in negating the determinateness in the determinations, reflection makes them non-human. Yet by this negation the concept is dissolved; there remains only a negative, contentless, self-contradictory representation; for precisely that determinateness has been negated which made the determination what it is, and only this is a real concept; whereas that which is to make the determination something essentially other is objectively nothing, subjectively a mere

fancy.

This Feuerbach now carries out in “das Wesen der Christenthums” with respect to the chief Christian dogmas. The contradiction in Christianity, “the religion of love”, he sees decisively concentrated in *the opposition between faith and love*.

For in love he sees a revelation of religion’s *hidden* essence, in faith that which constitutes its *conscious* form. Love identifies man with God and God with man, and therefore man with man; faith separates God from man, but therefore also man from man; for God is nothing other than man’s mystical concept of the species: God’s separation from man therefore becomes man’s separation from man, the dissolution of the common bond. Since faith makes God into a *separate* being and apprehends him as *person*, the relation to God is separated from the relation to men, and there must unavoidably arise a conflict between the two relations, between religion and morality; and since the relation to God, as the highest, lays claim to all man’s powers and his whole interest, morality must give way to religion, love be annihilated by faith. Faith must raise itself above the laws of natural morality; there must be actions in which faith comes to light in distinction from and in opposition to morality; the duties towards God must collide with the simple human duties, and faith privileges everything. Even when Christianity says God is love, there remains — since love becomes only predicate, and the proposition is not at the same time reversed, so that it would read love is God — a place for the divine personality as such; and the subject, the divine personality, becomes the main thing, the predicates, the ethical determinations, a mere side-issue. But in thinking God as subject, in separation from the predicate, a room is left over for unlovingness, and it becomes unavoidable that I give now the subject, now the predicate the preponderance. This contradiction the history of Christianity has sufficiently confirmed. — Christian love is, as Christian, a limited love. But a love which is limited by faith is an untrue love. True love, free, universal love, knows no other law than its own and reason’s. It is the universal law of intelligence and of nature; it is nothing other than the realisation of the species’ unity by the way of disposition. It thus has a self-validity independent of the religious, and does not need to be supported upon it. When universal love, grounded in itself, becomes the principle, Christ vanishes before the consciousness of the species; for Christ is himself only an image under which the popular consciousness represented the species’ unity, and true universal love can be grounded only upon the unity of the species, of intelligence, upon humanity’s nature. Only then is it a thorough, principle-secured, free love; for it supports itself upon love’s origin, from which Christ’s love too derived. That love was itself a derived one: Christ did not love of himself, but in virtue of humanity’s nature.

The law of the species, of intelligence, is that we should love man *for man's sake*; love tolerates no intermediary.

Although Christianity acknowledges love, it nevertheless comes to deny it again, because it has not set love free, has not apprehended it absolutely; and this it could not do, because it is religion, and love is therefore subjected to the dominion of faith. Love is only Christianity's exoteric doctrine, but faith its esoteric; love is only its morality, but faith its religion.

In the contradiction between faith and love lies the necessity of going beyond Christianity, and beyond religion's peculiar essence generally. *Religion's content and object is a completely human one: theology's secret is anthropology.* Of this religion has no consciousness; but the task is to lift the illusion, to come to the cognition that consciousness of God is nothing other than consciousness of the species; that man can and should raise himself above the barriers of his individuality, but not above his species' laws and positive determinations of essence; that man cannot think, divine, represent, feel, believe, will, love and worship any other being than the human species' being — including nature, which belongs to man's essence as man belongs to nature's — as the absolute being.

*Man, who in religion is in and for himself the first, must be posited and declared as the first.* All man's moral relations to man must be posited as in and for themselves valid, holy, and thereby as religious. As substantial relations they can be grounded only by themselves: a grounding of morality by theology is an illusion, a movement in a circle. The right, the true and the good has everywhere its ground of holiness in itself, in its own quality. Where right and morality are taken in earnest, there they are in and for themselves divine powers. If they have no ground in themselves, then neither is there any inner necessity for them: they are then given over to religion's groundless arbitrariness.

In the self-conscious spirit's relation to religion, then, all that is at stake is the annihilation of an illusion — but of an illusion which works fundamentally corruptingly upon humanity, and robs man both of powers for actual life and of the sense for truth and virtue; for even love, in and for itself the most inward, truest disposition, becomes through religion a merely apparent, illusory one, since religious love loves man only for God's sake, and therefore only apparently man, but in reality only God, and in God egoistically itself. But that illusion is annihilated and the truth becomes manifest as soon as we merely turn the religious relations round — as soon as we constantly apprehend what religion posits as means as the end, and what it makes the subordinate thing, the side-issue and condition, as the main thing and the cause. It is therefore in the interest



of reason, of humanity and of morality that the religious representations are given up; precisely that interest is atheism's source, and this atheism therefore negates not the real, positive content of the representation of God, but only the untrue representation of God as a separate personal being, and what is inseparable from that representation. —

What in "*das Wesen der Christenthums*" is developed about the religious with particular regard to the Christian is completed in the treatise "*on religion's essence*", in that closer account is taken of the lower forms of religion, and in that the universal relation between *the nature-religions* and *the religions of spirit* is determined.

The starting point is formed by the proposition *that man's feeling of dependence is religion's ground* — religion therefore being the conscious, declared feeling of dependence. As the *original object* for this feeling of dependence *nature* is then determined; and nature is posited not merely as religion's *original object* but also as its *abiding ground*, the lasting though hidden background for it, as the ground of belief in God's *objective* existence outside thought and reason, as the foundation for those properties which express the divine being's difference from the human. God, thought as the originator of nature, is indeed represented as a being distinct from nature; but this being's real content is only nature. All God's properties, which make him an objective, actual being, are properties abstracted from nature, which presuppose it, express it, and which therefore fall away when nature falls away. There does then indeed remain a being, an aggregate of properties such as infinity, unity, necessity, eternity; but this being is nothing other than nature's *abstract* essence, which as such presupposes nature's concrete, sensible, actual essence.

But when it is now said that religion's first and essential object is nature, this is, be it noted, to be understood thus: that nature, even in the nature-religions, is *not* an object *as nature*, but as a *personal, living, sensing, man-like being*. Man does not originally distinguish himself from nature, and consequently does not distinguish nature from himself either: he therefore makes the sensations which a natural object awakens in him immediately into properties of the object. *The nature-being* thus becomes a *being of the heart*, i.e. a subjective, human being. It is particularly nature's changeableness that brings man to apprehend it as a human, arbitrary being. This conception reveals itself in *sacrifice*, the most essential act of the nature-religions. And in sacrifice the whole essence of religion concentrates itself; for sacrifice's ground is the feeling of dependence, but its result and end self-feeling. *And thus the feeling of dependence upon nature is indeed religion's ground; but the abolition of this dependence is religion's end.* The contradiction between willing and being able, wishing and attaining, representation and actuality, is

religion's presupposition; the being in which this contradiction is abolished is the *divine* being, and this being is an object of prayer, determinable by prayer and sacrifice. But since nature becomes religion's object as metamorphosed into a being of the heart, of representation, of imagination, the nature-religion becomes the striking contradiction between representation and actuality, fancy and truth. This contradiction religion escapes only by making its object an *invisible* one, a wholly *non-sensible* one, a being which is an object only for *faith*, for representation, for imagination — in short, for *spirit* — and therefore in and for itself a *spiritual* being. When man, from a merely physical being, becomes a *political* one, and generally a being which distinguishes itself from nature and concentrates itself upon itself, then his God too becomes, from a merely *physical* being, a *political* being distinct from nature. Where man, through the life of society, becomes a being which determines itself by principles, rules of wisdom, laws of reason — therefore a thinking, understanding being — and where powers other than powers of nature, namely political, moral, abstract powers, become objects of his feeling of dependence, there the world, nature, also shows itself to him as a being dependent upon and determined by *understanding and will*. Where man with will and understanding raises himself above nature, becomes a supranaturalist, there God too becomes a *supranaturalistic* being, *lord over nature*, and finally — what is the condition of being lord in the strict sense — *creator of nature*. The unity of the human consciousness and spirit, which comprehends the whole manifoldness of the outer world, is what leads to laying down *God's unity*. Proper *theism* arises only where man refers nature only *to himself* and makes this relation nature's essence, thus making himself nature's final end. Where nature has *its end* outside itself, it necessarily has also its *ground* and *beginning* outside itself; where it exists only *for another being*, there it necessarily exists also *through another being* — and through such a being as in producing it had man in view as enjoying nature. The doctrine that God is the world's creator has its ground and significance only in the doctrine that man is creation's end. And nature's creator is only the condition of the creator of man raised above nature; only he is God and creator *sensu eminenti*, just as religion's proper providence is the *special providence for man*.

The *spiritual* being which man, having advanced from the stage of the nature-religions to that of the religions of spirit, posits above nature and makes nature's presupposition, is nothing other than *man's own spiritual being* in the *religious* consciousness's apprehension — but which for that reason shows itself to man as *another* being, *distinct* from man, incomparable, because it is made into *the cause of nature*, into the cause of effects which the human spirit, the human understanding and will, cannot produce; for the reason,

therefore, that man combines with this spiritual human being at the same time nature's being, which is distinct from the human. While nature's essence is in this combination humanised, its being in objective separation from man conditions the objectification of the human essence as divine.

Belief in a God becomes therefore either *belief in nature*, in the objective being, as a human, subjective being, or *belief in the human being as nature's being*. The former belief is *nature-religion*, polytheism; the latter *religion of spirit* ("spirit-man-religion"), monotheism. Religion's first principle runs: I am nothing over against nature, all is God over against me (the standpoint of fetishism, the foundation of polytheism). Religion's concluding proposition, on the contrary, runs: all is nothing over against me, all is only a means for me. But this nature can be only when it is not through itself but through God. In *the miracle* religion's end is fulfilled in a sensibly popular way; man's dominion over nature, his divinity, is in the miracle a striking truth. *The God-man is the revelation of the miracle's secret thought: that man is God.*

God is a *religious* word, a religious object and being, an object whose existence is given only with religion's existence, whose essence is given only with religion's essence, which therefore cannot exist outside religion, and in which there is contained no more objectively than there is subjectively in religion. God expresses only religion's essence: imagination and heart. Religion's object, as it is an object for religion, does not exist in actuality, but is only an object for faith, which represents that which is not but is craved to be, as being. — As men's wishes are, so are their gods. The Greeks had limited wishes and limited gods, the Christians an unlimited God, exalted above all natural necessity, superhuman, transcendent, and absolutely unlimited, fantastic wishes. Their fundamental wish is the enjoyment of an infinite, unlimited, unutterable, indescribable blessedness. — *Blessedness and divinity are one.* —

In the treatise on religion's essence, as emerges from the foregoing, not only is the horizon widened by the account taken of the nature-religions, but the determination of the religious has undergone an essential modification. In "das Wesen der Christenthums" religion's standpoint was indeed apprehended as the one-sidedly *practical* one, and the determination of "*the heart*" as religion's organ prepared the consequences later drawn; but there lay nevertheless, in the apprehension of religion as man's indirect *self-cognition* — when that was put in connection with the apprehension of the species', the universally human's, relation to the individual, and of its relation to reason — a point of attachment for a theoretical, rational element; and this also came to validity in so far as God's essence acquired the determination "being of understanding" too, even though this determination

was to be only an outermost point of attachment for the religious consciousness and not to express what was religion's proper kernel. Now, on the contrary, in the apprehension of religion the accent falls far more sharply and exclusively upon that side of human nature which, in its separation from the theoretical, becomes the *egoistically drive-like, the pathological, the alogical*. As a connecting transition there appears, in the treatise *vom Wesen des Glaubens im Sinne Luthers*, the apprehension of *faith* as the expression of *indirect self-love*. But still more sharply than in the treatise on religion's essence, and with a still more complete pushing back of the rational moment, the change in the apprehension of the religious appears in "*Theogonie*" and in Feuerbach's last writing, "*Gottheit, Freiheit und Unsterblichkeit*".

In "*Theogonie*" it is developed, with many turns of phrase, how *the wish* — the irrational, egoistic craving — is *the gods' first ground*, the source of belief in them; that the gods are *not* beings of reason but essentially expressions of craving and wish. God is the supplement to man's defective essence, to his capacity, so finite and limited in contradiction with his wishes; the certainty of God's being rests upon the power of self-love, which over against actuality's painful limitation forces out a representation of that limitation's abolition — a representation so rooted in man's craving that it unavoidably acquires actuality for him. Before the divine power the tormenting feeling of limitation vanishes. God is and can do what man is not and cannot do, but would gladly be and be able to do. The wish has, as a *theogonic* power, precedence over fear: it is not fear in and for itself, but fear's wish — that there should be nothing to fear — that creates gods. But the wish which sums up all wishes is *the wish for happiness*; in this wish, therefore, the gods' origin, religion's principle and fundamental essence are to be sought, and by the nature and limit of the wish for happiness the nature and limit of the gods are determined.

*The wish itself as such* stems from *man*; but the wish's *object* stems from *outer nature*, from what is given by the senses; for man has originally no empty, supranaturalistic, fantastic wishes. No: the objects of his senses are also the objects of his wishes. Precisely therefore the gods, as "*wish-beings*", are at the same time *nature-beings*. But this is not to be understood as though the gods as such were deified or personified powers of nature or bodies of nature; they are expressions of *nature's effects upon the heart and the imagination* — personified, made independent, objectified *feelings, affects* — but affects which are bound to those bodies of nature by which they are awakened or brought about. Thus the *human* shines through in the determination of the nature-being; and the *human wish*, which draws its content *from nature*, is raised in power — as man

distinguishes himself as the *higher* from nature — into the *supranaturalistic wish*, into the *wish for blessedness*, in which the mystery of the Godhead is first revealed. *The wish for blessedness, self-love's most intensive expression*, is *Christianity's* fundamental wish; and the Christian God, who fulfils this wish, is personified blessedness, absolutely raised above the barrier of nature and of natural necessity.

That men have *everywhere* represented gods, but as *human* beings, is the historical, factual proof that man in reality represents the *human* essence as divine, and that the human essence is the fundamental presupposition for the representation of a Godhead — that it is the primal-being which lies at the foundation of the gods. As *highest* being I can worship only what expresses *my own* essence, but in a degree and perfection which I lack, and which precisely therefore carries me away to worship and admiration. God is indeed the *superhuman*, the infinite being — but, be it well understood, the *infinitely human*, the *superhumanly human* being: a being which is more, infinitely more man than man himself. The Christian God is just as fully as the heathen one a human being, only of another kind than the latter, because the Christian too is a man of another kind than the heathen. —

With this result this writing joins itself to the earlier ones; and in taking polemical account of the distorting reinterpretations of religion, it declares itself against them in these words: “There is only one true, one venerable God; — it is the immediate, self-active, self-speaking, self-shining, self-lightning-flashing, self-thundering, self-raining God of the ancient world. Either this one or no God! Where the old view of the world is abandoned, where there is an independent doctrine of state and of law, an independent doctrine of nature, which no longer sees in the wind God's breath, in the thunder God's voice, in the lightning God's fire; there *atheism* is not merely a scientific but a moral truth and necessity”. —

By means of the survey given of the development of Feuerbach's theory of religion, what is unsatisfactory in that theory can easily be made plain. There is in Feuerbach a great deal to which one cannot deny recognition. There is in him a great clarity in the negative: in the polemic against theology and against those philosophical mixed forms in which philosophy and Christianity were sought to be fused into a unity. There is in him a sharp eye for what is *common to all the positive* forms of religion, and a sharp apprehension of the phenomena which appear within the domain of the positive religions<sup>\*)</sup>.

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<sup>\*)</sup>This *phenomenal, factual* element F. then apprehends as the *necessary* expression of the positive religion's essence, without letting that *question* come forward which is *indirectly* answered by Kierkegaard, in “Kjærlighedens Gjæringer” and in other places: whether this factual, phenomenal element may not

There are fine and deeply penetrating analyses of the positive religion's determinations, and of the fundamental psychological relations which illuminate the religious representations. There is a correct recognition of religion's essential connection with human nature, and of the essential connection between the religious consciousness's object and the apprehending organ. There is a clear demonstration of the impossibility of reaching beyond the human being's fundamental determinations, of the impossibility of negating thought by thought. And to this comes, as something essential, that all F.'s investigations bear the stamp of a high degree of honesty and love of truth, of a living conviction, and at the same time of an energetic striving forward which always sets his inquiry in motion anew and does not let it content itself with results once won. But in spite of all this the Feuerbachian theory has its great and essential defects. We bring out the most decisive.

*The fundamental defect* is that with him a one-sided emphasis is laid upon religion's proceeding *from the human being*, and that it is overlooked that the human being is itself something posited, something derived, and that what posits and gathers together works through it. This defect already becomes striking in F.'s earlier writings, as in *Wesen der Christenthums*, where nevertheless, by a reminiscence from idealism, the concept of "the species" was still accentuated as the universal, the essential, in which the individuals are absorbed and which realises itself in them, and where the apprehension of *the human species' relation to reason and to nature* made it natural to seek back to a principle of existence which within the unity of essence with the human had a transcendence over it. But still more determinately must the defect come forward in the later writings, where in a nominalist manner the individuals are posited as the properly real, the species only as a subjectively valid universal expression for their aggregate, just as reason's identity is apprehended only as "an expression necessary for thinking and for language, by which the universal is fixed and made independent, but in respect of which it must not be forgotten that it is only a product of thinking". Here religion can be thought only as proceeding from the individual, and its source then becomes, since the individual is not governed by the species' unconsciously through-working rational power, merely *the alogical in the individual*.

*The rational* moment in religion is with F. pushed back in a one-sided manner. Since religion's essential standpoint becomes the subjective-practical, man in religion is to apprehend himself only from the standpoint of the practical, and everything which is theory's object is to fall outside the religious individual's consciousness of the human,

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find its corrective at the positive religion's own standpoint, and whether it is not to be explained by an unconscious relapse from the sphere of the religious to lower stages of life.

and to find its place in the divine only in a transformation necessitated by the religious standpoint, or as an outermost point of attachment which is soon lost wholly from sight. But in this apprehension the essential co-operation of the different capacities, the different organs, in the human being — even under the sporadic development — and the necessity of a striving after a satisfaction of *all* the fundamental capacities, are misapprehended. It is indeed originally conceded that the theoretical too makes itself felt involuntarily for consciousness; but this concession is in reality taken back by the limitations added, and by the significance F. attributes to the determination of *personality* in the religious representation of God. That, however, the theoretical *as* theoretical must acquire a determining influence upon the religious apprehension of the Absolute lies not merely in this, that spirit in religion seeks reconciliation, satisfaction, *according to its wholeness*; it also emerges from the fact that it has been possible for the human spirit to work its way out of the first, crudest religious forms, before which as yet no independent — i.e. independent of the religious —

development of thought had taken place. At *higher* stages of religion's development there is, in spite of the apprehension of the *divine* will as *arbitrary*, a possibility that a *content of thought* may lay itself into the religious forms, and that in them the rational may assert an *essential* significance; and this content of thought, which is as it were precipitated into those forms, has partly come about through a development of thought which has not separated itself from the religious but has been furthered by religion itself, and has partly, in virtue of an inner need, been *appropriated* by the religious consciousness from a development of thought relatively independent of it.

The pushing back of the rational which shows itself in F. hangs together with this, that the significance of the working of the *a priori* in the religious consciousness, as rationalising and ethicising, is overlooked. The unconscious power is misapprehended which *man's essence* exercises over *the individual*, in that the essence, working as a unity, governs what is individually irrational and egoistic. But since this working of the *a priori* is overlooked, there is a one-sided accentuation not merely of the irrational but also of the *egoistic* in the religions. Therefore neither does the moment of religious self-surrender receive its proper significance. F. is not blind to this moment's presence in the religious mind, which demands a disinterested, self-surrendering love: *diligere Deum propter Deum et non propter se ipsum* (St. Bernhard). But just as the rational "metaphysical" determinations of the divine were only the "outermost points of attachment", not the proper, specifically religious determinations, so self-surrendering love is to designate only the moment of highest religious enthusiasm, which is at once succeeded by that

relation in which the subject, as separating itself from the divine object, relates itself to itself as an object for God, and therefore indirectly egoistically. And even where the self negates itself in self-surrender, it is to do so only because it has in God the enjoyment of a personality freed from all barriers; because God is the human heart's highest self-feeling and feeling of pleasure<sup>\*)</sup>.

This one-sided singling out of a single side in the religious relation is strengthened in F. by this, that precisely through the accentuation of personality's determination of form, in separation from its content, the *one-sided separation between the divine and the human* gains the preponderance over that *equilibrium* between unity and separation — or rather, over that *preponderance* of unity over separation — which was originally laid down by the determination of the *specifically religious* predicates of the divine. And it is strengthened likewise by this, that the *difference of degree in the clarity and distinctness of the content of consciousness* which takes place in the course of the religious consciousness's development is as little sufficiently brought out as *the relation between the moments of the religious process of consciousness* is correctly apprehended. The *mystical* element in the life of faith does not come into its right in F.'s apprehension. But precisely upon this mystical element — conditioned by the fact that in the unity of the religious relation of life the moments of the relation of consciousness *do not step sharply* apart from one another — rests the immediate religious consciousness's feeling of unity with the divine: the possibility it possesses of a self-surrender of enthusiasm, of a finding of itself again according to its essential determination in the divine. *It is unavoidable that reflection*, the source of separation, should make itself felt in the religious domain. Where human thinking, freeing itself from the religious, develops beyond the determinate religious standpoint and reacts back upon it, or where the human spirit, in the domain of the religious itself, begins by a spontaneous development of thought to loosen itself from the earlier standpoint, reflection cannot fail to make itself felt; but it is only where reflection acquires an *essential* significance in the domain of the religious, and where it seeks to maintain religion's truth *in opposition to thinking's*, that *the moment of separation* gains preponderance in the religious consciousness, and that the consequences F. draws acquire their validity.

With the one-sided bringing out of the separation there hangs together finally that defect in F., that *the relation of opposition between the religious and the ethical is one-sidedly brought out*, while the unity which the mystical element in religion grounds is one-sidedly pushed aside. —

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<sup>\*)</sup>Cf. with this F.'s apprehension of sacrifice: above, p. 115.



Through this indication of what I regard as the defects in Feuerbach's apprehension of *the positively religious*, its difference from mine will have become sufficiently plain, and from the developments of concepts given in the foregoing an essential difference in our whole fundamental view will emerge.

The difference appears at once in the determination of the *fundamental concept*. For me it becomes the concept of the ideally-real Absolute as that principle of unity which grounds existence in relative independence; for Feuerbach it becomes, where his peculiar standpoint is *fully* developed, the individuals, the single sensible things and beings — while the divine becomes only a mirroring of subjective craving, and the universal only a subjectively indispensable expression for the aggregate of the individual, and as such without real validity.

From this difference in the fundamental concept there follows as a consequence that, whereas at the standpoint I have indicated the conditions will be present for maintaining the possibility of *freedom in the human*, for maintaining a *cognition and an acting* which bears the stamp of the *universally valid* — and therefore a true scientific cognition and a true ethical acting — and finally for maintaining a *religious relation* to the through-working Absolute, in such a way that this relation is everywhere in harmonious unity with the relation to man: with Feuerbach, on the contrary, the successive development of his fundamental view into individualism and sensualism must lead to this, that not merely is a religious relation to an absolute made impossible, but that the very foundation of the universal is annihilated upon which a true scientific cognition must rest — and that even, through the annihilation of freedom's possibility and of the concept of an ideal for action, the ethical itself must be undermined — the very thing for whose benefit the religious was to be sacrificed.

When F. retains the expressions *religion and religious*, it is only in an *improper* sense, as a designation for that to which man relates himself as to something highest, and which also acquires practical significance for him. They do not designate for him what they designate for me: an absolute relation to the Absolute, a relation which is through this Absolute and in which man relates himself to it with what is of his own essence, but at the same time to that higher principle which grounds the human being and with it the whole of existence, and gathers it together in its eternal unity. For me, therefore, "man's self-cognition" in religion becomes a self-cognition *by and through his essence's ground*, his absolute ideal.

**The Hegelian Philosophy.** — This philosophy's apprehension of *the task of life* follows with necessity from its apprehension of *the idea*. Since the idea, as the highest

expression of “pure thought”, comprehends within itself all

existence, is *a unity of thought and being*, then *the idea’s eternal process* — in which nature and the finite spirits, whose independence is only a semblance, are eternally taken up as abolished moments — comprehends *all* actuality and *all* truth; all true existence is reduced to eternity’s element; and what falls outside this in the forms of time and space is the *merely untrue*, which *with eternal necessity* is abolished in the Absolute. Therefore human life’s forms of nature and its natural content too become merely something unwarranted and untrue; spirit’s one absolutely true being becomes *thought’s individuality-less, contemplative life in eternity’s element*, in which spirit knows the Absolute *as the sole existent in its eternal process*, and knows *itself as a moment in this Absolute*, in whose knowing of itself man’s knowing of the Absolute, and of himself in the Absolute, is taken up. Over against the view of the eternal metaphysical process — which is not a striving towards a goal but an eternal existent’s self-affirmation, in whose necessity therefore every opposition is eternally *abolished* — the problems of actuality belonging to personality lose their significance and their sharpness: the problem of the finite spirit’s freedom of will; of the free will’s realisation of the being as naturally-spiritual; of the human spirit’s relation to time, within which it relates itself to a task of eternity, to the ethical-religious; of its self-determination towards that task’s solution; of its failure of the task; of its guilt and its reconciliation of guilt. Over against the necessity of the *eternal and eternally completed* process, *finitude’s* movement — even where it concludes in *evil* — becomes only a jest, eternally taken back into the Absolute’s process, in which all the seriousness falls away. Through *the thought of the Absolute* the individual can take itself out of finitude’s contradictions, and in the individuality-less contemplative unity with the Absolute it has *the absolution* for all imperfection and *the reconciliation* with its ground of essence. In nature-determined existence one is to live in the abstraction of pure spirituality; in finite existence one is to live only in eternity’s element, so that time is in time to be taken back into eternity, so that the temporal relation acquires no significance as actuality, does not become a moment in the ethical-religious resolution to action and self-surrender. *Thought is action*; and to *comprehend* the Absolute is *the absolute action*. Life becomes an illusion of spirituality, *ethics* is transformed into abstract *metaphysics*, *religion* into a *comprehending of the idea*.

*The difference* between this apprehension of the task of life and the one indicated above is determined by the difference *in the fundamental concept*. The apprehension developed earlier of the Absolute’s *essential* relation to the determinations of *reality*, of the *essentially valid* real’s *essential forms of being*, leads with necessity, on the one

side, to maintaining the *nature-determined* finite spirit's *relative independence*, and on the other side to laying a decisive emphasis upon *the conditions of reality's* significance for ethical acting, and generally for the determination of the human task of life. This difference will appear in its concrete form through the following developments of central ethical-religious problems. —

From the critical comparisons we now pass over to these developments, in which essential determinations of concepts that have been anticipated in the foregoing are to find their justification, and what has only been indicated is to acquire its more concrete determinateness. From the nature of the case the problem of *the will's freedom* is that whose solution must first be attempted.

## 1. On the Freedom of the Will.

The problem of the will's freedom leads us into the domain of metaphysics, of physics, of psychology and of ethics, but must find its definitive solution in the last.

The concepts which give the first, *abstract points of attachment* for the determination of freedom are the concept of *being as activity* and the concept *selfhood*. In the concept of being itself the determination of activity lies enclosed, since all being asserts itself as being, preserves its being, only by activity, and without this determination of activity would immediately sink back into not-being. But this activity, which is inseparable from being, expresses being's *peculiarity*; through it, therefore, every being makes itself felt *according to its determinateness*, and posits in the reciprocal action something proceeding from its own essence, expressing its own essence.

In this determination of a peculiar *expression* of essential activity we have the first intimation of freedom; but a step nearer to the concept of freedom we come through the concept *selfhood*, subjectivity. The concept of selfhood expresses a being-for-itself through its other; selfhood, as the expression of the *ideal*, is, according to the relation of the concepts, what determines in relation to otherness and what converts every determinateness by an other into self-determinateness. But the concept of selfhood too still affords only *abstract* points of attachment for the concept of *the will's freedom*; it is not sufficient as a foundation for that concept, nor for maintaining the finite existent's freedom in relation to the infinite and Absolute. Selfhood is the fundamental determination for *all* that is organic, for *all* that is living, and therefore also for plant life and animal life. But even animal life's highest, most developed forms come under the determination of instinct: that abstract, metaphysical determination of freedom which lies in selfhood

therefore becomes, in real actuality, in the existence of the single animal life, enclosed and hidden by necessity. The finite selfhood's relation to the real which is not posited by this self, and does not belong to its essence, is not immediately determined by the universal metaphysical relation between selfhood and otherness. And what metaphysics lays down with respect to this relation — which is apprehended rather as a relation between the fundamental moments in the absolute principle and in the *total* existence determined by the principle — can still less immediately secure the finite, individual selfhood in its relation to the absolute subjectivity.

Through the points of attachment indicated there are thus reached indeed moments in the concept of freedom, but not the concrete determination of freedom as *the will's freedom*, nor a maintaining of this concept's reality. In order that a securer foundation may be found for the determination of the human will's freedom, a new determination must come to the concept of selfhood, namely the determination of *essential universality*. In this determination lies, as shown earlier, the determination of *inner infinity*, and thereby the possibility of *a being-for-itself in the form of self-consciousness and of comprehending cognition*. The working of the selfhood-energy becomes, with essential universality for its presupposition, a *conscious* working — which is the condition of its being able to be a working of *will*; and since it is the expression of the energy in a being with *inner infinity*, there shows itself a possibility that it can be a *free will's* self-determining.

Freedom would then express, more closely, that the human spirit, in its working through the will which expresses the being's infinity, takes the initiative for the will with consciousness *within itself*, and gives the will its content out of *itself*. What held generally of every existent — that as existing it must be active out of its being's peculiarity — would then here take the form that spirit, in virtue of its inner infinity, posits its content of will in its self-determining, and, where the self-determination was the true one, gave the will a content which expressed the self according to its truth, i.e. according to its essence, and therefore an essentially valid, reason-determined content. In this determinateness the will was then essence-willing, i.e. self-determining out of its universal essence. But this essence, which is seen as self-determining in its willing and as having itself for the content of its self-determination, is according to its primitive conceptual determinateness the self-conscious and cognising essence: in that true form of self-determination there must therefore be a unity of the fundamental determination of the theoretical and of the practical spirit, and freedom thus became the highest expression of the human being according to its totality, became this total being's true form of actuality, the *τέλος* of cognition and of will.

In the determinations given, what conditions the possibility of freedom of will has been indicated, and freedom's relation to the being intimated. But when the human being and the human will are seen not merely according to the universal concept of the being as it were in isolation, and according to the will's fundamental relation to the being, but are considered under the conditions of reality and in actuality's concrete connection, there arises a doubt whether what showed itself as a possibility under abstraction from the concrete can be maintained as valid under actuality's real conditions. Only when this doubt is removed does the developed concept of freedom acquire more than a merely hypothetical validity.

What awakens doubt about freedom's actuality is on the one side the individual's relation to *the Absolute*, on the other its relation to *the real conditions of existence*. The first of these relations will receive its proper elucidation through the treatment of the problem of evil's possibility; the second is here to be treated from the various standpoints from which it shows itself.

The individual's relation to its conditions of existence is namely to be seen partly under the standpoint of a relation to *the outer*, partly under the standpoint of a relation to *the conditions of development*. Under the determination of *the relation to the outer* we gather together: the individual's relation to *the outer real*, into whose causal connection it is ordered; the relation to *the outer within the individual itself*, i.e. to its *determinateness by nature*; and the relation to *other individuals*.

*The first* relation — the relation to *the real's causal connection* — has been accentuated above all as a ground of doubt against freedom's actuality, and not merely from materialistic systems, for which the human will becomes only a member in the mechanically connected infinite series of material causes and effects, but also from such systems as separate a sphere of the noumenon from that of the phenomenon and concede an intelligible freedom, but urge that man, as phenomenon in time and space, is unconditionally subject to the necessity of the law of causality, and therefore in his willing is with necessity determined by an *outer motive*. Although it is not here overlooked that the presupposition upon which the necessity of all causes' effects rests is each thing's inner essence, and although there is talk of *inner* incitements (in the organism) and of an *inner* prompting (in animals, through instinct), it is nevertheless held fast — since the intelligible act of freedom is to have posited that fundamental will which constitutes the essence, as an original, *unchangeable* unity — that *every* motive to a movement of will, to a determinate act of will, that the whole "matter of the will", is to be given by *the outer world*. The abstract, merely thought motive too is to be just as fully an outer cause

determining the will as the intuitable one, which consists in a really present object; in the last instance it is nevertheless always to be something real, something material, in so far as it always rests upon an *outer* impression received at some time and in some manner — and to this is reckoned also transmission through word and writing from the remotest times (Schopenhauer). For this conception it then becomes just as impossible as for materialism to think the human will's freedom; in that freedom, as a capacity for an *absolute beginning*, it can see only what would constitute a conflict with the universal world-order.

Now as regards this so strongly accentuated ground of doubt, it must at once be pointed out that that mechanical conception of nature's connection — which acquires its validity also within the form of idealism characterised — suffers from the unavoidable defect that a *primitive* mover, a *definitive* originator of the movement given *as a fact*, cannot be found without an inconsistency. *If all movement is only movement communicated from outside, then that means that it is nowhere originally present*: an infinite increase of the members becomes only a tautological repetition of the same relation, and *it becomes a contradiction to acknowledge movement, activity, as factual*, since it can have no ground in the material and none outside it; for that which was thought as standing outside the series of material causes would, as essentially opposed to the material, be unable to exercise an effect upon it. If movement, activity, in nature is to be explained — indeed even merely acknowledged as factual — it becomes unavoidably necessary to go back to the concept of a *totality-activity*, and then to see the effect of the totality as resulting from the working of the *totality's* members, since the very concept of a *totality's* working points to *relatively independent individual centres of activity*. When, then, the concept of an *active totality of nature* has stepped into the place of the concept of a *mechanical connection of nature*, then the relation indicated above between the self-less and the self — more closely, the self-conscious self — is to be accentuated, as is also the concept of the human self's centralisation in itself as a relative totality with inner infinity and therefore with a peculiar centre for conscious activity. The concept which for mechanism showed itself immediately as an absurdity — the concept of a *primitive beginning* — must *necessarily* come forward when the individual being which has inner infinity concentrates, centralises itself in itself as a relative totality, and thereby, as taking possession of itself, in its constituting of itself posits a new point of beginning, a peculiar relative centre in existence's total organisation. How this working of the relative totality is to be apprehended in relation to the *absolute* principle will be elucidated in what follows.

In the self's essence, in its ideal doubling, in its character as energy, lies the possibility of a self-determining whose motive falls *within* the self, in its concrete content of essence; in the relation between the self which according to its foundation is *eternal* and its unfolding in a *development in time* lies the possibility that a determining which from the phenomenon's side appears as a temporally determined *change*, and which was therefore asserted to have to be effected by something *outer*, can proceed from the self's eternal ground. And since the self exists as ordered into a totality of existence, and at every moment receives influences from *the outer*, this relation too does not abolish, for the self-conscious self, the possibility of a free self-determining.

For with respect to the influences from *the outer real* — which, as influences upon the will, do not become mechanically working causes but *motives* — there lies in the first place in the human being's *universality the possibility of abstracting from the determinate motive*. In virtue of abstraction's inner infinity freedom's possibility is preserved, even though for the present only in *the form of negativity*, as a free not-willing of what presses in from outside; and this freedom in the form of negativity has as its outermost limit a free surrender of individual existence in order to maintain freedom. But that uni

versality of the being — which through the capacity for infinite abstraction grounded freedom's possibility in the form of negativity — encloses at the same time a *positive* determination of freedom. When the outer motive's determining is warded off by the will, this happens in virtue of *inner motives, i.e. motives proceeding from the being*, which form the foundation for abstraction's act; and what determines in the act of will therefore becomes a determination in *the self's essence*. The will is thus determined by what belongs to that essence which the will *itself* expresses; and since the essence becomes transparent to consciousness in this determining, the *inner necessity of essence transforms itself into conscious freedom*. Finally it lies in the being's *universality* that the *outer motive*, where an *essential unity* takes place, *can be transformed into an inner one, i.e. converted into a moment in the determination of essence*. Throughout, then, it is held fast *that the act of will results with necessity from motive and will*; but since the motive becomes an *inner* one, freedom is maintained — not in the sense of a groundless and therefore meaningless *liberum arbitrium*, but in the sense of the true, essence-determined freedom, that freedom through which the will, in being determined by motives proceeding from the being, shows itself as an expression of essence, in unity with the essence.

In the foregoing regard has been had to the will's free *resolution, to free acting in the inner, to freedom's inner realisation*. As regards the free will's *outer realisation*, this is — when it is seen only *in relation to the individual will* — to be determined as something

essentially independent of the resolution of freedom. The relation shows itself otherwise when the relation between the will and its execution in the outer, when the free ethical acting's relation to the course and order of nature and of history, is seen as mediated by the *universal* — not as an ordering third standing outside (Kant), but as the immanent harmonising principle<sup>\*)</sup>.

When the free acts of will which proceed from the primitive centres of activity step out into outer action, the action comes *as phenomenon under the necessity of the law of causality*, and from the co-operation of the free acts of will there results in the historical *the necessity of universal action*. Here a *conversion of activities* takes place, like that which takes place among the activities of nature among themselves; and under this conversion the activity's goal is preserved unchanged.

In the foregoing the will's *relation to the outer* has been seen as the relation to the real existing *outside the individual*: the single real and the totality of the real. It is now to be seen as a *relation to the outer within the individual itself, i.e. to the individual's side of nature*. Setting aside what will be treated under the standpoint of the individual's *relation to its conditions of development*, there are here to be considered the relation to *the influences from the untransparent natural element in the individual*, and the relation to those *hindrances to freedom* which may lie in original determinatenesses of nature: endowment, temperament and the like. As regards those influences — which hang together with the abiding separation between *the conscious* and *the unconscious in the individual's life*, and which may be designated as *promptings of drive*, if we take the concept *drive in a wide sense* — the concept of *essential unity* and of *the totality of essence* becomes with respect to them decisive for freedom's maintenance. Since what proceeds from *the unconscious* proceeds from the *same* undivided essence as what comes forward in *the life of consciousness*, the necessity lying therein becomes — so far as we do not reflect upon the determinateness possibly working through it from outside — an *inner necessity of essence*, and therefore a *free necessity*. And when the determination of *the totality of essence* and of *essential universality* is then more closely brought to bear, what proceeds from the individual's side of nature is seen as taken up, through the organic relative *totality, into the spiritual being's unity of life*, as gathered together in that being's ideal concentration; and the inner necessity of essence is clarified into the *spiritual being's inner necessity of essence*, i.e. into essence-determined freedom. Over against

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<sup>\*)</sup>The question how far the free will's non-realisation in the outer, as hanging together with a culpable defect of cognition, can become an object of ethical responsibility also from the standpoint that such non-realisation may react upon freedom's *inner* realisation and hinder the development of freedom, falls outside the present investigation.



the single determinateness, *the totality of essence* and *spontaneity* then make themselves felt, and the consciousness of the totality preserves its significance even when it appears in the form of abstraction.

As regards what lies as *hindrances to freedom* in the individual endowments, in the temperament and the like — which as something determined by nature, something given by nature, goes *before* the individual's conscious life of spirit and is presupposed by it — there is, in relation to these individual differences, however strongly they may appear, the human being's *abiding universality* to be held fast, and thereby the validity of the universally human for *every* human individual, in spite of the intensity of the differences. But with the *fundamentally human* there is given that *ideal relation to itself* which is freedom's fundamental determination; and this relation, which is the human individuality's ideal *prius*, is realised for consciousness in the ideal concentration (see below, pp. 139 f.), in which the individual constitutes itself as personality.

What holds of the natural differences in the individual generally holds also of that peculiar form of them which comes forward in the *abnormal physical* and *psychical* states. In the individual's relation to these states, which hinder the will, there lies partly a relation to the outer within the individual itself, partly a relation to the real outside the individual, in so far as a disharmonious influence of this real upon the organism conditions those states. With respect to these states the standpoint is to be brought to bear that the continued existing, in spite of these states, of the human individual endowed for a life of spirit and of freedom involves the possibility of a liberation — a possibility therefore present *so long as the individual exists as an individual of this kind*, as a *human* individual. —

When finally the individual's relation to the outer is seen as a relation to *the other individuals* as acting, to the effects of the other self-determining wills, then this relation comes on one side immediately under the same standpoint as the individual's relation to the influences of the outer real; on another side there shows itself a *nuance in the relation*, in that the other individual has, not merely through the unconscious power of likeness of essence but through its cognition, the possibility of an influence embracing the will far more firmly than the outer real has. But the difference becomes nevertheless *only a difference of degree*, which does not alter the fundamental relation in what is essential.

On the other hand, in the individuals' mutual relation the *supplementary relation of unity* between them acquires an essential significance for freedom's realisation in the individual — which will be more closely elucidated in what follows, under the development of the problem of reconciliation. The supplementary relation of reciprocal

action between the individuals — in which, as in the realisation of self-consciousness, the relation to the other I *as the species' representative* acquires its significance — will be shown as the condition for freedom's realisation in the individual: a realisation which takes place in the *ethical* relation to those spiritual individualities by which the individual is integrated, and which points back to a *presupposing of freedom by itself*, and finally to its last ground in that which gathers together the mutually integrating individualities in spirit's unity: to its ground *in the absolute principle*.

When freedom's significance as actuality has thus shown itself to be preserved under the relation to the outer, it is now, according to what was indicated above, to be maintained *in the relation to the conditions of development*. With respect to this relation a twofold standpoint makes itself felt, which leads to a twofold aporia. For since freedom — in the pregnant sense as *spirit's freedom* — cannot be immediately given to the nature-determined individual, but must be *acquired by the individual*, and therefore acquire a *becoming* through the individual's development in time, the difficulty shows itself first when this becoming is reflected upon. According to spirit's concept freedom must be posited as that which is to become, because it is to be acquired; but since it can be only as *self-acquired*, and therefore *must be through itself*, and therefore *must presuppose itself*, this seems to exclude a becoming, since such a becoming, as freedom's becoming, would presuppose *unfreedom* as that out of which freedom was to become. And the difficulty shows itself *secondly* when the human spirit's development in time is seen *as an approximation to the being's ideal* — when therefore freedom, as the expression and the realisation of man's true essence, is seen under the standpoint of *the ideal*, as an object of an *approximation*; for freedom then acquires the stamp of that which is realised *only approximately*, and which never in the full sense acquires actuality — which, if only the full and comprehensive realisation of freedom rightly bears freedom's name, would be one with *freedom's acquiring no actuality at all*. This difficulty lying in the approximation appears in a more determinate form when it is reflected that the realisation of freedom of will has *cognition* for its essential condition, and therefore shows itself as conditioned in its perfection by cognition's perfection — which, when cognition is taken in its most concrete sense, is only approximately attainable; so that freedom, on the presupposition indicated above, would never acquire the complete condition for its realisation.

As regards the difficulty which lies in *freedom's presupposing of itself*, its solution is to be sought above all in a concept which hovered before Kant when he developed his doctrine of the timeless *intelligible act of freedom* — but which with him, in virtue of his abstract separation of the sphere of the noumenon from that of the phenomenon,

received an almost mythical clothing: namely in the concept of *the spiritual individual's concentration of the whole of its development in an ideal point*, which abolishes the development's temporal externality and necessity. This means, in other words: the solution is to be sought in the concept of *a breaking through*, in which *the eternal* — which in the individual self has covertly determined that self's development — joins itself together in its unity as the presupposition of its own being. And this moment of concentration coincides with *the moment of the ethical choice*, in which freedom, through the breaking through of the eternal, first acquires true actuality. But beside this decisive concept there acquires — as was already indicated above — the single human individual's relation *to the supplementary personalities and to the divine*<sup>\*)</sup> its essential significance for the aporia's solution.

The solution of the difficulty which lies in *what is approximative in freedom's realisation* must be sought through this, that *a twofold* standpoint is brought to bear for the apprehension of freedom, in that freedom is seen at one and the same time *as task and as existing as an essential determination*. That freedom is seen from this twofold standpoint is grounded in its essence, and generally in the essence of the ideal. Since freedom, like everything ideal, is *existing through itself*, it is only as *constantly self-produced*. In the highest relation too it holds of the divine actuality that it, as living, ideal actuality, is an eternally self-producing actuality, at one and the same time existing and τέλος for a working.

But in the relation of human freedom there comes in that determination in which the difficulty lies: that the self-production is a *temporally determined* self-development. When freedom therefore becomes a task for itself, it must as task become something fuller than it was as presupposition; and since freedom is a determination of *eternity*, and since it is *an ideal* not merely for *the individual* but for *humanity*, there shows itself *an infinite possibility of development*. But when this has been laid down, then it is on the one side to be held fast that the presupposition is nevertheless *in its essence* equal to the task — that therefore the will which is still realising its freedom *is in principle free*, in spite of its relative abstraction — and on the other side the standpoint indicated above is to be held fast, that the free will at every moment of realisation joins its own past together in an *ideal point of unity*, and thus takes the development in time ideally

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<sup>\*)</sup>Just as to that concept of a concentration of the development in a point of eternity there is a parallel in *Aristotle*, in the apprehension of form (εἶδος) as that which, at the goal of the development which it itself determines, can be said only to *be*, not to *have become*, so there is in him a parallel to the thought of freedom's realisation through the relation to the supplementary individualities and to the principle, in the determination that the moral's realisation in the individual presupposes an *already occurring actual being of the moral*, just as all becoming generally presupposes something actually existent. That determination makes itself felt in his well-known apprehension of *the state's* significance for *individual* morality.

*back into a moment of eternity*, in order, in the last instance, to concentrate itself in ideal eternal unity, as an organic moment in the all-comprehending, to concentrate itself into the “willing of one thing”, understood in eternity’s sense. Thus what characterises the ideal is seen at every point of the development.

When it is therefore conceded that freedom’s realisation, since it must take place through a development towards an ideal which is not merely an individual but a universally human one, must in virtue of this determinateness of the ideal be subject to an infinite approximation, then at the same time — since the relation to the ideal is the relation to the will’s τέλος — what is at work in the development, its entelechy, becomes *the ideal itself as an energy of development*, i.e. as the will’s actual determination of essence<sup>\*)</sup>.

Herein lies, then, that degrees *in freedom* are indeed laid down; but in the sense that freedom, in constituting itself, unfolds itself *as freedom* from the relatively more abstract form to the more concrete one; and this is again to be determined more closely thus, that it unfolds itself from the *abstract willing*

*of the being* — a willing which is only as *ethical* willing — into a *concrete essence-willing*, into a conscious, resolved willing of the being according to its full content. This gradual development, through which the *principle* of freedom revealed *in the resolution* (in the choice) wins concretion, is at the same time a development *in intensity*, since freedom’s energy increases in the same proportion as the will becomes the expression of the concrete essence’s energy, of the essence clear to itself, of the essence conscious of itself in its fullness.

This leads us back to the difficulty specially brought out above, which lay in this, that freedom presupposed as its condition a *cognition* subject to constant development, since only through cognition is the possibility given of the essence’s clarity to itself. Here reference must be made to the relation between the *a priori* cognition, which encloses the a priori element in the ethical, and the *empirical* one. The a priori cognition has in its *relative abstraction a completedness in itself*, and by its relation to man’s *essence a real validity*; and it is therefore such a cognition as a *free* willing can rest upon. When I, with consciousness of the good’s validity, of duty’s demand, will the good, will duty, then my willing — as determined by the a priori, and therefore by my own ideal essence’s determinations, as a conscious willing of what is essentially valid — is a *free* willing; and this free, essentially valid willing acquires its filling out, limited by no immovable barrier, through that cognition which, resting upon the a priori and having in it the abstract

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<sup>\*)</sup>Cf. for the rest what will be developed in what follows, 3, c, on the ideal’s realisation.

essence of the self and of the real, penetrates into the empirically given real — here therefore above all into the real within ourselves, into our own essence's determinations of reality and relations of reality — as an assimilating cognition. In the course of this development of cognition, then, that cognition is present *at every point* which makes the will free, even where the will relates itself to the concrete that is not cognised.

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Since in the foregoing freedom's reality was maintained against the doubt which rested upon the individual's relation to the outer, the decisive concept was the concept of the human individual's concentration in itself as a relative totality, determined by essential universality, with inner infinity; and this concept acquired its essential significance in the developments that followed as well. Through that concept of self-concentration the unfreedom in the relation to the outer was abolished, and converted into self-determination out of the whole of essence, in which the ideal totality of spirit is in unity with the organic totality. But since now the individual, in this joining together in its relative totality, is seen as determining itself by freedom, the working of *the individual* which expresses this self-determining is at the same time to be seen as ordered *into the absolute totality*. This holds whether freedom is apprehended according to its untrue or according to its *true* form. If freedom is only the *formal* freedom, *arbitrariness*, the abstract expression of inner infinity, the *semblance* of essence-determined freedom, the apparently groundless determining, then there are precisely here determinate, finite, though not clearly conscious motives present, which have connection with the real's totality and draw the will's working into it. If freedom on the contrary is the *true, essential* freedom, so that its "absolute beginning" has an essence-determined, substantial content, then there is, in a timeless relation, a connection with the totality of existence and its eternal principle — a determining which goes in unity with that principle's eternal determining.

Man's relation of freedom to the outer thus points back, through the concept of totality, to *the relation to the Absolute*. And it is only by this relation that the individual being — which as free is for itself in the form of infinity, in which the principle's being reflects itself within it — can have the possibility of withdrawing itself from the dominion of outer causal necessity, yet in such a way that at the same time, by its very positing of an absolute beginning, it is ordered into the principle-determined totality and subjected to that totality's dialectic. For when the Absolute is the human spirit's principle, then man's freedom is to be seen *as grounded in it*, the only thing which *in an absolute sense is free*; and *freedom in its truth* can then be only one with the *free absolute surrender* to

the Absolute as the power that works through all. But when freedom as *man's* freedom is then to be seen as *derived*, and yet is to be maintained as freedom; when it is to be seen as being through the Absolute, while at the same moment, in expressing man's relative independence, it shows itself to enclose the possibility of separating itself from the Absolute — then there appear, through the relation to the principle, new grounds of doubt against freedom.

When these grounds of doubt are to be examined, they lead us into the investigation of the other problems brought out above. The problem of *derived freedom*, and of its *twofold* form of actuality — as asserting itself in *self-will*, and as independently joining itself together with the principle in *self-surrender* — coincides essentially with the problems of *evil's possibility and of evil's abolition in reconciliation*.

The problem of human freedom therefore leads us, when the new grounds of doubt are to be removed, once more into the domain of the ethical-religious, to which we were referred above where the individual's self-concentration showed itself as identical with the breaking through of the eternal in that choice by which the ethical was constituted in the individual. We therefore point back at this point to the earlier — anticipatory and therefore for the present only hypothetically valid — development of the ethical's essence, and particularly of the will's constituting of itself as ethical will in the ethical choice, in which that breaking through takes place, in which freedom gives itself actuality and, in giving itself actuality, presupposes itself as an essential determination and posits itself as an infinite task.

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## 2. On the Essence and Possibility of Evil.

The concept of *evil* must, as the concept of something *negative*, be made plain through the concept of the *positive* which it negates. The concept of *the good*, as the concept of this positive opposite, must therefore form the starting point for the apprehension of evil.

The concept of *the good* has already been touched upon in the foregoing (p. 76) in the development of the Absolute's idea. When the Absolute was determined as existence's principle, it was determined as that which posits real being as determined by the ideal; and it was at the same time seen as the *teleologically* working, and in this working as its own end, as the goal for its subjectively-ideal activity, and as comprehending and governing, in its eternal process of self-realisation, the totality of the real moments. In

these determinations of the Absolute lay the point of attachment for the apprehension of the Absolute as *the good* (the idea of the good) — a concept which developed from the more abstractly metaphysical towards the metaphysical-ethical.

In opposition to the *good in its metaphysical* determinateness, evil becomes the *metaphysically evil*. If now the good in this determinateness expressed *the idea*, the *Absolute, as its own end, as the goal* for its *eternal* process of realisation, then *evil* — since the idea's process encloses all being, and evil can therefore express only something falling within this process — can, in that it must be something standing in opposition to the goal, acquire only the general determination of being *the moment in its isolation*: which as such, in opposition to the absolutely existent, becomes something merely *relative*, something determined by *negation* (determination), which fixes





## **Conclusion.**



## **Errata:**